DEBIUTY STUDENCKIE

2026

NEW TRENDS IN BUSINESS MANAGEMENT

Culture, Strategy, Engagement

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Joanna Radomska
and Anna Witek-Crabb

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Wrocław 2026

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The book cover uses images from 123rf

ISBN 978-83-68699-34-0 (paper version)
ISBN 978-83-68699-35-7 (electronic version)

DOI: 10.15611/2026.35.7

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Foreword

In an increasingly complex and dynamic business environment, contemporary organisations face the challenge of aligning strategy, people, and market expectations. The studies collected in this volume explore a wide range of management and business challenges, from startup growth and marketing effectiveness to organisational culture, employee engagement, and strategy implementation. Despite their diversity, they share a common focus on the human, cultural, and strategic dimensions that shape organisational performance across industries and contexts. Together, they offer valuable insights into how organisations adapt, innovate, and respond to both internal and external pressures in a rapidly evolving global landscape.

Papers presented in Students' Debuts *New Trends in Business Management. Culture, Strategy, Engagement* examine the role of branding in startup development, managerial practices in strategy implementation, and innovative approaches to employee engagement such as gamification. One study examines how Airbnb leveraged branding as a strategic tool to evolve from a startup into a global company. Another paper analyses how managerial practices at various hierarchical levels influence strategy implementation within the Strategy-as-Practice framework. A separate study examines the impact of gamification on employee engagement during onboarding. Other papers further investigate intergenerational consumer behaviour patterns in emerging markets, particularly in the apparel industry, the impact of organisational culture on job satisfaction, and motivational dynamics within NGOs. Additionally, the contributions address key drivers of successful marketing strategies in the video game industry, the challenges and opportunities of multicultural teamwork, the application of agile project management in times of crisis, and the effectiveness of modern versus traditional internal auditing models in a medium-sized enterprise.

Taken together, these studies reveal that success in contemporary organisations is not driven solely by structures and strategies, but also by culture, communication, and attention to human factors. Flexibility and the ability to adapt to specific contexts emerge as key determinants of success.

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DOI: 10.15611/2026.35.7.01
JEL Classification: M31, M13, L26

The Role of Branding in the Success of Startups – Case of Airbnb

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Quote as: Dorosh, D. (2026). The Role of Branding in the Success of Startups – Case of Airbnb. In J. Radomska, & A. Witek-Crabb (Eds.), *New Trends in Business Management. Culture, Strategy, Engagement* (pp. 5-16). Publishing House of Wroclaw University of Economics and Business.

Abstract: There are more than 150 million startups worldwide, yet only about 10% achieve long-term success, while the majority fail due to financial, technological, and marketing challenges. Airbnb stands out as one of the most prominent examples of this successful minority, notable for its early focus on branding and community-building rather than revenue alone. The central question of this paper is: How did Airbnb use branding to grow from a startup into a multinational company between 2007 and 2024? The research adopts a qualitative descriptive single case study, with secondary data as the main source of analysis, including interviews, company press releases, and industry reports. The findings indicate that branding played a central role in Airbnb's evolution, shaping its actions and positioning across different stages of growth.

Keywords: branding, brand equity, startups, Aaker's Brand Equity Model

1. Introduction

Startups have become a global phenomenon, with many individuals seeking more independence, ownership, and the opportunity to be their own bosses. The rapid development of artificial intelligence and digital technologies has accelerated this trend, making tech startups particularly popular.

Beyond their growing visibility, startups are a cornerstone of modern economies. High-growth startups, often referred to as scale-ups, play a crucial role in European entrepreneurship by driving employment, industrial renewal, and sectoral productivity

(European Commission, 2025). Together with small businesses, they form the big part of the European economy: small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) – a category encompassing most startups, represent 99.8% of all EU businesses and contribute approximately 50-55% of total value added (European Commission, 2025). Their economic weight is further underscored by rising investment flows; for instance, venture capital funding for European startups reached nearly 1.2% of GDP across OECD countries in 2021 (OECD, n.d.). Recognising this, the EU has launched initiatives such as Startup Europe and the EU Startup & Scale-up Strategy, which aim to reduce regulatory barriers, expand financing opportunities, and foster innovation hubs, with the ambition of making Europe "the best place in the world to launch and grow" innovative companies (European Commission, 2025).

However, the promising outlook stands in contrast to a challenging reality: despite their economic importance and visibility, statistics consistently show that nine out of ten startups eventually fail. This high failure rate reflects the risks and uncertainties inherent in entrepreneurship, where limited financial resources, intense competition, and regulatory barriers make it hard to survive the early years (Kotashev, 2025). As a result, understanding the factors that separate the rare successes from the majority of failures has become a key focus of both scholars and practitioners. Recent studies emphasise that startup success is shaped by multiple factors rather than a single determinant. Innovation remains central: startups often drive technological and business breakthroughs, but excessive novelty without execution or market demand can undermine survival (McCarthy et al., 2023). Research highlights that achieving product-market fit is among the most decisive milestones, as many failed ventures never align their offerings with real customer needs (Bethlendi et al., 2025).

Branding and marketing are increasingly recognised as critical but unused tools for growth. Strong marketing capabilities, particularly the development of a recognisable brand image, directly improve performance and help attract both customers and investors (Bruce et al., 2025). Nevertheless, many early-stage startups neglect branding due to resource constraints, which reduces their competitiveness. Access to funding is another consistent determinant: sufficient capital enables startups to scale, while undercapitalization is one of the most common causes of failure (OECD, 2022). Team composition and human capital further play a decisive role. Studies find that founders with prior experience, diverse skills, and cohesive teams are significantly more likely to lead successful ventures (McCarthy et al., 2023). Beyond internal resources, external conditions such as networks, accelerators, and government support contribute to resilience and growth. Overall, the literature suggests that startup success depends on the alignment of internal capabilities, innovation, branding, funding, and team quality with external opportunities in the market and ecosystem (Argaw & Liu, 2024).

Although branding is extensively studied in established firms, research on branding in startups remains limited and relatively recent. Scholars note that startup founders often underestimate or postpone brand-building despite evidence that branding capabilities can significantly influence survival and growth (Pöhlmann et al., 2025). This underexplored area highlights the need for further research on how branding functions as a critical success factor in new ventures across sectors.

This study aims to examine the significance of branding in Airbnb's success in the hospitality sector. Accordingly, the guiding research question is: *How did Airbnb use branding to grow from a startup into a multinational company between 2007 and 2024?* In this paper, success is defined as the ability of a startup to grow from an early-stage venture into a globally operating company with sustained revenue and market presence. Since Airbnb is a unicorn and one of the most successful global startups, it provides a relevant case for analysis. Its journey from a small platform for renting air mattresses to a leading hospitality brand illustrates how branding can serve as a decisive factor in growth and survival.

This paper follows a standard research structure. It begins with the introduction and literature review, which outline key theories, followed by a methodology section explaining the research design and data sources. The results are then presented, and the paper concludes with key insights, limitations, and directions for future research.

2. Literature Review

The concept of a startup has been widely discussed and studied in various contexts. However, there is no universally accepted definition, as different academics and practitioners emphasise various aspects of what qualifies as a startup. The challenge in defining startups come from their diverse characteristics, including operational structure, business model, and market approach. As summarised in Tab. 1, Olek (2023) provides an overview of key definitions of startups proposed by various authors.

Table 1. Definitions of a startup

Author	Publication year	Definition
C. Christensen	2000	Organizations that create breakthrough innovations, i.e. those that change market paradigms in the long run by implementing the strategy and business model management in startups, were identified and classified.
A. Damoradan	2009	A young company that is most often loss-making in the early stages of its existence.
E. Ries	2011	A human institutions created to build new products or services under conditions of extreme uncertainty.
S. Blank	2012	A temporary organization looking for a scalable, repeatable, and profitable business model.
P. Criscuolo et al.	2012	A company existing for less than five years.

Author	Publication year	Definition
PwC	2015	A high-growth enterprise
A. Skala	2018	At the beginning of its existence, an organization has limited resources. It operated in uncertain or non-existent demand for products or services in the area of new technologies that it wants to introduce to the market. Such an organization is looking for an innovative business model that will allow hyper-scalability of sales.
Forbes	2021	Young companies founded to create a unique products or services belong to new technologies that change market paradigms.

Source: (Olek, 2023, p. 3747).

2.1. Main Features of the Startup

When discussing the main features of startups, four are most often highlighted: innovation, scalability, evolvability, and uncertainty. Innovation is central, as startups are created to build new solutions (Ries, 2011). Scalability often stems from technology that enables rapid and cost-efficient growth (Webstarted, 2024). Startups are also dynamic and adaptable, evolving in response to market changes – a critical ability for long-term survival (Ries, 2011). Finally, they operate under extreme uncertainty, facing high risks in market demand and business viability (Valluri, 2024). Together, these traits shape strategic decisions, resource allocation, and growth trajectories, while also influencing how startups progress through their typical development phases, from ideation to exit, each marked by unique opportunities and challenges.

2.2. The Development Stages of Startups

The journey of a startup typically unfolds in several stages, beginning with Ideation, where entrepreneurs identify problems, explore opportunities, and assess market potential (Passaro et al., 2026). This is followed by the Pre-Seed Stage, focused on refining ideas, validating concepts, and developing prototypes, often financed through personal resources or family support. Next is the Seed Stage, where the business model is validated, a minimum viable product (MVP) developed, and early customers acquired, often with help from accelerators and incubators (Salamzadeh & Kawamorita Kesim, 2015). Upon validation, startups enter the Growth Stage, characterised by scaling operations, refining products, and expanding sales and marketing to strengthen market presence (Schuh et al., 2022). Success here leads to the Expansion Stage, involving entry into international markets and diversification of offerings, often supported by larger funding rounds and partnerships with established firms. Finally, many ventures reach the Exit Stage, where founders and investors realize value through acquisition, merger, or IPO, marking a transition rather than an end of journey (Venturz, n.d.) Although these stages represent a typical progression, the path is rarely smooth. Each phase introduces unique challenges that can threaten survival, requiring adaptability and strategic decision-making.

2.3. Definition of Brand and Branding

The term '*brand'* originates from the Old Norse word *brandr*, meaning 'to burn', referring to marks used to identify livestock (Keller, 2008 as cited in OpenLearn, n.d.).While originally a simple identifier, the modern brand extends far beyond a symbol: it represents perceptions, emotions, and trust. The American Marketing Association defines a brand as a name, term, or design that identifies and differentiates goods or services (AMA, 1960, as cited in Maurya & Mishra, 2012). More recent perspectives emphasise feelings and associations created through customer interaction (Jones, as cited in Beulah, 2015) and the promise of consistent quality (Kenton, as cited in Okereafor et al., 2023). Data highlight its importance: 77% of consumers buy because of brand name, and 82% of investors prioritize brand recognition (Forbes, 2021, as cited in Okereafor et al., 2023).

Branding, in turn, is the strategic process of shaping and sustaining this identity. It goes beyond visual design to include messaging, values, and long-term strategies that build recognition, trust, and differentiation (Okereafor et al., 2023). Its scope extends from visual identity to product innovation, marketing communications, and customer experience, all of which contribute to building strong brand equity. Today, it is recognized not only as a tool for differentiation but also as a driver of customer loyalty, investor confidence, and long-term business value.

2.4. Brand Elements and Models

A strong brand begins with identity—the image a company wants to project and the associations it hopes to build, such as brand-as-product, person, or organisation (Aaker, 2012, as cited in Masterson & Pickton, 2017). Yet identity is only half the picture. What truly matters is the brand image, or how people actually perceive the company. As Aaker (1993, as cited in Williams, 2021) notes, this perception is shaped by associations of attributes and benefits and may not always align with the intended identity, creating what he calls the "brand image trap". These perceptions are reinforced through brand associations—mental connections people form each time they encounter the brand. For marketers, a brand is a promise; for customers, it becomes a network of expectations, shaped by ads, usage, or even casual encounters (Batey, 2008). When these elements align, they create brand equity—the added value a name carries. Aaker (1991, as cited in Farjam & Hongyi, 2015) defines it as the assets and liabilities linked to a brand. Strong brand equity brings loyalty, profitability, and resilience, while increasing preference and willingness to choose one brand over another.

Several models explain how brand elements interact within a unified framework. Aaker's Brand Equity Model shows how awareness, perceived quality, loyalty and other units shape brand equity. Keller's CBBE Pyramid maps the path from recognition to emotional resonance and advocacy, while Kapferer's Brand Identity Prism links internal values with external perceptions, emphasizing coherence and authenticity. Each framework explains a different dimension of brand development.

In short, branding is a decisive factor in startup success. It enables new ventures to build trust and credibility at a stage when reputation is not yet established (Raihan, 2024), provides differentiation in competitive markets and strengthens customer loyalty through trust-based relationships (Raj, 2024). A consistent and professional brand identity also signals strategic direction and future potential, making startups more attractive to investors and partners and thereby helping secure early funding, often the greatest constraint in the early stages (Monae, 2024). As Forbes said, "your brand is the single most important investment you can make in your business" (as cited in Raj, 2024). Over time, strong branding does more than attract attention; it lays the foundation for sustainable growth, competitive advantage, and positive brand equity.

3. Methodology

This paper applies a qualitative descriptive single case study to explore Airbnb's branding, as this method allows analysis of branding strategies within a real-life context (Baxter & Jack, 2008). The case is bounded by time (2007-2024) and focuses solely on Airbnb, examining how branding supported its growth from a startup to a global company. Data comes primarily from secondary sources, including Airbnb's press releases, marketing campaigns, media articles, and a 2010 co-founder interview. The company's journey is divided into seven phases, with milestones such as major campaigns, policy announcements, and visual identity shifts. These developments are analysed through Aaker's Brand Equity Model, Keller's Customer-Based Brand Equity Pyramid, and Kapferer's Brand Identity Prism.

4. Results

Airbnb is an online platform where people can rent homes, apartments, or rooms from everyday hosts, providing an alternative to traditional hotels; founded in 2007, it has grown to become one of the most well-known companies in the world by 2025. Airbnb's branding journey began not with slick marketing campaigns or heavy funding, but with a simple act of trust: letting strangers sleep on air mattresses in a living room. From that moment, the challenge was not just to offer a bed, but to make the experience feel personal and safe. The first website reflected this priority, it did not just list rooms, it showed faces and bios, giving the service a human voice. In Aaker's terms, this built the first layer of awareness and associations, while integrated payments soon after strengthened perceived quality. Yet visibility still mattered, and when investors ignored them, the founders turned to creative survival tactics like the Obama O's cereal boxes, a nontraditional ad that gave the young brand salience in Keller's pyramid by turning political humour into national press coverage. Their South by Southwest conference trial in 2008, though nearly empty of bookings, revealed that branding had to solve practical gaps as well, pushing the team to improve user experience. A year later, Y Combinator reinforced this path: by photographing hosts' homes and meeting users face to face, the founders were not just fixing listings, they were cultivating loyalty and deepening the relationship facet of Kapferer's prism. Finally, the shift from AirBed & Breakfast to the cleaner, more universal Airbnb name marked more than a cosmetic change, it moved the brand from simple recognition to meaning, positioning it as a service with global ambition (Mixergy, 2010). Step by step, branding became less a tool for survival and more the language through which Airbnb defined what it stood for: trust, belonging, and human connection.

As the company grew, branding became the compass that guided decisions. When a host's home was vandalised, Airbnb doubled down on trust with the Host Guarantee, strengthening perceived quality (Aaker) and brand judgments (Keller). The 2014 Bélo rebrand, supported by the Belong Anywhere campaign advanced the brand into Keller's feelings and early resonance stage, while also strengthening Kapferer's self-image and personality facets, positioning Airbnb as a lifestyle identity rooted in belonging and openness. Campaigns like #WeAccept or 'Aibiying' in China showed adaptability: they built cultural relevance and reinforced the relationship and reflection dimensions of Kapferer's prism, proving that branding was not just communication but a way to align with global and local values. These actions reflected a deliberate use of branding to build credibility, strengthen associations, and move steadily toward loyalty and resonance.

During its toughest period, the COVID-19 pandemic, Airbnb drew on the resilience of brand equity built over years. Although forced to cut advertising spend by more than half, the company still retained 95% of traffic, clear evidence of the strength of its brand assets (Aaker) and the depth of accumulated equity (Jefferson, 2021). Transparent host communication and the creation of Airbnb.org strengthened relationships (Keller) and reinforced the culture facet (Kapferer). By 2022-2024, initiatives like the 'Airbnb It' campaign, AirCover, and host recognition programmes pushed the brand further into resonance, creating loyalty and advocacy. To conclude, each phase illustrated how branding is not static but adaptive, expanding from awareness to emotional resonance while responding to crises and opportunities. The discussion across Aaker, Keller, and Kapferer highlights that strong branding systems reinforce each other: awareness feeds trust, trust builds meaning, and meaning enables loyalty. In Airbnb's case, branding was not a layer added to the business model, it was the business model itself, guiding survival, growth, and resilience at every stage.

Table 2 summarises Airbnb's branding evolution across seven key phases (2007-2024). Each stage highlights core milestones and their connection to branding frameworks:

Aaker’s Brand Equity Model, Keller’s Customer-Based Brand Equity Pyramid, and Kapferer’s Brand Identity Prism. The table shows how Airbnb’s focus shifted from visibility and differentiation in the early years to emotional loyalty, authenticity, and community belonging in later stages.

Table 2. Core branding takeaways by phase

Phase	Main events	Branding focus
1. Building the foundation during the early startup years (2007-2010)	• Founding & initial hosting experience • Website creation & differentiation • SXSW trial & payment integration • Cereal box campaign & financial struggle	• **Main focus:** media coverage, brand differentiation and visibility • **Main models’ parts:** Aaker’s brand awareness; Keller’s brand salience; Kapferer’s personality and culture
2. Rebranding and early growth	• Y Combinator • Rebranding to ‘Airbnb’” • Expansion and improving of listing options • International offices • Host meetings/community building	• **Main focus:** user trust-building, product improvement, rebranding • **Main models’ parts:** Aaker’s perceives quality, associations, assets; Keller’s salience, brand meaning; Kapferer’s physique, personality, relationship
3. Market expansion (2011-2013)	• Global expansion & acquisitions • Host guarantee • Neighbourhoods programme • Hurricane sandy response • ‘birdbnb’ campaign • Funding rounds	• **Main focus:** expansion, trust & safety of users, local immersion • **Main models’ parts:** Aaker’s brand loyalty, brand awareness, perceived quality; Keller’s meaning, response (judgements); Kapferer’s brand culture, personality, relationship & reflection
4. Rebranding and the ‘Belong Anywhere’ Era (2014-2016)	• Visual and strategic rebrand • Belong anywhere approach • Strategic partnerships • Anti-discrimination policy	• **Main focus:** emotional branding and lifestyle identity, inclusivity & values, community engagement • **Main models’ parts:** Aaker’s associations, perceived quality and assets; Keller’s brand response, early resonance; Kapferer’s brand physique, culture, self-image
5. Purpose-driven branding and platform expansion (2017-2019)	• #WeAccept Campaign • Launch of ‘Aibiying’ in China • Preparation for IPO • Partnerships and acquisitions	• **Main focus:** cultural localisation & adaptation, socially conscious messaging • **Main models’ parts:** Aaker’s perceived quality, brand awareness; Kellers’ brand feelings and resonance; Kapferer’s relationship, personality, self-image

Phase	Main events	Branding focus
6. Strategic decisions in times of crisis, brand resilience (2020-2021)	• Crisis response & refocus • Transparent internal & external communication • IPO • Shift from performance to brand marketing • Community-focused projects	• **Main focus:** crisis resilience, brand trust & transparency, community impact, emotional loyalty • **Main models' parts:** Aaker's brand loyalty, brand associations; Keller's brand response & relationship; Kapferer's brand relationship, culture, self-image
7. Keeping it personal at a global scale (2022-2024)	• Major platform upgrade • Employee policies • Superhosts recognition	• **Main focus:** user-centred innovation, empowerment of hosts, platform simplicity, personalisation at a global level • **Main models' parts:** Aaker's brand loyalty, perceives quality & associations; Keller's brand response and resonance; Kapferer's brand culture, relationship and self-image

Source: own elaboration.

5. Discussion

The findings of this study show that Airbnb's success was driven less by pricing or technology and more by branding as a strategic tool. Branding aced not as an external element, but as the driver through which the company established trust, visibility, and loyalty across different development stages. Another observation is that branding consistently compensated for resource gaps. When investor interest was low, marketing generated media visibility through creative tactics such as the Obama O's cereal boxes. When safety and credibility were questioned, Airbnb responded with guarantees and trust-building features, which enhanced perceived quality in Aaker's framework. When global crises such as the COVID-19 pandemic disrupted travel, branding reframed the company as human-first, sustaining loyalty despite reduced marketing budgets. These findings confirm Keller's argument that brand equity develops progressively, from salience and performance to meaning and resonance and show how Kapferer's culture and relationship facets were reinforced at each stage. Table 2 supports this interpretation by showing how Airbnb's branding focus evolved across overlapping dimensions rather than isolated phases. Therefore, the main focus at each stage should be seen as dominant but not exclusive; while one aspect may be central, others still operate in parallel. This layered interaction helps explain how Airbnb maintained coherence and adaptability in its brand identity over time.

It is important to note that this study has limitations. First, it is based on secondary data and a single case study, which restricts the generalizability of the findings. Moreover, while branding was the central focus, other factors such as funding, networking, and team dynamics also contributed to Airbnb's growth but were not examined here. Future research should expand to examine different industries and contexts, as well as explore how branding interacts with other aspects of entrepreneurial success, in order to uncover additional factors that contribute to startup performance.

6. Conclusions

This study examined how Airbnb used branding to grow from an early-stage startup into a multinational company with sustained global presence between 2007 and 2024. The findings indicate that Airbnb leveraged branding through early trust-building with users, cultivating a community-based identity, fostering emotional engagement, executing adaptive campaigns in new markets, and reinforcing loyalty and credibility during crises such as the COVID-19 pandemic. These strategies collectively supported growth and strengthened brand equity, as conceptualised by Aaker, Keller, and Kapferer, showing how awareness, meaning, and relationships interact to enable loyalty and resonance. Branding consistently functioned as a guiding mechanism rather than a peripheral activity, helping Airbnb navigate resource constraints, enhance perceived quality, and align with cultural and global expectations. More broadly, the case demonstrates that branding plays a strategic role in startup development alongside funding, innovation, and team composition, and serves as a tool for building trust, legitimacy, and emotional connection, which can determine whether ventures evolve into enduring, globally recognised companies.

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Rola brandingu w sukcesie startupów – przypadek Airbnb

Streszczenie: Na świecie istnieje ponad 150 mln startupów, jednak tylko ok. 10% z nich osiąga długoterminowy sukces, podczas gdy większość upada z powodu problemów finansowych, technologicznych i marketingowych. Airbnb wyróżnia się jako jeden z najbardziej znaczących przykładów tej odnoszącej sukcesy mniejszości, szczególnie dzięki wczesnemu skupieniu się na budowaniu marki i społeczności, a nie wyłącznie na przychodach. Centralnym pytaniem niniejszej pracy jest: w jaki sposób Airbnb wykorzystało branding, aby rozwinąć się ze startupu w międzynarodową firmę w latach 2007-2024? W badaniu przyjęto jakościowe podejście opisowe w formie studium przypadku, oparte głównie na danych wtórnych, takich jak wywiady, komunikaty prasowe firmy oraz raporty branżowe. Wyniki wskazują, że branding odegrał kluczową rolę w ewolucji Airbnb, kształtując jego działania i pozycjonowanie na różnych etapach rozwoju.

Słowa kluczowe: branding, kapitał marki, startupy, model kapitału marki Aakera

DOI: 10.15611/2026.35.7.02
JEL Classification: L1, L2

Strategy Implementation Challenges: The Strategy-as-Practice Perspective

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Quote as: Kulig, K. (2026). Strategy Implementation Challenges: The Strategy-as-Practice Perspective. In J. Radomska, & A. Witek-Crabb (Eds.), *New Trends in Business Management. Culture, Strategy, Engagement* (pp. 17-28). Publishing House of Wroclaw University of Economics and Business.

Abstract: The aim of the chapter is to identify and explain how managerial practices at different hierarchical levels enable or constrain strategy implementation within the Strategy-as-Practice (SAP) framework, and to interpret these practices using the 3P (Practices-Praxis-Practitioners) perspective. The author examines the challenges of strategy implementation in a multinational, global financial institution from a managerial perspective. While strategy design receives significant attention, failure often arises from ineffective execution. Adopting the SAP approach, the study views strategy as a set of daily activities shaped by managers at multiple organisational levels. Based on 30 in-depth interviews, findings underline the crucial role of mid- and front-line managers in translating strategic priorities into operational goals, motivating employees, and ensuring alignment through communication and trust. Key barriers include resistance to change and limited authority, while success depends on authentic leadership, collaboration, and two-way communication. The research shows that standardised frameworks are insufficient without adapting to cultural, organisational, and managerial contexts, underscoring the importance of practice-driven strategy execution.

Keywords: strategy; strategy-as-practice (SAP); management; leadership; execution

1. Introduction

The successful implementation of a corporate strategy remains one of the most important management factors. The strategy formulation attracts a lot of attention, however organisations fail not because of the poor design, but due to ineffective implementation. The operational execution is quite complex in large, multinational organisations, where communication flows, and managerial alignment at all corporate levels may influence the outcomes.

Strategy is not something that an organisation *has* but something that people *do* through strategy formulation and implementation. The Strategy-as-Practice perspective implies that strategy does not exist until managers enact it through human agency (Christie & Tippmann, 2024).

Accordingly, the aim of the research is to explore how managers at different hierarchical levels interpret, enact, and adapt strategic priorities in their daily practices. For the purpose of this study, the name of the Global Financial Institution (GFI) and its actual strategy have been anonymised. The author examines the challenges associated with the strategy implementation from a managerial perspective based on the GFI's "Strategic Priorities". The study is aimed to examine and understand how managers working at different corporate levels in a financial services company adopt and implement a global strategy in their local business environment.

The research has been conducted with the in-depth interview method (IDI). 30 interviews were held with managers working in a financial institution. Managers with various corporate seniority titles have been asked the same set of questions. They have shared their individual, subjective opinions on how organisations implement business strategies, what challenges they face, and what factors support the execution. The research reveals the connection between the theoretical aspects of strategy implementation and practical business approach.

From a scientific and practical perspectives, it is important to highlight that organisations in the modern business environment are constantly influenced by multiple internal and external factors. The standard 'book patterns' do not reflect the complex reality. All strategy implementation models should be adjusted with the cultural factors, organisation's specific communication and management styles.

The research shows the importance of the mid- and front-line managers in the successful strategy execution. Their knowledge, experience, personal commitment, and attitude are the key factors to motivate employees, and translate the high-level company's strategic vision into operational goals.

2. Strategy-as-Practice (SAP): An Activity Based Approach

The traditional strategy research has been focused on the macro-level frameworks that used to characterise organisation or industry landscapes. The Strategy-as-Practice (SAP) movement started to emerge in early 2000s as a concept to focus not only on the macro-level, but on the human-centred activities.

The SAP concept has been promoted and developed by the distinguished scholars such as Richard Whittington, Paula Jarzabkowski and David Seidl. SAP is not a theory, it is rather a research field and an approach toward a better understanding of the strategizing activities. Strategy as practice is an important approach to studying strategic management that focuses on strategic activities. SAP research can be broadly categorised as techniques, tools, and methods used in strategy making (practices) by members of an organisation (practitioners) who engage in lived instances of routine and non-routine strategizing work on a daily basis (praxis) (Mirabeau et al., 2017).

What is the strategic activity? According to Jarzabkowski et al. (2007), activity is considered strategic to the extent that it is consequential for the strategic outcomes, directions, survival and competitive advantage of the firm. SAP emphasises that strategy should not be considered as a top-down process dictated solely by the senior management, but rather an activity-based approach. It should include stakeholders across different levels of an organisation, as their actions shape the final outcomes. This perspective is aligned with a contemporary understanding of strategy as a practice embedded in everyday organisational activities rather than a static plan.

Whittington (2006) sets the three themes for strategy research: Practice, Praxis and Practitioners (the 3P Framework). Figure 1 visualises the concept of the 3P Framework and the intersection of these elements, where the strategy formation occurs, that is strategizing.

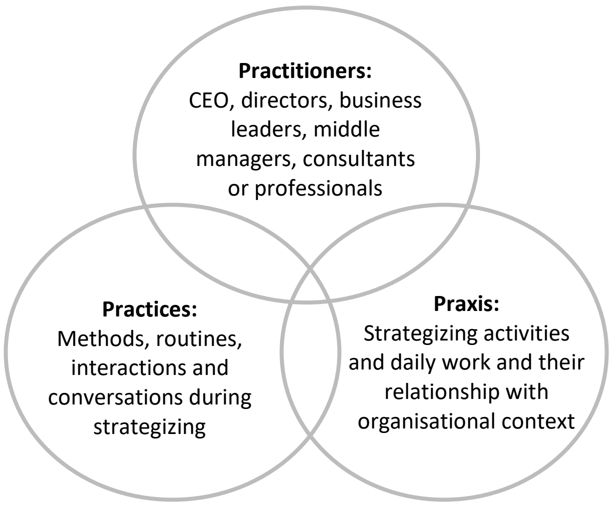

Fig. 1. The 3P Framework: Practice, Praxis, Practitioners

Source: own elaboration based on (Whittington, 2006).

According to Radomska and Kozyra's (2020) research, the strategy execution process should be perceived as a set of integrated factors that should be analysed from an aggregated perspective. This includes management functions: planning, organising, motivating and control; soft factors (hard to measure): organisational structure and culture, leadership, strategic approach and communication; measurable factors: tools, systems, procedures, processes, resources.

On top of the above formalised models, from the practical perspective it is important to consider leadership, communication and engagement, organisational culture, ability to prioritise, and change management. Leaders at various management levels act as role models who initiate and stimulate processes needed to drive change.

In the context of strategy-as-practice studies, Hedborg et al. (2024) indicate that consequentiality implies exploring practices that lead to strategic changes, without necessarily being deliberate or proposed by management. Actions can also have an indirect influence on change; a perspective that opens up for acknowledging the multiple actors and their actions on strategy practices. Thus, grasping this multiplicity implies a need for research to follow strategic practices in inter-organisational projects.

According to Lemos da Silveira Santos et al. (2020), the concept of open strategy is characterised by an openness in terms of inclusiveness, that is the range of people involved in making strategy, and an openness in terms of transparency, both in the strategy formulation stage and, more commonly, in the communication of strategies. The societal, organisational, technological and cultural forces support the strategizing process. It is important to understand how 'practices' shape the daily activities (praxis) of 'practitioners' while these actors are strategizing in an open and transparent organisation.

Middle-level managers with a deep operational knowledge can adjust and fit the big strategy picture to the local realities. Effective communication allows not only to understand *what* the strategy is about, but also *why* it matters and *how* it can fit their individual roles. Research in SAP shows that getting employees involved in strategy conversations positively impacts their sense of ownership and gives them practical insights that may streamline strategy execution. Managers (practitioners) shape the construction of practice through who they are, how they act and what resources they draw upon.

The concept of strategy plays a crucial role in determining an organisation's success and sustainability. This is especially visible in the modern, dynamic environment which may evolve rapidly. The contemporary models propose and expect a more agile and flexible responsive approach to overcome challenges and to align organisation's resources and objectives with opportunities. The contemporary understanding of strategy emphasises collaboration rather than competition in certain scenarios and is characterised by adaptability, integration of technology, stakeholder inclusivity, and a focus on long-term value creation.

3. Managerial Roles and Challenges in Executing Strategy

Managers play a critical role in bridging the gap between strategy formulation and execution. SAP emphasises and focuses on activities and actual practices involved in strategizing. This means how strategies are formulated, communicated and established within organisation. In this approach the strategy emerges from the actual interactions between various stakeholders and is not cascaded as a formal planning process.

The strategizing process involves multiple stakeholders starting with the CEO and the executive committee (board of directors), and business leaders, middle managers and employees. The context in which the strategy is developed is quite significant. The SAP perspective values the organisational culture and the external environmental conditions which may affect or influence the way strategy is developed and implemented.

The strategizing process in SAP is considered as an ongoing, dynamic process without the traditional phases like strategy formulation or implementation. It rather reflects the modern business environment with the agile approach, where the strategizing process needs to adapt to the constantly changing circumstances. SAP connects and bridges the traditional and theoretical strategy management frameworks with the day-to-day actions. Figure 2 presents the business strategy creation process.

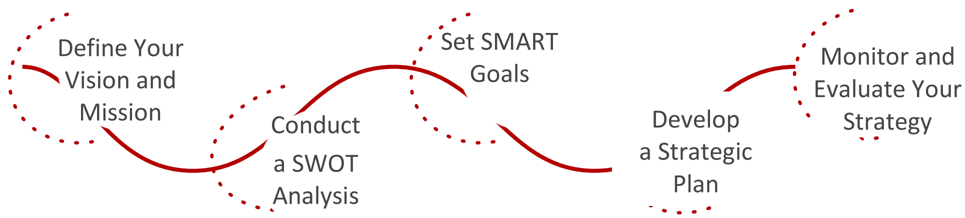

Fig. 2. Five steps to build a business strategy

Source: (The Strategy Institute, 2024).

According to Radomska (2014), who quotes a few perspectives in her research, the strategy implementation process alone requires extraordinary abilities, as it appears to be a much more difficult task than strategy formulation. Currently, it is rather necessary to employ strategic thinking and thus to modify the role of the manager and adopt a bottom-up approach to the decision-making process (Lorange, 1998). This requires a number of skills from the managers, such as creating an appropriate organisational culture and providing an adequate interpretation of the strategy (Ashforth & Kreiner, 1999).

The strategic management process requires managers and employees to identify themselves as a part of the company, and to get them actively involved in the strategy-formulation activities.

4. Research Method

The main purpose of the research was to examine and understand how managers working at different corporate levels in a global financial services company adopt and implement a global strategy in their local business environment. The research was focused on the practical aspects of the managerial practices and actions that facilitate effective strategy implementation and their approach in overcoming obstacles and challenges. The chapter presents the subjective opinions and the understanding of strategy, change management process and the scope of responsibilities in that field from the manager's perspective.

The research employed a qualitative method, using semi-structured interviews with the open-ended questions as the primary data collection tool. The research aims to find out how managers overcome challenges and whether:

- the results are going to be the same and common for all managers;
- there is any difference in the understanding of strategy and its execution at diverse hierarchical positions (corporate seniority), depending on the managerial function and the area of business (department specific);
- the overall work experience influences their current perception;
- they have any suggestions to share.

The data that has been gathered cannot be generalised. The organisational context plays a crucial role in the evaluation of the individual's perspective. The research was performed in one company, at a specific time which corresponds with one of the phases of strategy evolution. The organisation's dynamics, external and internal factors may influence the managers' perspective and reshape their previous approach, if any of the factors in their business environment is changed.

The research has been conducted with the in-depth interview method (IDI). According to M. Roller and Lavrakas (2015), this is one of the qualitative research models which may be used in the user experience research. The IDIs help to gather detailed insights from a selected group of individuals within a target population. The interview questions and the research framework are designed to receive credible and analysable results. The IDI model aims to explore respondents' point of view, their subjective experience and perspectives (Roller & Lavrakas, 2015).

According to Rutledge and Hogg (2020), an in-depth interview resembles a conversation but is designed to stimulate depth of meaning from the perspective of the participant. This method is used to conduct detailed interviews with a small number of participants. The traditional meetings are conducted one-by-one, and the researcher has to invest a significant amount of time with each participant. The open-ended questions encourage interviewee's detailed, subjective narratives.

The IDI allows for eliminating the biased, group perspective. This is especially important, when the researcher would like to receive answers which are not influenced by the others. One of advantages of the IDI is a freedom for interviewees to share all they feel is important, whereas one of the disadvantages is a relatively small sample size. Additionally, the interviewer's tone, posture, delivery of questions and reactions to responses, such as facial expressions, body language, or word choice, can influence participants and introduce unintentional bias that compromises the quality of the data (Rutledge & Hogg, 2020).

The research data was collected through a series of the live, individual interviews (IDIs) with the GFI's managers. The author went through a formal approval process at GFI and received the company's permission to organise meetings with managers. The interviews were conducted in February and March 2025 with managers with diverse titles and hierarchical positions from different departments.

For the purpose of this study, managers, who were interviewed are referred to as the informants. All were asked the same set of seven questions.

1. Can you describe your understanding of GFI's three strategic priorities and how they influence your daily operations?
2. Can you name a few practises of a successful strategy implementation/a few factors supporting it? How can they be utilised in a business environment?
3. What specific practices or processes have you observed that facilitate effective strategy implementation within your team/department?
4. Can you name a few factors hindering the strategy implementation? How can they be overcome?
5. In your experience, what challenges have you faced while implementing three strategic priorities, and how have you addressed them?
6. How do you think the organisation can improve its current strategy implementation practices to better align with its strategic goals?
7. Can you share an example of a learning experience or insight gained from a project that involved the strategic priorities, and how it influenced subsequent efforts?

Potential informants were identified based on their managerial roles, seniority, and direct involvement in operational and strategic activities. All informants were encouraged to share their honest and open perspective and informed their answers were going to be anonymised. None of the interviews were recorded, but all were summarised, and supplemented by notetaking to ensure comprehensive data collection for subsequent analysis. All 30 interviews were conducted in full, all questions were asked and answered. None of the informants refused to give answers to any of the questions. All interviews were conducted with the informants based in the local GFI's office, located in Wroclaw, Poland. Table 1 presents the characteristics of the informants.

Table 1. Work experience of informants

Length of service/ work experience (years)	Number of informants	Length of service as managers (years)	Number of informants	Length of service in GFI (years)	Number of informants
0-5	0	0-5	5	0-5	8
5-10	2	5-10	7	5-10	7
10-15	7	10-15	12	10-15	8
15-20	14	15-20	4	15-20	7
> 20	7	> 20	2	> 20	0
Sum	30		30		30

Source: own elaboration.

5. Research Findings

The data and all answers have been categorised, grouped, and analysed. Data analysis followed a thematic approach, involving systematic coding and categorisation of responses to identify key themes and patterns relevant to the research questions.

All informants have demonstrated a clear understanding of GFI's Strategic Priorities and reported that these principles significantly shaped their daily operations. One informant emphasised that GFI has implemented a new strategy "by the book", and all actions and proposed solutions match the market needs perfectly. To quote informant I12, who said: "I fully support GFI's Strategic Priorities, which represent the simplicity and a future-forward thinking".

Company's strategy is reflected in managers' operational goals. A success factor is to reshape and reformulate a global, high-level strategy into a local, business specific goals. As indicated by informant 10: "the company's strategy needs to be simple at a high-level, this leaves operational space for the mid and front-line managers to create the team specific business goals".

There should be a foundation of trust in an organisation, so the front-line and the mid-level employees can have confidence in the leadership's plans and their vision. The culture and strategy are not personal, but organisational. Mutual trust is a factor supporting strategy execution. To quote informant 2: "the strategy goes top to bottom, and the full context is not always visible to all employees, the mutual trust is a success factor".

Informant 15 demonstrated a human-centred approach: "for me people are the most important, and it's one of my priorities to keep them engaged. When my employees are appreciated, they support strategy execution as truly active stakeholders".

A few informants highlighted a crucial role of the middle-level managers. In their opinion a disconnect between the message from the top management and from the middle-level managers increases the likelihood of strategy failure. This is driven by the personal impact the middle-level managers have directly on their departments and teams. Only a strong leadership alignment across all hierarchical levels strengthens and enables strategy execution.

One of the informants emphasised that managers need to be authentic. A manager should "lead by example" to facilitate execution and inspire subordinates. To quote informant 3: "a strategic change requires commitment from managers, who need to lead by example, as their actions speak louder than words".

Senior informants emphasised the importance of clear ownership and responsibility. They highlighted their personal responsibility for the all goals that had been set for them. This sense of ownership enables them to adapt the global strategy to the local culture. They emphasised that breaking down corporate strategy into specific missions at the team level makes it more understandable and implementable by employees. To quote informant 19: "the accountability and a sense of ownership build commitment. Managers, who feel responsible for the cascaded goals, may be more creative and successful in execution".

Informants, who work mainly with internal customers, emphasised the importance of the feedback loops from various stakeholders. To quote informant 25: "together with my team we regularly review feedback from our internal stakeholders. It's a daily work—to be constantly focused on moving forward, learn, take ownership and provide better services in the future".

An open dialogue builds trust and confidence. It is not about turning into action all employees' suggestions, but about giving them the comfort they are listened to, and their opinions are welcome. As indicated by informant 4: "an open communication works both ways top to bottom and bottom-up, the transparency and dialogue are needed to build long-term commitment".

It has been noticed that experienced managers tend to offer opportunity to have an open discussion with their employees. As a result, employees are more likely to accept and acknowledge new business goals along with key requests coming from the top management. This approach is effective across all functional levels within the organisation. It also empowers people. Informant 22 noted: "I share decision-making authority through task delegation. Employees have some flexibility and can decide for themselves how to achieve the cascaded goals. I ask for feedback and offer support, I do not micromanage".

Another informant emphasised that she encourages her team to ask all kinds of questions and tries to provide very specific answers supported by operational examples. She tries to illustrate how even small daily tasks add value to the final product or service delivered to the customer. Informant 27 explained: "I constantly talk to my team, I prefer to communicate even more in detail, rather than leave space for understatements or misinterpretation". The empirical findings from this research can be interpreted through the lens of the 3P Framework.

Praxis: mid- and front-line managers were able to translate strategic objectives into context-specific decisions, and to balance top-management directives with the operational realities of their teams. Informants' responses revealed how strategy is actively realised through human interactions, sense-making, and iterative learning processes.

Practices: informants consistently emphasised the need to simplify corporate strategy to operationalise objectives in ways that are relevant to their teams. Operational tools such as regular feedback loops, cascading goals, and structured task delegation served as tangible practices that enabled employees to engage with strategy meaningfully. Additionally, communication and collaboration mechanisms, such as cross-functional meetings, and open dialogues have been identified as the critical practices to facilitate alignment across organisation (Hitt, 2002).

Practitioners: findings underscored the critical role of middle managers as intermediaries between top management and operational teams, acting simultaneously as translators, motivators, and role models. Managers' accountability, sense of ownership, and the leadership styles directly influence the strategy acceptance and commitment.

6. Practical Implications

Several respondents emphasised the value of a cross-functional collaboration in overcoming strategy silos. Organisations should support this by fostering interdepartmental dialogue, encouraging knowledge sharing, and leveraging collaborative platforms. This would help aligning goals, process owners, resources and timelines. This is particularly important in organisations like GFI, where the strategy execution often involves multiple business units.

All managers have their unique understanding of the company's strategy, however their subjective perspectives are not always fully aligned with the company's vision and expectations. The informants highlighted that while the strategic goals are often clearly communicated at the executive level, the interpretation and application at functional or departmental levels can vary significantly. To address this, managers should focus on breaking down broad strategic objectives into department-specific goals, aligning them with employees' roles, and providing clear examples of how everyday actions contribute to larger outcomes. These actions should be coordinated by the higher management through regular checkpoint sessions. Managers briefing sessions would help ensure that managers at all levels within the given business unit are aligned, have the same understanding of their goals and can share and exchange their perspectives.

Internal communication has emerged as a critical factor influencing the success of strategy implementation. Managers very often have a dual role: as communicators and translators of the strategy. At the same time, they are between the top-down directives coming from the top management, and bottom-up realities: feedback or pushback from their teams and direct subordinates. Transparent and consistent communication, especially during periods of change, helps building a common trust. The communication should flow both ways and the mutual trust may be a key success point in a long-term perspective.

7. Conclusions

This study explored the strategy implementation challenges from a managerial perspective. The GFI's Strategic Priorities were used as an analytical framework. The theoretical analysis was supported by the empirical interviews conducted with 30 managers from GFI. The in-depth interview model (IDI) was applied. The research showed that the GFI's Strategic Priorities were well understood by all interviewees. The strategy execution remains a complex and challenging topic.

The research showed that the standard 'book patterns' may be applied as the general guideline towards strategy execution, but they do not reflect the complex reality of each organisation. All strategy implementation models should be adapted to the cultural factors, company's specific communication and management styles. The interviews conducted with the GFI's managers revealed how they use their knowledge, experience, personal commitment and attitude to motivate employees, coordinate internal communication, and translate the high-level company's strategic vision into operational goals. The mid- and front-line managers play a crucial role in the successful strategy execution.

The research was limited by its single-case design and qualitative approach, which restricts generalisability. Future research should adopt comparative or longitudinal designs and integrate quantitative performance data to extend SAP- based implementation research.

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Wyzwania związane z wdrażaniem strategii: perspektywa SAP

Streszczenie: W niniejszym rozdziale zanalizowano wyzwania związane z wdrażaniem strategii w międzynarodowej, globalnej instytucji finansowej z perspektywy menedżerskiej. Choć projektowanie strategii przyciąga znaczną uwagę, niepowodzenia wynikają najczęściej z jej nieefektywnej realizacji. Przyjmując podejście Strategy-as-Practice (SAP), potraktowano strategię jako zbiór codziennych działań kształtowanych przez menedżerów na różnych szczeblach organizacyjnych. Na podstawie 30 pogłębionych wywiadów (metoda IDI) wykazano kluczową rolę menedżerów średniego i pierwszej linii w przekładaniu priorytetów strategicznych na cele operacyjne, motywowaniu pracowników oraz zapewnianiu spójności poprzez komunikację i budowanie zaufania. Do głównych barier należą opór wobec zmian i ograniczony zakres decyzyjny, natomiast sukces warunkują autentyczne przywództwo, współpraca oraz dwukierunkowa komunikacja. Wyniki badań wskazują, że ustandaryzowane modele okazują się niewystarczające bez dostosowania do kontekstu kulturowego, organizacyjnego i menedżerskiego, co podkreśla znaczenie praktycznego, opartego na działaniach wdrażania strategii.

Słowa kluczowe: strategia, strategia jako praktyka, wdrażanie strategii, zarządzanie, przywództwo

Debiuty studenckie
Student debuts

DOI: 10.15611/2026.35.7.03
JEL Classification: M12, M53, M54

Gamification as an Element of Building Employee Engagement in the Onboarding Process

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Quote as: Lasota, W. (2025). Gamification as an Element of Building Employee Engagement in the Onboarding Process. In J. Radomska, & A. Witek-Crabb (Eds.), *New Trends in Business Management. Culture, Strategy, Engagement* (pp. 29-40). Publishing House of Wroclaw University of Economics and Business.

Abstract: The growing use of gamification in human resource management raises questions about its role in key processes such as onboarding. Most existing studies address education, training or marketing, while onboarding as a structured process has received little attention. This article explores how gamification influences employee engagement during onboarding, compared with traditional approaches. Engagement was measured with the UWES-9 scale, and the data were analysed in JASP to ensure reliable results. To provide context, the survey was complemented with three case studies of organisations that had applied gamification in onboarding. The findings show that gamification supports higher engagement than traditional methods. However, neither the length of onboarding nor the number of mechanisms proved any significance. What mattered most was the quality and relevance of the solutions. The study highlights that effective gamification is not about how many points, badges, or tasks are added, but whether the design truly supports employees' needs. When done well, gamification can be more than a fashionable trend, it becomes a practical tool for building motivation, integration, and lasting engagement from the very first days at work.

Keywords: gamification, employee onboarding, employee engagement, organisational socialisation, work motivation

1. Introduction

Nowadays, organisations operate in an environment of increasing competition for talent, high staff turnover, and dynamic technological changes, which redefine the way human resources are managed. Onboarding new employees is no longer just a formal stage of adaptation but a strategic process that affects pivotal moments for new employees. Its quality can determine whether they will build a lasting relationship with their employer or start considering changing jobs at an early stage. A key determinant of onboarding effectiveness is employee engagement. Engagement is understood as a positive, active state related to the work performed, defined in the literature as vigour, dedication and absorption (Schaufeli et al., 2006). When these qualities are fostered early on, they can strengthen employees' perceptions of the organisation and their role, leading to positive outcomes such as lower turnover rate and reduced costs associated with the process. Despite the growing interest in gamification, most researchers focus on its application in education or marketing activities. As a result, knowledge about the real impact on engagement by using gamified solutions while onboarding remains limited, especially the lack of empirical studies that directly examine the relationship between the two variables. To contribute to this underexplored area, this article investigates whether onboarding with gamified elements is associated with higher levels of employee engagement compared with traditional induction methods. In addition, it is followed by two potential factors that may shape this relationship: (1) whether the number of gamification elements used is related to engagement, and (2) whether the length of the onboarding process is associated with engagement outcomes. Addressing these objectives helps clarify the mechanisms that may determine the effectiveness of gamified onboarding and provides a foundation for further research in this field.

2. Theoretical Background

Gamification is commonly defined as the use of game design elements in non-game contexts (Deterding et al., 2011). Early applications appeared mainly in marketing and customer loyalty programs, where game mechanics were used to capture client attention and strengthen relationships. Over time, both researchers and practitioners recognised that the same principles could be applied in organisational settings, from recruitment and training to employee development and onboarding (Werbach & Hunter, 2012). Unlike full-scale games, gamification relies on structured mechanics such as challenges, rewards, and feedback loops that aim to foster engagement and motivation in professional environments. Its usefulness is also linked to cultural and technological change. Prensky (2001) highlighted that younger generations, the so-called 'digital natives' are accustomed to interactivity, immediacy, and technology--driven experiences, which makes gamification appealing in the modern workplace. Studies indicate that mechanisms used in gamification can foster belonging and give newcomers a sense of progress during onboarding (Melnikova et al., 2023; Van der Heijden et al., 2020). The fact that gamification works is not due to attractive graphics or modern technology, but because it taps into basic psychological mechanisms that have been described for years by researchers studying motivation and engagement. Deci and Ryan's (1985, 2000) Self-Determination Theory highlights that people are most motivated when their basic psychological needs for autonomy, competence, and relatedness are fulfilled. Building on this, Locke and Latham (1990, 2002) emphasise in their Goal-Setting Theory that clearly defined and challenging goals further strengthen engagement by directing attention, increasing effort, and sustaining persistence, especially when accompanied by feedback that allows individuals to track progress. Complementing these perspectives, the Job Demands-Resources model developed by Demerouti et al. (2001) explains how the balance between job demands, such as workload or time pressure, and available resources, such as support or autonomy, shapes employee engagement and well-being. Together, these theories provide valuable insights into the psychological mechanisms that drive people to commit to tasks and maintain their energy and focus over time.

But as with every innovation, it can have its drawbacks. When the solution is poorly designed, its impact on employees quickly weakens. Instead of fostering genuine involvement, it can draw attention to game scores and rankings, making people focus on results rather than their actual work (Almeida et al., 2023). This 'sportification' of the workplace, where excessive competition mirrors the logic of sports, may create tension and erode the sense of community that is vital for lasting commitment (González- González & Navarro-Adelantado, 2020). Instead of supporting employees in building a deeper understanding of their work, gamification may sometimes fall short in situations that require reflection or more complex learning (Zhang & Hasim, 2023). Altogether, these risks suggest that engagement grows only when gamification truly addresses employees' needs and fit the organisational culture; otherwise, it is quickly dismissed as a superficial layer with little relevance to their everyday experience.

3. Research Problem

To dive into the research problem, a set of hypotheses were formulated that relate to the relationship between the onboarding process and the level of employee engagement.

H1: Employees who experience gamification during onboarding are more engaged at work than those who undergo traditional onboarding.

This hypothesis is grounded in Self-Determination Theory (Deci & Ryan, 1985, 2000) which suggests that interactive and personalised learning environments can boost engagement by fulfilling basic psychological needs. Previous research (Deterding et al., 2011; Saks, 2006) has shown that gamified onboarding can increase engagement and commitment to learning and work.

H2: The length of the gamified onboarding process significantly affects the level of employee engagement.

This hypothesis is based on the Job Demands-Resources model (Demerouti et al., 2001), according to which employee motivation depends on the balance between the demands and resources offered by the organisation. Onboarding can be viewed as a valuable resource, particularly when it offers support, structure, feedback, and clarity of expectations.

H3: The greater the number of gamification elements experienced during onboarding, the higher the level of employee engagement.

This hypothesis assumes that various gamification mechanisms can accumulate positive effects on motivation and engagement. According to goal-setting theory (Locke & Latham, 2002), clearly defined and ambitious goals increase concentration, effort, and the sense of meaning in actions. In the context of onboarding, elements such as points, levels, badges, and rankings can serve as milestone goals and support orientation in the process.

4. Method

The analysis of the role of gamification in the onboarding process shows research on this topic is still quite limited. While gamification has been studied in areas such as education, training, and marketing, its use in employee onboarding has not been explored in much depth. It was this research gap that became the starting point for designing an empirical study aimed at capturing whether and how the use of mechanisms derived from games can realistically increase employee engagement. The research question boiled down to determining whether people participating in gamified onboarding declare a higher level of engagement than those undergoing the process in its traditional form. The research sample included 56 people who had participated in the onboarding process in recent months either in a traditional form (33 people) or with elements of gamification (23 people). The UWES-9 scale was used to measure the level of engagement, which examines three dimensions: vigour, dedication, and absorption. It is a tool recognised in occupational psychology research, with high reliability and validity, allowing the results to be interpreted in the light of a wide body of literature (Schaufeli & Bakker, 2004). Responses were given on a seven-point Likert scale, which allowed quantitative results that could be compared between groups. The questionnaire was made available online via social media and thematic groups related to HR and gamification. Participation was anonymous. Each respondent confirmed whether their onboarding process included gamification elements and then answered questions. The variable number of gamification elements was measured by asking respondents to indicate which elements from a predefined list (e.g., points, badges, leaderboards, challenges, feedback) were present in their onboarding. The total number of selected items was then calculated for each participant. In the original version of the study, the calculations were performed in Excel, but in this publication, it was decided to present the results based on JASP, which allows for a more transparent presentation and easier replication of the analyses. Appropriate non-parametric tests were used: the Mann–Whitney test to compare the level of engagement between the traditional and gamification groups, Spearman's rank correlation to check the relationship between the number of gamification elements used and the level of engagement, and the Kruskal–Wallis test to assess whether the length of the gamified onboarding process differentiates the level of engagement.

The analytical methods selected in this way made it possible not only to verify the hypotheses, but also to capture subtle relationships that could be missed with simpler analysis tools. The quantitative analysis was supplemented with three case studies of organisations implementing gamification in the onboarding process. The examples were selected to show different approaches to the topic. Each of them allowed for capturing different aspects of gamification—from solutions strongly based on technology and micro-learning, using realistic simulations and repeatable scenarios, to projects based on long-term internal initiatives. This allowed the figures to be compared with organisational practice and placed in a real business context, which increased the credibility and multidimensionality of the conclusions drawn from the research.

5. Results

This part of the study presents the results of statistical analysis aimed at examining the relationship between the nature of the onboarding process and the level of employee engagement. The analyses were based on data obtained using the UWES-9 scale, which allows for a multidimensional approach to engagement in a professional context. The research assumptions were verified based on three hypotheses.

5.1. Gamified vs Traditional Onboarding

Hypothesis H1 stated that employees who experience gamification during onboarding are more engaged at work than those who undergo traditional onboarding. To verify this assumption, engagement levels measured by the UWES-9 scale were compared between two groups of respondents: those who participated in gamified onboarding (n = 23) and those who experienced a traditional onboarding process (n = 33).

Descriptive statistics indicated that employees in the gamified group achieved a higher mean UWES score (M = 4.23) compared to the traditional group (M = 3.34). This suggests a noticeable difference in overall engagement between the two onboarding formats.

The t-test for independent samples showed a significant difference between the groups, $t(54) = 4.65$; $p < .001$. To further confirm the result, a non-parametric Mann–Whitney U test was performed, which also confirmed the significance of the difference, $U = 621.50$; $p < .001$. Both tests led to the clear conclusion that employees participating in gamified onboarding achieved a higher level of engagement than those in the traditional group.

These findings provide strong support for hypothesis H1 and align with prior research suggesting that gamification mechanisms foster engagement by satisfying psychological needs for autonomy and competence (Deci & Ryan, 2000; Saks, 2006).

5.2. Onboarding Length and the Engagement

The second research hypothesis examined whether the duration of onboarding differentiates the level of employee engagement in gamified processes. This assumption was based on earlier theoretical findings, primarily the JD-R (Job Demands-Resources) model, according to which the appropriate structure and length of the induction process can increase employees' psychological resources, reduce feelings of uncertainty, and promote greater engagement in work (Demerouti et al., 2001).

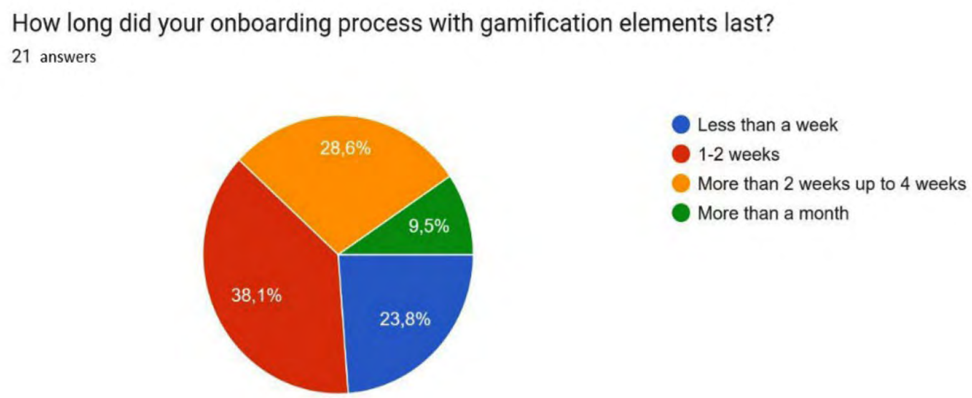

Fig. 1. Duration of gamified onboarding processes reported by respondents

Source: own elaboration based on survey data (2025).

In the study, participants from the gamification group (n = 23) were divided into four categories depending on the duration of their implementation process:

a) less than a week,
b) 1-2 weeks,
c) 2-4 weeks,
d) more than a month.

To check whether the differences between these groups are statistically significant, the analysis of variance (ANOVA) and additional non-parametric Kruskal–Wallis test were performed. Both ANOVA ($F(3,19) = 1.61$; $p = .221$) and the Kruskal–Wallis test ($\chi^2(3) = 3.64$; $p = .303$) showed that the duration of onboarding did not significantly differentiate the level of engagement. The mean UWES values were similar in each category, and the differences that did occur were not statistically significant.

The results do not confirm the assumption that a longer onboarding process promotes higher engagement. Hypothesis 2 was therefore rejected. This can be interpreted to mean that it is not the length of onboarding itself, but its quality and suitability to the employee's needs that may play a key role in shaping engagement.

5.3. Number of Gamified Elements and Engagement

The third hypothesis assumed that a greater number of gamification elements in the onboarding process would be associated with a higher level of employee engagement. The logic behind this assumption is that different mechanisms can reinforce each other, increasing the effect of engagement. Goal-setting theory (Locke & Latham, 2002) emphasises that clearly defined and ambitious goals promote concentration, effort and a sense of purpose in the actions taken. In the context of onboarding, such functions can be performed by points, levels, badges or rankings, which mark successive stages and help to navigate the process.

As shown in Fig. 2, the gamification group (n = 23) was used to test this hypothesis. The independent variable was the number of gamification elements, and the dependent variable was the average UWES score. Due to the relatively small sample size and the need to test the assumptions of normality, the Shapiro–Wilk test was performed, which indicated no significant deviations from the normal distribution (W = 0.938, p = .119). Nevertheless, to increase the reliability of the conclusions, it was decided to use Spearman's non-parametric rank correlation test.

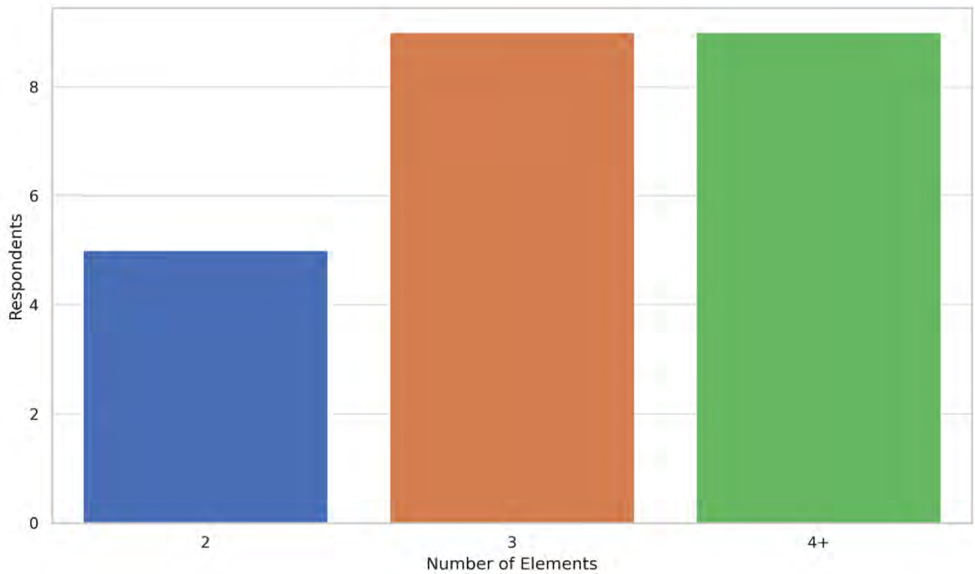

Fig. 2. Number of gamification elements experienced

Source: own elaboration.

The analysis showed that there is no statistically significant relationship between the number of gamification elements and the level of engagement (ρ = –0.046, p =.833). The coefficient obtained indicates no relationship (even approximately neutral), which means that a greater number of gamification mechanisms did not translate into higher UWES scores in the sample studied.

Hypothesis 3 was not confirmed. The results suggest that it is not the number of gamification elements used, but rather their quality and suitability to the needs of employees that may be important for building engagement.

5.4. Case Studies

To complement the quantitative results, three case studies were reviewed to illustrate how gamification functions in real organisational settings. Webhelp, a global BPO company, implemented the Centrical platform combining gamification mechanics, microlearning, and real-time feedback. The initiative reduced absenteeism, accelerated proficiency, and maintained engagement among younger employees by emphasising autonomy, feedback, and team-based challenges (Albi Research Team, 2025; Centrical, 2024). Arion Bank, operating in the conservative financial sector, partnered with Attensi to introduce replayable simulations that allowed new hires to practice real tasks in a safe environment. This approach closed knowledge gaps by up to 95% and generated high enthusiasm among participants, aligning with the Job Demands-Resources model by lowering stress and increasing support resources (Attensi, n.d.). By contrast, Sofigate launched a year-long 'Sofipoly' program aimed at strengthening culture and motivation. While it initially energised employees, issues such as unclear rules, excessive competition, and stress led to frustration and disengagement, showing the risks of poorly balanced gamification (Albi Research, 2025).

To better illustrate the contextual differences between the analysed organisations, key characteristics of the cases are summarised in Tab. 1.

Table 1. Contextual factors across case study organisations

Variable	WebHelp	Arion Bank	Sofigate
Industry sector	business process outsourcing (call centres, sales support)	retail banking and financial services	IT consulting and digital transformation
Organisation size	large multinational (> 50,000 employees globally)	medium-sized national (ca. 1,000 employees)	medium-sized Nordic consultancy (ca. 700 employees)
Job type/profile	frontline customer support and telesales roles	finance, admin, banking clerical roles	consulting, IT project management, hybrid/remote teams
Onboarding program format	short-term, centralized onboarding campaign with gamification	modular onboarding with autonomous, adaptive learning pathways	game-based onboarding tool (Sofipoly) embedded in broader onboarding process

Variable	WebHelp	Arion Bank	Sofigate
Gamification duration	one-off implementation over 6 weeks	continuous, iterative development by internal HR and training teams	ongoing programme, revised over time but implemented as a top-down system
Gamification origin	developed externally and integrated into onboarding	designed in-house by internal team with contextual knowledge	developed with external consultants; branded as a game-like platform
Perceived strengths	high engagement, fast adoption, alignment with digital pace	psychological safety, autonomy, reduced onboarding anxiety	initial interest and novelty; recognition for innovation
Reported challenges/ weaknesses	limited longevity: impact declined post-campaign	maintenance demands; required internal expertise	ambiguity of rules, competitive stress, mismatch with employee expectations
Observed organisational fit	high: gamification matched pace, incentives, and communication style	high: gamification supported values of trust and individual development	low: gamification perceived as controlling; failed to address deeper work issues

Source: own elaboration.

Taken together, these cases highlight that gamification can significantly improve onboarding when well designed and culturally aligned, as in Webhelp and Arion Bank, but may backfire if perceived as controlling or unfair, as shown by Sofigate. Their outcomes confirm that success depends less on the number of mechanisms and more on their quality, transparency, and integration with organisational values.

5.5. Key Insights

The analyses showed that employees participating in onboarding with gamification elements declared a higher level of engagement than those undergoing the process in its traditional form. At the same time, no correlation was found between the length of onboarding or the number of mechanisms used and the level of engagement, suggesting that effectiveness is determined more by the quality and suitability of the tools than by their quantity or the duration of the process. Case studies have also shown that gamification can have very different outcomes from complete success to mixed results to failure which highlights the importance of proper design and organisational context.

6. Conclusions

The research confirms that gamification can be an effective tool for supporting the onboarding process and building employee engagement. Quantitative analysis showed that people participating in onboarding programmes that included gamification elements reported higher levels of engagement rather than those who went through the traditional onboarding process. Complementary case studies confirmed that well-designed solutions based on gamification mechanisms can shorten adaptation time, increase motivation and improve learning effectiveness. At the same time, the results indicate that the length of the process or the number of elements used do not directly translate into the level of engagement, suggesting that the quality and suitability of the program to the participants' needs play a key role. However, certain limitations of the study should be kept in mind. First, the sample was relatively small (56 people) and diverse in terms of industries, which limits the possibility of generalising the results. In addition, the data was collected in the form of a retrospective online survey, which carries the risk of subjectivity and simplification in the responses. In addition to the fact that the case studies are based on materials provided by the suppliers, this means that all results should be considered as illustrative examples and not as definitive evidence. Despite these limitations, the results obtained are of significant value both for HR practice and scientific research. They show that gamification can effectively support the adaptation process of new employees, if it is implemented in a thoughtful manner and embedded in the organisational culture. In the future, it would be worthwhile to conduct longitudinal studies to assess the long-term impact of gamification on maintaining engagement. Future research should also extend the analyses to larger and more homogeneous samples and to compare the effects in different industries, time frames and employee characteristics. This approach will provide a better understanding of the conditions under which gamification in onboarding brings the greatest benefits and how to design solutions that are not only attractive but also effective in building engagement.

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Grywalizacja jako element kształtowania zaangażowania kadr w procesie adaptacji zawodowej

Streszczenie: Rosnące wykorzystanie grywalizacji w zarządzaniu zasobami ludzkimi stwarza pytania o jej rolę w kluczowych procesach, takich jak onboarding. Większość istniejących badań koncentruje się na edukacji, szkoleniach lub marketingu, podczas gdy onboardingowi jako ustrukturyzowanemu procesowi poświęcono dotychczas niewiele uwagi. Autorka zbadała, w jaki sposób grywalizacja wpływa na zaangażowanie pracowników podczas onboardingu w porównaniu z podejściem tradycyjnym. Zaangażowanie mierzono za pomocą skali UWES-9, a dane analizowano w oprogramowaniu JASP, aby zapewnić rzetelność wyników. W celu nakreślenia kontekstu badanie uzupełniono o trzy studia przypadków organizacji, które wdrożyły grywalizację w procesie adaptacji zawodowej. Wyniki pokazują, że grywalizacja sprzyja wyższemu poziomowi zaangażowania niż metody tradycyjne. Jednak ani czas trwania onboardingu, ani liczba zastosowanych mechanizmów nie okazały się istotne. Kluczowe znaczenie miały jakość i adekwatność rozwiązań. Badanie podkreśla, że skuteczna grywalizacja nie polega na samej liczbie dodanych punktów, odznak czy zadań, lecz na tym, czy projekt faktycznie wspiera potrzeby pracowników. Dobrze przeprowadzona grywalizacja może być czymś więcej niż tylko modnym trendem – staje się praktycznym narzędziem budowania motywacji, integracji i trwałego zaangażowania już od pierwszych dni w pracy.

Słowa kluczowe: grywalizacja, onboarding pracownika, zaangażowanie pracownika, socjalizacja organizacyjna, motywacja do pracy

Debiuty studenckie
Student debuts

DOI: 10.15611/2026.35.7.04
JEL Classification: M12, M14

The Impact of Organisational Culture on Job Satisfaction

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Quote as: Narajewska, M. (2026). The Impact of Organisational Culture on Job Satisfaction. In J. Radomska, & A. Witek-Crabb (Eds.), *New Trends in Business Management. Culture, Strategy, Engagement* (pp. 41-51). Publishing House of Wroclaw University of Economics and Business.

Abstract: The purpose of this study is to determine the impact of organisational culture and job satisfaction. The quantitative study surveyed individuals holding various positions in various companies. The anonymous survey aimed to obtain the most reliable information possible about organisational culture and job satisfaction. The study results indicate that organisational culture does indeed have a significant impact on job satisfaction. A strong, positive organisational culture not only increases job satisfaction but also contributes to employee retention and overall better organisational performance. The study concludes with recommendations for leaders and managers who want to build a culture that promotes engagement, loyalty, and satisfaction in the workplace.

Keywords: organisational culture, job satisfaction, management

1. Introduction

Recently, job satisfaction has become an increasingly important topic for organisations, regardless of whether public or private (Gastearena-Balda et al., 2021; Joshi & Bhatt, 2024). This is largely due to changes in the labour market, including the growing popularity of remote work, increased flexibility, the expectations of new generations (Y, Z), and the growing emphasis on mental health and well-being. Modern organisations are beginning to understand that intangible factors, such as leadership style, communication, team relationships, and shared values, can significantly impact how employees perceive their work and how well they perform it (Gastearena-Balda et al., 2021; Joshi & Bhatt, 2024). These elements significantly influence how employees perceive their work and their overall performance. Organisational culture lies at the heart of these phenomena, strongly influencing job satisfaction in various aspects, both motivational and emotional (Putra et al., 2025).

This chapter examines the relationship between two important and complex organisational phenomena: organisational culture and job satisfaction. Although each of these concepts has been extensively studied separately by numerous researchers, e.g. (Wu et al., 2003; Schein, 2004), the purpose of this study is to analyse their interactions and influence on each other practically and measurably. By examining this relationship, the study aims to determine which elements of organisational culture have the greatest impact on employee satisfaction and how changes in culture can lead to increased effectiveness and efficiency. The analysis presents both positive and negative relationships between various variables and indicates which factors have the strongest influence. It also examines whether leadership and management styles influence organisational culture and employee satisfaction. The study is based on both the literature and own empirical research which was conducted through a quantitative survey using the CAWI method (n = 42), focusing on employees working in different positions.

By combining theory with real-world data, this chapter provides useful insights for both researchers and practitioners. It emphasises the importance of fostering an open and supportive organisational culture as a crucial factor in enhancing employee satisfaction, motivation, and long-term commitment.

2. Theoretical Background

2.1. Organisational Culture

Organisational culture is a concept that combines several disciplines, including anthropology, sociology, social psychology, and management science (Smircich, 1983; Schein, 2010).

Anthropologists often claim that organisations are cultures, whereas sociologists argue that organisations have cultures (Collins et al., 1989). Nevertheless, in both views, culture is perceived as a set of beliefs, norms, assumptions, and shared values that particular members of an organisation perform. Each organisation creates its own culture, which is designed by individuals who have different experiences, values, and expectations. Since the 1980s, more attention has been paid to how culture affects work results, which has largely influenced the change in the perception of enterprise management and introduced the concept of organisational culture (Chen, 2022). Structural changes, social interactions, and negotiations ensure that culture remains a dynamic entity, not a static one, constantly evolving through the process of meaning-making and socialisation (Alvesson, 2013; Denison et al., 2014). This dynamic nature is explained by the fact that individuals seek meaning through interactions in specific contexts. For example, the meaning of managerial authority is shaped and redefined by cultural norms, power relations, and everyday practices. Organisational culture, therefore, provides a framework within which such meanings are negotiated, facilitating coordination and interaction among organisational members (Patriotta & Brown, 2011; Alvesson, 2013).

Special attention deserves the concept of Schein—he defines organisational culture in the most general and wide way as "a pattern of shared basic assumptions learned by a group as it solved its problems of external adaptation and internal integration, which has worked well enough to be considered valid and, therefore, to be taught to new members as the correct way to perceive, think, and feel in relation to those problems" (Schein, 2010, p. 18). Similarly, Hofstede et al. (2010, p. 6) describe culture as "the collective programming of the mind" that distinguishes one group from another, and emphasise cultural dimensions that influence work behaviours across societies.

Cameron and Quinn (2015, pp. 34-38) contributed to the creation of the organisational culture model which they called the Cameron and Quinn Competing Values Framework (CVF). The model categorises organisational culture into four types: Clan Culture, Adhocracy Culture, Market Culture, and Hierarchy Culture. The framework is widely used in organisations to diagnose and transform organisational culture, thereby improving performance and job satisfaction.

2.2. Job Satisfaction

Job satisfaction integrates psychological, physiological, and environmental components. Hoppock (1935) defined it as "any combination of psychological, physiological, and environmental circumstances that cause a person truthfully to say I am satisfied with my job" (as cited in Aziri, 2011). Spector (1997, p. 12) defines job satisfaction as "a global feeling about the job or a related constellation of attitudes about various aspects or facets of the job". In general, job satisfaction is considered a core element of organisational behaviour and employee performance, reflecting the sense of achievement and fulfilment one derives from their work.

Understanding what drives satisfaction is crucial, as it directly influences motivation, well-being, and organisational effectiveness. Researchers distinguish between intrinsic and extrinsic sources of satisfaction. Intrinsic factors are internal and relate to psychological needs such as achievement, responsibility, recognition, or interest in the work itself (Goetz et al., 2012; Herzberg et al., 1959). Extrinsic factors, by contrast, include external job conditions such as salary, supervision quality, workplace policies, and working conditions (Goetz et al., 2012).

Herzberg's Two-Factor Theory remains one of the most influential models in this domain (Herzberg et al., 1959). According to this theory, hygiene factors (e.g., pay, company policies, working conditions) can prevent and decrease dissatisfaction but do not lead to satisfaction. In contrast, motivators (e.g., advancement, responsibility, recognition) lead to genuine satisfaction. Importantly, Herzberg argued that the absence of dissatisfaction is not the same as satisfaction, and vice versa. This concept challenged earlier theories that viewed satisfaction and dissatisfaction as being on a single continuum (Herzberg et al., 1959; Herzberg, 2003).

Other scholars have highlighted the broader psychosocial aspects of job satisfaction. Spector (1997) noted that job satisfaction is not only about the job itself but also about how employees perceive their environment, relationships, and opportunities for personal development. Factors such as family, health, or personal beliefs can significantly influence satisfaction levels, even if unrelated to professional tasks (Dion, 2006; Timmreck, 2001).

More recent studies continue to support this dual-factor framework. For example, 2023 study by researchers from Antalya Bilim University developed a scale to measure job satisfaction across industries. The model included 12 fundamental indicators categorised into internal (e.g., personal interest, development opportunities) and external (e.g., salary, safety, working conditions) factors, confirming that both dimensions are essential in assessing overall satisfaction levels (Tab. 1).

Table 1. Job satisfaction scale development

		Strongly disagree	Disagree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly agree
Dimension 1 – Internal Satisfaction						
1	I enjoy doing my job.					
2	I like my colleagues.					
3	I am satisfied with the attitude and behaviour of managers toward me.					
4	I have the opportunity to use all my skills at work.					
5	I am satisfied with the success I achieve in my job.					
6	I feel motivated when doing my job.					
Dimension 2 – External Satisfaction						
1	I am satisfied with the salary and benefits related to my job.					
2	I am satisfied with the promotion opportunities at my workplace.					
3	I find the reward system at my workplace fair.					
4	I am satisfied with the working conditions at my workplace.					
5	I feel safe at my workplace.					
6	The working hours and flexibility at my workplace make me feel free.					

Source: own study based on (Çalişkan & Köroğlu, 2023).

2.3. Relationship Between Organisational Culture and Job Satisfaction – a Review of the Previous Studies

The relationship between organisational culture and job satisfaction has been extensively researched; however, previous studies have not taken into account the perspectives of new generations and the impact of post-pandemic changes.

Organisational culture, defined as the shared values, norms, and beliefs within an organisation, significantly affects employee attitudes. A positive culture can enhance satisfaction, while a negative one may lead to dissatisfaction and turnover (Nystrom, 1993). According to Lund (2003), some cultural characteristics are more impactful than others. For example, strong cultures are often associated with higher job satisfaction (Nystrom, 1993), whereas Chang and Lee (2007) found that organisational culture alone may not directly affect satisfaction unless supported by continuous learning and adaptability. Wu et al. (2003) identified values such as respect, innovation, and stability as key contributors to satisfaction. Gifford et al. (2002) emphasised the importance of interpersonal factors, such as empathy, leadership, morale, and trust, suggesting that human-relations-based cultures foster stronger employee satisfaction. Doughty et al. (2002) further noted that job involvement, support from superiors, and autonomy are decisive mediators of this relationship.

Schein (2010) highlighted the dynamic interaction between leadership and culture, with leaders both shaping and being shaped by culture. Brown (1992) noted that effective leaders must address cultural barriers to improve organisational performance. Leadership style, transformational or transactional, plays a vital role in influencing employee satisfaction and organisational dynamics.

Job satisfaction is affected by intrinsic and extrinsic factors, including development opportunities, work relationships, and a sense of belonging. Task- and people-oriented cultures promote satisfaction related to growth and creativity, while hierarchical or bureaucratic cultures tend to enhance the sense of security but may reduce opportunities for self-expression and belonging (Jo et al., 1999; Odom et al., 1990).

Improving organisational culture and job satisfaction requires intentional strategies such as promoting open communication, enabling employee autonomy, encouraging collaboration, and maintaining regular feedback. Positive employee experiences built on mutual respect and supportive leadership significantly influence workplace satisfaction and organisational performance (Koustelios, 1991; Denison et al., 2014; Lund, 2003).

In conclusion, organisational culture has a significant impact on job satisfaction. While the specific mechanisms may vary, alignment between cultural values and employee needs remains central to fostering a motivated and committed workforce.

3. Research Methodology

The study was conducted among individual entities in various sectors and industries across the Republic of Poland. The survey questions were delivered via multiple sources, email and WhatsApp. The impact of organisational culture on job satisfaction was evaluated through a systematic, descriptive approach. Organisational culture was treated as the independent variable and operationalised through respondents' perceptions of key cultural dimensions, including communication, leadership style, shared values, organisational support, and interpersonal relationships. Job satisfaction was treated as the dependent variable and operationalised as overall satisfaction with work, encompassing aspects such as working conditions, interpersonal relationships, recognition, and personal fulfilment. The analytical approach was descriptive, summarising respondents' ratings using frequencies, percentages, and mean scores. This approach allowed for the identification of trends, patterns, and variation in perceptions across demographic groups, such as gender, generation, and education. Interpretation criteria for the results were based on the distribution of responses: higher and mean scores indicated a stronger positive perception of organisational culture or higher job satisfaction, while lower scores indicated neutral or negative perceptions.

Table 2 presents basic information about the respondents. The sample size consisted of 42 individuals, providing insight into how individuals perceive cultural factors and their impact on workplace well-being.

Table 2. Characteristics of respondents

Gender		Generation		Work experience		Type of company	
Women	57.1%	X	33.3%	over 5 years	35.7%	public	31%
Men	42.9%	Y	23.8%	over 3 to 5 years	11.9%	private	69%
		Z	42.9%	over 1 to 3 years	21.4%		
				up to 1 year	31%		

Source: own elaboration.

Variables included in the gender, generation, and education sections were measured using a nominal scale, based on Stevens' (1946) theory of measurement scales. It allows respondents to be classified into distinct categories without any specific order.

4. Results

One of the most striking and surprising findings was the overall positive perception of organisational culture among participants. Most respondents described their workplace culture as average, high, or very high, with no indication of a very low level of culture. At the same time, most respondents reported being satisfied or very satisfied with their current job. This suggests that even if culture is not perceived as perfect, as long as it meets certain expectations regarding interpersonal relationships, communication, and leadership, it can significantly contribute to job satisfaction.

Essentially, respondents largely agreed with the statement that organisational culture influences job satisfaction (90.4%), with only a small percentage expressing disagreement or indifference. This consensus reinforces the assumption that organisational culture should be considered a strategic area of management. Culture is not an abstract or secondary concept; rather, it directly shapes the emotional engagement, motivation, and long-term loyalty of employees. One of the dominant themes emerging from the survey was the importance of interpersonal relationships in organisations. The majority of respondents emphasised that relationships with colleagues and the atmosphere within teams (69%) have a strong impact on their job satisfaction. Collaboration, open communication, and teamwork were consistently cited as the most satisfying aspects of organisational culture. In contrast, toxic relationships (88.1%), lack of respect (45.2%), and unfair treatment (61.9%) were identified as the most important factors leading employees to consider changing jobs or leaving altogether. This link between positive and negative factors underscores the fundamental role of interpersonal interactions in defining culture.

Respondents also identified key areas for improvement in organisational culture. Improving communication and transparency were most frequently cited as changes that could increase job satisfaction. Similarly, many respondents expressed a desire for greater recognition of achievements (54.8%), both financial and verbal, through rewards. Leadership style was another recurring factor—employees expect more supportive, engaged, and committed management. These expectations emphasize the need for human-centred leadership that goes beyond control and supervision and instead creates an inclusive and motivating environment.

The study also revealed generational differences in expectations for organisational culture. Generation X was most sensitive to fairness, interpersonal respect, and the absence of toxic behaviour within teams. Generation Y further emphasised the need for clear communication and effective work organisation, while Generation Z highlighted the importance of development opportunities as a key element of culture. This generational divide suggests that organisations should adopt a flexible approach, adapting cultural practices and management strategies to the evolving expectations of younger employees while maintaining core values such as respect and integrity.

Gender differences also emerged. Women participating in the study were significantly more likely to be critical of organisational culture and its impact on satisfaction. They were more likely to choose neutral or negative responses and tended to rate the culture as average. Men, on the other hand, were generally more satisfied with workplace culture and its impact on their well-being. This may indicate discrepancies in how different genders perceive workplace culture, potentially due to unequal treatment, differences in expectations, or the degree of integration. The results suggest that it might be prudent to adapt HR policies that take gender into account, and inclusive leadership could be essential to ensuring cultural equality.

There is a noticeable relationship between length of service and employees' assessments of organisational culture. Employees with less than one year of experience assess organisational culture more positively. This likely stems from initial optimism about their work and onboarding experiences. As employment time increases to 1-3 years, ratings become somewhat more moderate. Although positive ratings remain, the first signs of dissatisfaction begin to emerge. This suggests that after the initial phase, employees begin to recognise organisational flaws more clearly. Employees with 3-5 years of experience show a concentration of "average" responses, with none rating the organisational culture as "high". This may indicate a retention of satisfaction or growing chagrin midway through their careers. The group with more than 5 years of experience shows the greatest variation in responses, ranging from "very high" to "low". This division suggests that long-time employees either become deeply integrated and see value in the culture or become increasingly dissatisfied over time. It is important to note that employees' expectations evolve, as does their critical perspective. Such mixed responses may be due to varying employee expectations and their current length of service. Organisations should prioritise employees within the 3-5-year employment period, as this appears to be a crucial stage in which satisfaction levels decline. Appropriate steps should be taken at this time to provide development opportunities or recognition. This should positively impact the organisational culture and prevent employee turnover. This data highlights the importance of ongoing organisational culture management, rather than one-time interventions.

Another aspect considered in the study was the type and size of the organisation. Incidentally, responses showed some variability across workplaces, both in the private and public sectors. While public sector employees demonstrated greater stability and consistency in their job satisfaction levels, private sector employees presented more polarised responses—ranging from very satisfied to dissatisfied. Although the sample size does not allow for definitive conclusions, this may suggest that private companies, potentially due to their dynamic and competitive environment, face greater challenges in building a consistently positive organisational culture. Work experience, education level, and company size did not significantly differentiate the results.

This may indicate that the perception of culture and its impact on satisfaction is largely universal, regardless of length of service or formal qualifications. What matters most is how employees are treated, how clear information is communicated, and whether the culture fosters collaboration, recognition, and development.

5. Conclusions

The purpose of this study was to examine the relationship between organisational culture and job satisfaction.

The analysis confirms that elements such as workplace atmosphere, interpersonal relationships, communication, and management style have a real and direct impact on employee satisfaction. Organisational culture is not an abstract concept, but a powerful force that shapes the daily experiences, engagement, and loyalty of employees. It should not be ignored or minimised. Even a momentary lack of attention to organisational culture can impact the health and functioning of an organisation. However, several limitations of the study should be noted, as they have significant implications for the reception and interpretation of the results. The results are based on the subjective opinions of employees from specific companies, making generalisations difficult.

Furthermore, the study covered only a single point in time, limiting its ability to reflect the dynamic nature of organisational culture, which requires significant time to build, define, and then nurture. Future research could benefit from a broader scope, incorporating both quantitative and qualitative methods across industries and organisational levels, as well as longitudinal approaches to better observe cultural change over time.

Despite these limitations, the results provide valuable insights and practical recommendations for managers, emphasising the importance of cultivating a positive organisational culture as a foundation for employee satisfaction and long-term organisational success.

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Wpływ kultury organizacji na satysfakcję z pracy

Streszczenie: Celem niniejszego badania jest określenie wpływu kultury organizacyjnej na satysfakcję z pracy. W badaniu ilościowym udział wzięły osoby zajmujące różne stanowiska w rozmaitych przedsiębiorstwach. Anonimowa ankieta miała na celu uzyskanie jak najbardziej rzetelnych informacji na temat badanych zjawisk. Wyniki wskazują, że kultura organizacyjna ma istotny wpływ na zadowolenie pracowników. Silna, pozytywna kultura nie tylko zwiększa satysfakcję z pracy, ale także przyczynia się do zatrzymania pracowników oraz poprawy ogólnej efektywności organizacji. Badanie kończy się rekomendacjami dla liderów i menedżerów, którzy chcą budować kulturę sprzyjającą zaangażowaniu, lojalności i satysfakcji w miejscu pracy.

Słowa kluczowe: kultura organizacji, satysfakcja z pracy, zarządzanie

Debiuty studenckie
Student debuts

DOI: 10.15611/2026.35.7.05
JEL Classification: D12, M31

Intergenerational Drivers of Consumption Behaviour: A Socio-Economic Analysis in Emerging Markets

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Quote as: Nyatanga, L. T. (2026). Intergenerational Drivers of Consumption Behaviour: A Socio-Economic Analysis in Emerging Markets. In J. Radomska, & A. Witek-Crabb (Eds.), *New Trends in Business Management. Culture, Strategy, Engagement* (pp. 52-64). Publishing House of Wroclaw University of Economics and Business.

Abstract: Understanding consumption behaviour is essential for both economic policy and business strategy. In emerging markets, consumption patterns are increasingly influenced by intergenerational factors, reflecting a complex interplay of social, cultural, and economic forces. This study investigates the drivers of intergenerational consumption behaviour, examining how parental influence, cultural norms, economic transitions, and exposure to global trends shape purchasing decisions across generations in the apparel industry. This study employs a mixed-methods approach, combining quantitative survey data from 152 respondents with qualitative thematic analysis to explore these dynamics. The findings indicate that while older generations prioritise durability and quality, younger cohorts (Millennials and Generation Z) are driven by affordability, sustainability, and digital trends. The results reveal a significant gap between stated ethical preferences and actual purchasing behaviour, often moderated by economic constraints. This research provides critical insights for retailers and policymakers, highlighting the need for targeted, generation-specific strategies that balance tradition and modernity in rapidly evolving economic contexts.

Keywords: intergenerational consumption, emerging markets, consumer behaviour, socio-economic analysis, apparel industry, sustainable consumption

1. Introduction

Consumption behaviour is not merely an economic activity but a profound reflection of socio-cultural dynamics, individual preferences, and inherited social norms that shape societies across generations. A substantial body of research demonstrates that consumption patterns are socially constructed and transmitted through family structures, where values, preferences, and purchasing habits are observed, internalised, and reproduced over time (Guillemot, 2018; Lien et al., 2018). In this sense, consumption functions as both an economic and a social practice, embedding cultural continuity while simultaneously adapting to changing structural conditions.

In the contemporary global landscape, emerging markets have become critical arenas of economic and social transformation, characterised by rapid urbanisation, income stratification, and accelerated technological diffusion. These forces significantly reshape consumption behaviour by altering access to markets, exposure to global brands, and modes of purchasing, particularly through the expansion of digital commerce (Gallipoli et al., 2020; Lim et al., 2023). As a result, traditional intergenerational transmission of consumption norms is increasingly disrupted, giving rise to hybrid consumption patterns that combine inherited values with globally mediated influences.

Understanding the intergenerational drivers of consumption behaviour in emerging markets is therefore essential for both academic inquiry and practical decision-making. Prior research suggests that generational cohorts respond differently to economic uncertainty, social influence, and ethical considerations, reflecting variations in income stability, cultural capital, and digital literacy (Diprose et al., 2019; Mazumder, 2018). These differences are particularly pronounced in sectors where consumption is closely tied to identity and social signalling, such as the apparel industry, making it a critical context for examining how consumption norms evolve across generations.

2. Theoretical Background

The study of intergenerational consumption behaviour is an inherently multidisciplinary field, drawing axiomatic insights from economics, sociology, and psychology to elucidate how purchasing decisions are formulated, transmitted, and recalibrated across generations. This research integrates several key theoretical paradigms to contextualise consumption patterns within the dynamic and often paradoxical environment of emerging markets.

2.1. Core Theoretical Frameworks

To comprehensively analyse intergenerational consumption, this study is anchored in several foundational perspectives. Behavioural economics provides a critical lens by challenging the classical assumption of a purely rational consumer. It posits that psychological factors and cognitive heuristics such as bounded rationality, emotional reactions, and susceptibility to cognitive biases significantly affect decision-making. In the apparel industry of emerging markets, this is particularly evident among younger consumers influenced by the ephemeral allure of fast fashion. Research demonstrates that young consumers often engage in excessive spending due to marketing strategies that exploit these biases and leverage societal pressures for social acceptance, often overpowering practical financial planning (Cui et al., 2022; Jiang & Ananthachari, 2023).

This psychological dimension is complemented by social learning theory which demonstrates how behaviours are shaped through observation and imitation, with the family unit acting as the primary agent of consumer socialisation. Parental influences are powerful in shaping attitudes toward apparel through direct modelling and family traditions surrounding purchasing (Guillemot, 2018). This is further reinforced by cultural capital theory which explains how non-economic assets like social norms, education, and traditions dictate consumption priorities. This often manifests in a generational dichotomy, where older generations may emphasise functional, traditional clothing, while younger cohorts gravitate toward individualistic and status-driven fashion choices (Liang et al., 2024).

Furthermore, intergenerational mobility theory illuminates how economic opportunity or the lack thereof shapes aspirational consumption, as upwardly mobile families often shift spending toward higher-end apparel to reflect a change in social strata (Emran & Shilpi, 2019). The consumption behaviour of individuals is strongly influenced by systemic economic factors, which explains part of the persistence of income inequality across generations (Gallipoli et al., 2020; Mazumder, 2018). Finally, the contemporary paradigm of sustainability and generational responsibility has become a crucial analytical lens. This concept addresses the imperative to meet current needs without compromising the resources of future generations (Mladjan & Marković, 2021). Younger generations in emerging markets are often more conscious of sustainable fashion, driven by a greater awareness of environmental degradation (Minh & Quynh, 2024). However, a notable friction exists between this aspirational eco-consciousness and the exigent constraints of affordability, creating a complex 'attitude-behaviour gap' that this study explores (Diprose et al., 2019).

2.2. Key Socio-Economic and Social Drivers

These theoretical drivers are activated by a range of potent socio-economic and social forces. Economic drivers such as acute income and wealth inequality create disparate spending habits and priorities. Macroeconomic volatility, including high inflation and currency fluctuations, erodes purchasing power and can instil cautious spending habits that persist across generations. Rapid urbanisation acts as a powerful catalyst, exposing younger, migratory consumers to global trends, digital commerce, and new lifestyle aspirations that often diverge sharply from their rural origins (Shah & Asghar, 2023). Social drivers are equally formative. The influence of family dynamics, particularly in collectivist cultures where shared purchasing decisions are common, serves as a powerful force for normative continuity (Lien et al., 2018). Conversely, the power of peer influence, significantly amplified by the proliferation of digital platforms and social media, can either reinforce or radically challenge these inherited norms, accelerating the adoption of new consumption patterns among younger cohorts (Essiz & Mandrik, 2022).

2.3. Generational Consumption Trends in the Apparel Market

This complex amalgamation of forces has resulted in distinct consumption proclivities across four key generational cohorts, which retailers must navigate.

- Baby Boomers (born 1946-1964) represent a consumer base characterised by strong brand loyalty and a preference for quality, durability, and craftsmanship over fleeting trends (Maguire, 2025). They are likely to invest in premium, lasting clothing and often favour the tactile, service-oriented experience of traditional in-store retail (Cunningham & De Meyer-Heydenrych, 2021).
- Generation X (born 1965-1980) exhibits a pragmatic, hybrid of digital and traditional shopping habits. As discerning and price-sensitive consumers, they value both online convenience for research and the in-store experience for validation, seeking high-quality apparel at a reasonable price (Dabija et al., 2017) and showing a growing interest in ethically produced brands (Gupta et al., 2019).
- Millennials (born 1981-1996) are a dominant, digitally-fluent market force, prioritising stylish, sustainable, and highly personalised experiences (Napalai & Khamwon, 2023). As ethically minded consumers, they rely heavily on online shopping platforms, peer reviews, and influencer endorsements, and are often willing to pay a premium for brands that align with their values on sustainability and fair labour practices (Cham et al., 2018).
- Generation Z (born 1997-2012) are digital natives who demand authenticity, personalisation, and social responsibility from brands. While attracted to the affordability and rapid cycles of fast fashion, they paradoxically expect brands to be transparent, inclusive, and ethically conscious (Cui et al., 2022), using visually-driven social media platforms like TikTok and Instagram as their primary channels for fashion discovery and inspiration (Dabija et al., 2017).

3. Methodology

This study employed a mixed-methods research design, combining quantitative and qualitative approaches to provide both statistical breadth and contextual depth to the analysis of intergenerational consumption. For the quantitative component, data was collected using a custom-designed electronic survey, which was peer-reviewed for content relevance and clarity prior to distribution. The questionnaire's structure was informed by existing literature on consumer behaviour and intergenerational influences (Liang et al., 2024; Mazumder, 2018). The survey, administered via Google Forms and distributed directly to participants through email and SMS, targeted 200 individuals in emerging markets, ultimately yielding 152 completed responses for a 76% response rate. The instrument was composed of 19 structured questions that utilised a variety of formats, including multiple-choice, Likert-scale, and ranking questions, to systematically measure economic influences, generational apparel preferences, and specific spending habits. The collected data was subsequently analysed using the SPSS statistical package. Descriptive statistics were used to summarise purchasing patterns, while regression and correlation analyses were employed to identify and evaluate the key economic and social factors that predict spending behaviour across the different generational cohorts, including associations between sustainability considerations and purchasing choices (Diprose et al., 2019).

To add nuanced understanding and explanatory power to the statistical findings, the qualitative component of the study analysed responses from seven open-ended questions (questions 20-26) that were included at the end of the same electronic survey. This approach allowed for the collection of rich, textual data regarding consumer motivations, perceptions of retailers, and personal concerns related to sustainability in their own words. The responses were systematically analysed using NVivo software, following a bottom-up, inductive thematic analysis approach. This data-driven method ensured that themes emerged directly from the participant narratives rather than being forced into pre-assigned categories. To enhance the transparency and trustworthiness of the analysis, a codebook was developed to organize the findings, and key themes—such as the prominent concern for sustainability among younger generations (Liang et al., 2024) were substantiated with representative verbatim quotations drawn directly from participant responses. For example, the theme of affordability was clearly illustrated by direct statements from respondents, such as “Financial situation influences my fashion decisions a lot”. By integrating these two methodologies, the research was able to effectively triangulate findings, ensuring that the statistical trends were explained and enriched by the lived experiences of consumers.

4. Results

The most cited challenge was Pricing & Affordability, with 28 coding references highlighting how economic constraints dictate purchasing power. Participants noted that fluctuating exchange rates and inflation make apparel a luxury for many households. Other significant themes included Economic Shifts and Their Influence, where participants reported delaying nonessential purchases during downturns, and The Role of Sustainability, where the high price of ethical products was often noted as a barrier to adoption.

The analysis of the data revealed significant and nuanced patterns in intergenerational consumption, highlighting the profound influence of economic conditions and shifting generational values on purchasing behaviour within the apparel industry. The quantitative findings provide a statistical backbone for understanding consumer habits, while the qualitative results offer deep, contextual insights into the motivations and challenges consumers face.

4.1. Quantitative Findings

The descriptive statistics from the 152 survey respondents painted a clear demographic and behavioural picture of the consumer landscape. Demographically, Millennials (aged 25-39) constituted the largest and most influential segment at 42.1**%** of respondents, followed by Generation X (19.7%) and Baby Boomers (11.8%), confirming that younger generations are the biggest buyers influencing market trends (Liang et al., 2024). The employment status of participants was varied, with 35.5% employed full-time and 25.0% self-employed, indicating diverse financial capabilities and spending potential (Gallipoli et al., 2020). Shopping preferences revealed a reliance on traditional retail, with 44.7% of consumers preferring in-store shopping, while only 15.1% shopped exclusively online; 48.0% of respondents indicated that their shopping choices are influenced by friends. When rating the importance of factors in purchasing decisions, a clear prioritization of practical concerns was evident. Price (Mean = 4.03) and Quality (Mean = 4.18) were rated as the most critical considerations across all generations, substantially outranking factors like Brand (Mean = 3.59), Sustainability (Mean = 3.47), and Trendiness (Mean = 3.41).

The inferential statistical analysis provided deeper insights into the drivers of spending. The regression analysis, while showing a relatively low overall explanatory power (R^2 = 0.151), identified two predictors as statistically significant. A preference for formal wear emerged as a significant predictor of higher monthly apparel spending (p = .012), suggesting that consumers who prioritise professional or occasion-based attire as a symbol of identity make more substantial investments in their wardrobe (Guillemot, 2018; Dabijaet al., 2017). Furthermore, the generational adoption of new consumption patterns was also highly significant (p = .034), providing statistical evidence that younger consumers who embrace modern, digitally-integrated shopping habits shaped by peer trends and online platforms tend to spend more (Jiang & Ananthachari, 2023; Lien et al., 2018). Reinforcing this, the correlation analysis revealed a moderate positive relationship between household income and apparel spending (r = 0.397), which is consistent with literature indicating that greater financial capacity directly impacts purchasing decisions in emerging markets (Cunningham & De Meyer-Heydenrych, 2021). In a noteworthy finding, factors often assumed to be highly influential such as sustainability/ethical production, family influence, and peer influence did not show a statistically significant direct impact on the *amount* of monthly spending within the regression model, pointing to a complex dynamic where stated values do not always translate directly into expenditure (Cui et al., 2022).

4.2. Qualitative Findings

The thematic analysis of open-ended responses provided rich, contextual depth to the quantitative data, revealing the lived experiences behind the statistics. Several salient themes emerged from the analysis. The most prevalent theme was the multi-faceted challenges consumers face when shopping for apparel, as summarised in Fig. 1.

Fig. 1. Challenges in apparel shopping in emerging markets

Source: own elaboration based on survey results.

While the diagram shows many issues, the most frequently cited challenge was Pricing & Affordability, with 28 coding references highlighting how severe economic constraints dictate purchasing power, often trumping other attributes (Cham et al., 2018). Participants consistently noted that fluctuating exchange rates and high inflation make apparel a luxury, a sentiment captured in direct quotes like, "Financial situation influences my fashion decisions a lot". Beyond cost, respondents also expressed significant frustration with inconsistent Quality Issues and Sizing & Fit Challenges, as well as a fundamental Lack of Trust & Security in online retail, particularly concerning counterfeit products and uncertain payment systems (Rahadi et al., 2022).

Another major theme identified was the Factors Influencing Apparel Choices Over Time, which reveals a clear evolution in consumer priorities throughout their lives, as illustrated in Fig. 2.

Fig. 2. Factors influencing apparel choices over time

Source: own elaboration based on survey results.

This theme underscores a distinct consumer journey. While younger consumers may initially be driven by trends and fashion, the data reveals a clear and consistent shift toward comfort over trends (21 coding references) and a greater appreciation for brand and quality evolution (27 references) as consumers age (Cho et al., 2015). Financial considerations remain a persistent influence throughout this journey. Critically, this theme also highlighted the complex role of sustainability and ethical considerations (26 references). While it emerged as a powerful and growing factor, particularly for younger generations (Dabija et al., 2017), it was often framed as an aspirational goal rather than a practical purchasing criterion. This dichotomy was frequently expressed, with respondents stating a desire for ethical products "I now choose eco-friendly fashion as I've become more aware" while simultaneously acknowledging that the high price of these goods remains the primary barrier to adoption, forcing a compromise between their values and their budget.

5. Discussion

The findings confirm that intergenerational consumption behaviour in emerging apparel markets is shaped by a dynamic and often conflicting interplay of deep-seated economic realities and evolving social values. The quantitative results underscore the continued dominance of practical factors like price and quality in driving consumer choice, while the qualitative data reveals a growing, albeit aspirational, interest in sustainability and ethical production. This section interprets these findings, exploring the strategic implications for retailers and the underlying reasons for the observable gap between consumer attitudes and their actual purchasing behaviour.

The statistically significant link between formal wear and higher spending suggests that apparel is still viewed as an important investment for professional and social identity, particularly among consumers with greater disposable income. This creates an opportunity for retailers to focus on premium, durable collections that appeal to this segment. At the same time, the significance of 'generational adoption' highlights the undeniable shift towards digital and trend-driven consumption led by Millennials and Gen Z. Retailers who fail to innovate their digital platforms through omnichannel strategies, AI-driven recommendations, and social media engagement risk becoming irrelevant to this powerful consumer base (Lim et al., 2023).

The research brings the strategic challenges for retailers into sharp focus. The price sensitivity of younger cohorts demands flexible pricing models, loyalty programs, and an emphasis on value (Cham et al., 2018). In contrast, older consumers (Baby Boomers and Gen X) are more willing to pay a premium for quality and brand heritage, valuing personalized customer service and trust over fleeting trends (Cunningham & De Meyer-Heydenrych, 2021). This generational divide necessitates a tiered product strategy, where retailers might offer budget-friendly or 'affordable luxury' lines to attract aspirational young customers while maintaining premium offerings for their established, more affluent base, thereby capturing a wider consumer base across socio-economic segments (Alves et al., 2020).

Furthermore, the findings on economic uncertainty reveal different levels of consumer resilience. Younger consumers demonstrate greater adaptability by pivoting to online platforms and affordable alternatives during economic downturns (Jiang & Ananthachari, 2023), whereas older generations with more accumulated wealth tend to maintain their purchasing habits (Gallipoli et al., 2020). This suggests that retailers need adaptive supply chains and dynamic pricing mechanisms to navigate the economic volatility inherent in emerging markets (Gupta et al., 2019).

Perhaps the most compelling finding is the pronounced attitude-behaviour gap regarding sustainability. While many respondents, especially younger ones, expressed a strong desire for eco-friendly and ethically produced fashion, the regression analysis showed that these factors were not significant predictors of actual spending. This gap is not due to a lack of awareness but is primarily driven by the economic constraints detailed in the qualitative findings (Minh & Quynh, 2024). The high price points of sustainable products, coupled with limited accessibility, create a significant barrier to widespread adoption (Gupta et al., 2019). For sustainable consumption to become mainstream in emerging markets, brands must innovate to make ethical products financially accessible to the average consumer, moving beyond a niche, premium positioning (Cui et al., 2022). This requires not only more efficient and localized production but also a commitment to educating consumers on the long-term value and benefits of their sustainable choices.

6. Conclusions

This study set out to examine the intergenerational drivers of consumption behaviour within the apparel industry in emerging markets, adopting a socio-economic perspective that integrates economic constraints, cultural transmission, and evolving generational values. The findings demonstrate that consumption behaviour remains strongly anchored in practical considerations such as price and quality, while simultaneously undergoing gradual transformation driven by globalisation, digitalisation, and heightened ethical awareness among younger generations. Although family structures continue to function as a foundational mechanism for transmitting consumption norms, these inherited patterns are increasingly reshaped by peer influence, online environments, and exposure to global fashion trends, particularly among Millennials and Generation Z.

The empirical results reveal a clear intergenerational divergence in consumption priorities. Older cohorts tend to emphasise durability, brand trust, and functional value, whereas younger consumers exhibit a complex negotiation between affordability, trend sensitivity, and aspirational sustainability. While sustainability and ethical production emerged as salient concerns in the qualitative analysis, the quantitative findings confirm a persistent attitude-behaviour gap, indicating that economic constraints in emerging markets frequently inhibit the translation of ethical intentions into actual purchasing behaviour. This tension underscores the continued dominance of structural economic conditions over normative values in shaping consumption outcomes.

Despite its contributions, this study is subject to several limitations. First, the research relies on a cross-sectional design and a sample of 152 respondents, which restricts the generalisability of the findings across all emerging markets. Second, the focus on the apparel industry, while analytically valuable due to its identity-related nature, limits the applicability of the results to other consumption categories such as technology, food, or services. Third, the use of self-reported survey data may be affected by social desirability bias, particularly in relation to sustainability and ethical consumption claims.

Future research could build upon these findings in several ways. Longitudinal studies would allow for a deeper examination of how consumption values evolve across the life course and in response to economic change. Comparative research focusing on specific emerging economies could further illuminate the role of institutional and cultural contexts in shaping intergenerational consumption dynamics. Additionally, incorporating in-depth qualitative interviews or ethnographic approaches could provide richer insights into the mechanisms underlying the observed attitude-behaviour gap, particularly in relation to sustainable consumption.

Overall, this study contributes to the literature by demonstrating that intergenerational consumption behaviour in emerging markets is shaped by an intricate interplay between inherited norms, economic realities, and generational adaptation. For retailers and policymakers alike, the findings highlight the necessity of developing strategies that acknowledge both value-driven aspirations and material constraints, thereby fostering more inclusive, realistic, and sustainable consumption pathways in rapidly transforming economic environments.

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Międzypokoleniowe czynniki kształtujące zachowania konsumpcyjne: analiza społeczno-ekonomiczna na rynkach wschodzących

Streszczenie: Zrozumienie zachowań konsumpcyjnych jest kluczowe zarówno dla polityki gospodarczej, jak i dla strategii biznesowych. Na rynkach wschodzących wzorce konsumpcji są coraz częściej kształtowane przez czynniki międzypokoleniowe, odzwierciedlając złożoną współzależność sił społecznych, kulturowych i ekonomicznych. Niniejsze badanie analizuje determinanty międzypokoleniowych zachowań konsumpcyjnych, badając, w jaki sposób wpływ rodziców, normy kulturowe, przemiany gospodarcze oraz ekspozycja na globalne trendy kształtują decyzje zakupowe różnych pokoleń w branży odzieżowej. W badaniu zastosowano podejście mieszane (*mixed-methods*), łączące ilościowe dane ankietowe od 152 respondentów z jakościową analizą tematyczną w celu zbadania tych zależności. Wyniki wskazują, że podczas gdy starsze pokolenia priorytetowo traktują trwałość i jakość produktów, młodsze kohorty (Millenialsi oraz pokolenie Z) kierują się przede wszystkim przystępnością cenową, zrównoważonym rozwojem oraz trendami cyfrowymi. Rezultaty ujawniają również istotną rozbieżność między deklarowanymi preferencjami etycznymi a rzeczywistymi zachowaniami zakupowymi, która często jest moderowana przez ograniczenia ekonomiczne. Badanie dostarcza istotnych wniosków dla sprzedawców detalicznych oraz decydentów politycznych, podkreślając potrzebę opracowania ukierunkowanych strategii dostosowanych do różnych pokoleń, które równoważą tradycję i nowoczesność w szybko zmieniającym się kontekście gospodarczym.

Słowa kluczowe: konsumpcja międzypokoleniowa, rynki wschodzące, zachowania konsumenckie, analiza społeczno-ekonomiczna, branża odzieżowa, zrównoważona konsumpcja

DOI: 10.15611/2026.35.7.06
JEL Classification: L31, M12, O15

Motivation and Engagement in a Student Non-Profit Organisation Based on Independent Students' Association (Niezależne Zrzeszenie Studentów)

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Quote as: Sikora, K. (2026). Motivation and Engagement in a Student Non-Profit Organisation Based on Independent Students' Association (Niezależne Zrzeszenie Studentów). In J. Radomska, & A. Witek-Crabb (Eds.), *New Trends in Business Management. Culture, Strategy, Engagement* (pp. 65-74). Publishing House of Wroclaw University of Economics and Business.

Abstract: This chapter presents an analysis of various motivational tools and methods used in the Independent Students' Association (NZS), which is the largest student-run non-profit organisation in Poland. The aim of the study was to understand the role of motivation and engagement in this specific environment and to identify the most effective and efficient ways to foster, develop, and maintain it among organisation members. The research was conducted using in-depth interviews (IDIs), a qualitative research technique in which a selected group of respondents is interviewed to gather different perspectives, experiences, and opinions on a particular topic, situation, or idea. The findings of the study provide a better understanding of motivational mechanisms in the NGO sector, can be applied to improve organisational practices, and serve as a solid basis for further academic research in this area.

Keywords: motivation, non-profit organisation, NZS, students

1. Introduction

Being a part of a non-profit organisation is related to constant ups and downs when it comes to motivation and engagement. Without any particular forms of remuneration, one has to gain the willingness to work from different factors. These can vary, depending on a person, for example, one human would rather focus on personal growth and gaining new skills, when other would prefer to focus more on meeting new people and integrating with them. The nature of non-profit organisations challenges well- known models of motivation, and because of that, a need for further examination is being created.

The aim of the study is to understand, analyse and juxtapose the motivational tools and methods that are being used in non-profit organisations, focusing on the Independent Students' Association (NZS). By doing so, the possibility of finding the biggest difficulties and their solutions appears. The choice of NZS was made because of it being the largest voluntarily-driven students' organisation in Poland, whose history dates back to 1980. Since then, hundreds of thousands of students have spent their university years by being engaged in various projects and activities which are either charitable, entertainable or substantive.

The following research questions were formulated:

- How can individuals be motivated without offering financial compensation?
- Do people define and perceive motivation differently depending on their personal experiences?
- In what ways can motivation and engagement be strengthened while excluding the aspect of remuneration?
- Which factors affect person's motivation and engagement, and what tools can be applied to enhance it?
- How can one sustain their own motivation and engagement over time?

All of these questions were explored in the context of a non-profit student organisation.

To examine the topic deeply, a method of in-depth interviews was chosen. Those interviews were conducted with the members of NZS, who held various positions and had to deal with motivating others and themselves. Focusing on members of Independent Students' Association gives the possibility of a better understanding of NGO's motivational tools and methods, and can help in further improvement.

2. Defining Motivation and Engagement in Non-Profit Organisations

Motivation has always been an intriguing topic for many researchers, yet its complexity always challenged them. Everyone has their own preferences when it comes to this phenomenon, so the perfect compromise does not exist.

Motivation (from Latin *motus*, *-us*) means to encourage, have an impact on someone, move from one place to another (Crozier, 1993). Many philosophers and psychologists has been researching this topic since the 19th century. At the beginning it was described as satisfying the basic needs of every person. Behaviourists such as William James and William McDougal were focusing more on the instinctive components of human behaviour, while John B. Watson was emphasising the importance of gaining the knowledge. Those people created the Stimulus-Response Theory, which defined behaviour as one's reaction to change that takes place within the environmental stimulation, which later occurred as a basis of the school of behaviourism. Drive was a motivational concept consisted to S-R Theory, introduced at the beginning of 20th century by Robert S. Woodworth, but it was further developed by Clark Hull, American psychologist. He argued that motivation results from changes in the body's needs which can be satisfied by obtaining appropriate resources from the environment. In the 1960's Edward C. Tolman and Wolfgang Köhler disagreed with the S-R Theory, and begun to examine the phenomenon as a result of waiting for upcoming events, which resulted from the choices that were made. Because of that, people were able to describe some behaviours as purposive (Petri, 2024).

Modern theories excluded the ways in which early theories described a human being. They no longer portray the person as machine-like organisms, who are unable to control themselves and are fully impacted by internal and external forces. Bandura's self-efficiency theory emphasises that human beings, who truly believe in their ability to control the behaviours which are task-related, are more likely to succeed. This kind of belief can be a result of learning on the past experiences or from the authority figures, such as parents or teachers. High self-efficacy is connected with setting ambitious goals, the process of working to achieve them and also staying composed when it comes to facing the obstacles. Even more modern theories, like Gollwitzer's, go further, and describe humans as strategists who are flexible. People analyse information objectively, when it comes to setting the goals, and become more optimistic and focused, when they choose the goal and view it as highly desirable (Gollwitzer & Oettingen, 2001).

It should be emphasised that the terms 'motivation' and 'motivating' are not synonymous. Motivation is the most important factor that determines the work efficiency, whereas motivating refers to situations, when a person is being encouraged to do something in a specific way (Brzezińska, 2009).

Engagement in the working context is commonly treated as a mix of organisational commitment, job satisfaction, and discretionary effort that goes way beyond the formal job description. The consultancy models show that the engaged employees are those, who speak positively about the company or organisation, choose to stay in it regardless of the alternatives, and invest some extra effort and time in order to contribute to its success. Engagement therefore means the psychological bond with the organisation, as well as behaviour that goes beyond minimum performance expectations.

In scientific research, engagement is defined as a mental state. A regular literature review reveals many distinct theoretical approaches. On the one hand, engagement is defined as an active expression of person's physical, cognitive, emotional, and mental self while executing work roles. On the other hand, engagement is conceptualised as the positive counterpart of burnout, either as an independent construct linked to commitment to work, full absorption in tasks and high levels of energy, or as the opposite pole on a shared continuum. In that interpretation, those engaged experience enthusiasm, vitality, and deep concentration, often losing track of time during working hours.

Definitions of work engagement emphasise observable behaviours and work outcomes, whereas academic definitions focus on work-related experiences and internal mental states (Schaufeli, 2013).

3. Specificity of Non-Profit Organisations

There are plenty of imperfections in both public and private economical sectors, therefore, there is a need for the existence of non-governmental organisations. The key elements that shape non-profit organisations include community involvement, a tailored approach to activities, and the promotion of social solidarity. Any group of people undertaking activities without the purpose of making money and working to achieve socially useful aims would be defined as a non-profit organisation (Krzyżanowska, 2000).

Johns Hopkins University defined NGOs as organisations that should be managed by an organised entity that is not a part of state structure. They also underlined that it should be natural for them to volunteer in activities and that they should not be splitting their resources between each other. Additionally, they should be self-governing, guided by the social mission assigned and the whole management process should be focused on the procedural dimension (Wygnański, 2006).

The United Nations Economic and Social Council defines non-profit organisations as private, independent from government, law-abiding, focused on public good, capable of international activity, and having a basic organisational structure (Hobe, 1997). Drucker (1995) emphasised that the true 'product' of NGOs is the change they create in people's lives—a recovered patient, an educated child, or individuals with renewed self-respect. In this way, anyone can be considered a customer of NGOs, as their services aim to improve lives.

These organisations play a crucial role in addressing issues where public and private sectors fail, raising the key question: what motivates people to work without financial profit?

4. Independent Students' Association (Niezależne Zrzeszenie Studentów)

NZS is the largest students' organisation in Poland, founded in 1980. Its first aim was to fight for the rights of academic youth, democracy, restoring civil liberties and national dignity. They had a great impact on the changes regarding academic rights that occurred during this time. In the 21st century, NZS became a non-partisan organisation, focusing on various fields. They organise projects, which are focused on charity, gaining knowledge, providing students with fun ways to spend time and giving them ability to grow as future specialists in whatever field they choose. Over the years, hundreds of thousands of students from various universities all around the country have been a part of this organisation, what most of them summarise as a life-changing experience. It is important to highlight that every student or PhD student supporting the goals of NZS and declaring their willingness to actively participate in achieving them can be a member of the association. Membership terminates in the event of resignation, death, violation of the statute or removal from the membership list, effective 12 months after the loss of student or doctoral status. With this in mind, we can conclude that the membership is temporary, so it is easier for students to plan their time within the organisation and for the authorities to track one's motivation (Popińska, 2010).

The structure of the organisation is rather vertical, although there are some differences between universities. The national board consists of the president and 8 vice-presidents, who specialise in different fields. They all manage their teams which consist of various specialist from all around the country. All projects have their own coordinators, vice-coordinators and team members. The presidents from each university form National Commission.

NZS organises both national and local projects that support students, integrate communities, and promote social engagement. Key initiatives include:

- *Wampiriada* – blood donation campaign promoting healthy lifestyles;
- *Studencki Nobel* – scholarship competition rewarding top students in nine fields;
- *KOKOS* – contest helping young inventors commercialise their projects;
- *Drogowskazy Kariery* – trainings and workshops for career development;
- *Prawie Kino* – free film screenings with industry guests, promoting legal culture;
- *OKFS* – national photography contest with workshops;
- *Maturalnie z NZS* – support for high schoolers preparing for exams;
- *Studenci dla Zdrowia* – mental and physical health webinars and consultations;
- *Studiuję|Głosuję* – encouraging political awareness and voting among students.

Through these projects, NZS educates, supports, and inspires young people, becoming one of Poland's most recognised student organisations (NZS, n.d.).

5. Research Method and Tool

Motivation is a personal and context-dependent phenomenon shaped by individual values, experiences, and backgrounds. This study aimed to explore how members of a non-profit organisation perceive and apply motivation, especially in the absence of financial incentives. The research focused on identifying differences in motivational approaches among members holding various positions within NZS. Using qualitative interviews, it gathered insights from people at different organisational levels, resulting in a broad range of perspectives.

Key research questions included:

1. How to motivate people without monetary rewards?
2. Do experiences shape how people define motivation?
3. Which non-financial tools can improve motivation and engagement?
4. What factors drive or reduce motivation and engagement?
5. How to maintain self-motivation?

The study assumed that non-profit leaders create unique strategies to motivate and keep others engaged, shaped by values, experiences, team structures, and organisational culture. Interviews provided a deeper understanding of these strategies and challenges in a volunteer-based environment.

Individual in-depth interviews (IDIs) were chosen as the most suitable research method for this study. IDIs allow for a detailed exploration of participants' experiences, attitudes, and emotions through flexible, interactive, and personalised conversations. Compared to written surveys, they provide richer, more nuanced data, enable clarification of questions in real time, and build trust that encourages honest answers.

However, IDIs are time-consuming due to interview preparation, transcription, and analysis. They can also be prone to bias, and findings cannot be generalised, though they still offer valuable insights if recurring themes emerge. Interviewers must be skilled in guiding conversations, maintaining neutrality, and using body language effectively.

A questionnaire of 16 open-ended questions was prepared, focusing on respondents' roles, motivational tools, team challenges, feedback, and personal approaches to motivation. Interviews were conducted both online and in person.

Participants were nine NZS members aged 20-24 (six women, three men) holding various positions, from project HR members to the National President. To capture a variety of perspectives, interviews included coordinators from projects with different levels of complexity and vice-coordinators from projects with and without motivation-related issues.

6. Conclusions from the IDIs

Motivation is understood differently by each person, and experience plays the biggest role in shaping this perspective. Less experienced members saw motivation as purely internal, while those with more semesters in NZS became better at noticing problems, analysing them, and finding solutions. Experience also improved their ability to evaluate motivational tools and suggest improvements.

Definitions of motivation varied—for some it was intrinsic and unchangeable, for others a process influenced by many factors. HR-related members viewed motivation as more complex and proposed more strategies. Commonly used tools included integration games, feedback, praising, conversations, gifts, and organising bonding events like bowling or karaoke. Management board members focused more on feedback and public recognition, while National Board members relied on online praise due to less personal contact.

The Excel-based motivational system was praised for transparency and efficiency, but inconsistent updates sometimes led to unfair results and demotivation. Feedback tools (unlimited, semi-project, post-project, and a moment of reflection) provided valuable insights, though some members submitted incomplete or unhelpful responses. Crisis- specific feedback proved helpful in re-engaging teams and addressing communication issues.

Integration activities were seen as essential for building bonds and increasing motivation. Praise—both public and private—was considered one of the strongest motivators in the absence of financial rewards. Conversations were emphasised as the key to solving problems and maintaining motivation. Small gifts and diplomas acted as symbolic recognition of effort.

The biggest challenges in motivating people were the lack of financial incentives, limited free time, and differing levels of engagement. Demotivation could spread among team members, making rebuilding morale difficult. Experienced leaders highlighted the need to manage large groups effectively, stay transparent in times of crisis, and show members the benefits of participation by sharing success stories of former NZS members.

To keep themselves motivated, leaders focused on bonding with teams, enjoying events, balancing work with personal life, setting goals, celebrating achievements, and staying positive. They agreed that HR and motivation are crucial to NZS—without motivated members, the organisation could not function.

7. Summary of the Research

The goal of this research was to demonstrate that people's definitions, applications, and reactions to motivational strategies differ depending on their experience, values, and background. Interviews with nine members of the Independent Students' Association—from project members to the National President—confirmed that these factors significantly shape the way motivation is understood and practiced.

The most common motivational tools identified were: feedback (in various forms), motivational systems, conversations, integration games and events, praise, small prizes, personalised approaches, and opportunities for development through training or new responsibilities. These methods were generally considered effective, but several challenges were highlighted, such as lack of financial compensation, limited availability due to personal commitments, high member turnover, and poor internal communication. Leadership quality—including communication style, engagement, and emotional intelligence—was seen as a key factor influencing motivation (Tab. 1).

Findings show that successful motivation in NGOs requires more than tools and systems—it relies on a culture of flexibility, empathy, and ongoing support. Without people actively fostering motivation, an organisation could risk collapse, as voluntary work depends on members' willingness to stay engaged.

Table 1. Comparison of various issues in the respondents' answers

Issue	Respondents' answers
Motivational tools	• motivational system • unlimited feedback • semi-project feedback • after-project feedback • a moment of reflection • integrational games and integrations • praising • conversation • gifts and diplomas
Difficulties	• lack of remuneration • amount of free time • willingness to dedicate • inequality of engagement • too many people in projects • too many projects • people 'infecting' others with demotivation • people that do not see the benefits on working voluntarily
Solutions	• praise every action • have an individual approach to each person • stay transparent • build awareness of all the skills that could be gained from working voluntarily • learn how to approach a demotivated person • react on each situation as quickly as possible • reduce the number of projects • reduce the number of people in projects
Keeping oneself motivated	• bond with people • find time for oneself, hobbies and private relations • stay active • set smaller and bigger goals • focus on positives • not compare oneself to others

Source: own elaboration based on the answers from the in-depth interviews.

The study also underlined the need to continuously improve motivational tools and adapt them to changing generations. Different age groups have different needs, e.g. younger members often require more stimulation and smaller tasks to maintain focus.

Participants with HR experience provided deeper insights and improvement ideas, showing that experience not only shapes one's approach to motivating others but also influences personal needs for staying motivated.

To foster the engagement within the organisation, it requires a deliberate interplay of social, structural and motivational mechanisms. The structural level of engagement enhances, when members understand the goals of the organisation and are able to see a clear pathway for contributing to them. Clarity of roles, transparency in communication and accessible decision-making spaces support this dynamic by minimizing uncertainty and enhancing members' sense of the significance of participation. Moreover, providing members with diverse involvement opportunities, from local initiatives to national projects, allows them to match activities to their competencies and interests, which strengthens both intrinsic motivation and sustained engagement in non-profit organisations.

It is crucial to underline that engagement expands when members witness tangible impact. It could be delivered in the form of satisfaction from a successful event, marketing campaign, contacting partners, or even getting recognition within the organisation. This reinforces a sense meaningfulness and affirms the collective value of the group's contribution. Thanks to that combination of relational climate and structural scaffolding, Independent Students' Association is able to foster a durable engagement culture that advances the organisation's objectives while simultaneously fostering individual development trajectories.

Overall, this research highlights that motivation in NGOs is a complex, evolving phenomenon. These results can serve as a starting point for further studies and as a practical guide for those coordinating teams in NZS and other student or voluntary organisations.

8. Conclusions

The chapter aimed to explore how to motivate people without financial rewards, whether motivation is perceived differently based on experience, what factors influence motivation, which tools can enhance it, and how individuals can maintain their own motivation. Conducting in-depth interviews allowed for capturing subtle nuances and gathering diverse perspectives from members of the Independent Students' Association in various roles, leading to a broad range of conclusions.

Key findings include the following.

1. Individual differences matter—each member has unique needs, availability, and approaches, making personalised and flexible strategies essential.
2. Motivational tools are crucial—with no financial rewards, intrinsic motivation becomes essential. Building strong relationships, offering praise (both private and public), and emphasising the importance of one's work are effective strategies.
3. Constant adaptation is necessary—as the environment and generations change, motivational methods must evolve to remain relevant.
4. Leadership sets the tone—leaders' communication, engagement, and emotional intelligence directly affect team motivation. Leading by example and staying empathetic are critical.
5. Dealing with demotivation—some people may remain demotivated despite efforts. Learning to work with them without lowering one's own motivation is vital.

This chapter offers both theoretical insights and practical recommendations for motivating others in non-profit organisations, particularly for current and future leaders of the Independent Students' Association.

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Motywacja i zaangażowanie w studenckiej organizacji *non-profit* na przykładzie Niezależnego Zrzeszenia Studentów

Streszczenie: Autorka prezentuje analizę różnych narzędzi i metod motywacyjnych wykorzystywanych w Niezależnym Zrzeszeniu Studentów (NZS), które jest największą organizacją *non-profit* w Polsce zarządzaną w pełni przez studentów. Celem pracy było zrozumienie roli motywacji i zaangażowania w tym konkretnym środowisku oraz zidentyfikowanie najbardziej efektywnych i skutecznych sposobów ich wspierania, rozwijania i utrzymywania wśród członków organizacji. Badanie zostało przeprowadzone z wykorzystaniem indywidualnych wywiadów pogłębionych (IDI – *In-Depth Interviews*), czyli jakościowej techniki badawczej polegającej na przeprowadzeniu rozmów z wybraną grupą respondentów w celu poznania różnych perspektyw, doświadczeń oraz opinii dotyczących danego tematu, sytuacji lub pomysłów. Wyniki badania pozwalają lepiej zrozumieć mechanizmy motywacyjne w sektorze organizacji pozarządowych, mogą zostać wykorzystane do usprawnienia praktyk organizacyjnych oraz stanowią solidną podstawę do dalszych badań naukowych w tym obszarze.

Słowa kluczowe: motywacja, organizacja *non-profit*, NZS, studenci

Debiuty studenckie
Student debuts

DOI: 10.15611/2026.35.7.07
JEL Classification: M31, L82

Crafting a Successful Marketing Strategy in the Video Game Industry

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Quote as: Sioła, W. (2026). Crafting a Successful Marketing Strategy in the Video Game Industry. In J. Radomska, & A. Witek-Crabb (Eds.), *New Trends in Business Management. Culture, Strategy, Engagement* (pp. 75-86). Publishing House of Wroclaw University of Economics and Business.

Abstract: The author explores the drivers of successful marketing strategies in the video game industry, a sector that has grown into a dominant force in global entertainment. The study aims to identify key factors contributing to effective marketing campaigns by analysing industry trends, consumer behaviour, and case studies of notable games. Employing a case study methodology, the research examines nine titles, categorised into four marketing approaches: universe creation, community-driven strategies, overpromising, and controlled leaks. The findings highlight the importance of community engagement, authenticity, and alignment between marketing promises and product delivery. Successful strategies leverage strong branding, word-of-mouth marketing, and player-driven promotion, while failures often stem from unmet expectations or lack of differentiation. The article concludes with insights into the need for adaptability, transparency, and ethical monetisation to foster long-term player loyalty and brand value. Limitations include the case study method's limited generalisability, suggesting future research could incorporate interviews with industry professionals.

Keywords: branding, community engagement, consumer behaviour, video game marketing, word-of-mouth marketing

1. Introduction

The video game industry has transformed from a niche entertainment sector into a global cultural and economic powerhouse, surpassing traditional industries like film and music in revenue (Richter, 2022). With annual revenues reaching $200 billion by

2021, the industry's growth has been driven by technological advancements, evolving consumer preferences, and innovative marketing strategies (Ball, 2025). This article investigates the drivers of successful marketing strategies in the video game industry, focusing on how companies engage audiences, build brand loyalty, and navigate a competitive and rapidly evolving market.

The aim of this study is to explore the key factors that contribute to effective marketing campaigns in the video game industry. The research addresses the following questions: What elements define a successful marketing strategy? How do community engagement and branding influence campaign outcomes? What are the risks of overpromising or misalignment with audience expectations? Using a case study approach, the article analyses nine games across four marketing strategies– universe creation, community-driven approaches, overpromising, and controlled leaks—to identify patterns of success and failure. The study draws on secondary data, including industry reports, player reviews, and sales figures, to provide a comprehensive understanding of marketing dynamics.

The article is structured as follows: the theoretical background synthesises key insights from the industry's marketing strategies and trends, followed by the research design outlining the methodology. The research findings present case studies, and the insights section consolidates key takeaways and conclusions. Finally, limitations and directions for future research are discussed.

2. Theoretical Background

The video game industry's marketing landscape is shaped by its unique characteristics, including diverse consumer demographics, rapid technological advancements, and evolving monetisation models. This section synthesises key elements of successful marketing strategies, drawing on industry analyses and consumer behaviour trends.

2.1. Defining a Successful Marketing Strategy

A successful marketing strategy is explicitly defined here as one that achieves measurable objectives aligned with company goals across both short and long-term horizons.

- Short-term success is measured by immediate outcomes such as increased brand/product recognition (e.g. trailer views, pre-orders, social media engagement), higher sales volume during the launch window, and positive initial reviews/user sentiment.
- Long-term success is evaluated by sustained metrics including customer loyalty (repeat purchases, community retention), profitability over the product lifecycle (e.g. DLC sales, in-game monetisation), and enhanced brand equity (franchise expansion potential).

This dual horizon is critical, as short-term spikes may fade without long-term nurturing, while sustained loyalty often compounds over years (Bibby et al., 2021; Kotler & Keller, 2016).

Importantly, ex-post evaluation of sales and recognition success must account for external confounding factors, which can amplify or undermine marketing efforts:

- economic conditions (e.g. recessions reduce discretionary spending on non-essential entertainment);
- global events (e.g. the COVID-19 pandemic boosted gaming demand via lockdowns but strained supply chains);
- platform dynamics (e.g. Steam algorithm changes affecting discoverability);
- competitive landscape (e.g., simultaneous blockbuster releases diluting attention).

These factors are identifiable in retrospective analysis through contextual data (e.g. industry reports correlating sales with macroeconomic indicators), enabling researchers to isolate marketing's attributable impact (Okada, 2024; Rock, 2024). This framework guides the case evaluations below, distinguishing marketing-driven outcomes from exogenous influences.

2.2. Elements of Successful Marketing Strategies

A successful marketing strategy in the video game industry aligns with company goals such as brand awareness, customer engagement, and profitability. Research identifies seven critical elements (Bibby et al., 2021; Gupta, 2023; Okada, 2024; Rock, 2024):

1. Clear Market Positioning: establishing a distinct brand identity differentiates a game from competitors, appealing to specific audience segments. Mislabelling a game's genre can lead to poor performance.
2. High Engagement and Community Building: strong player communities foster user-generated content, social media interaction, and long-term loyalty.
3. Effective Use of Digital Channels: leveraging influencers, streamers, and digital ads expands reach and engages potential players.
4. Data-Driven Decisions: analysing market trends and player feedback enhances targeting and campaign effectiveness.
5. Word-of-Mouth and Positive Reviews: quality gameplay and user satisfaction drive favourable reviews, critical in a community-driven industry.
6. Adaptability and Responsiveness: strategies must adapt to changing consumer expectations and market trends to remain relevant.
7. Financial Return on Investment: successful campaigns generate direct sales, in-game purchases, or brand equity.

These elements underscore the importance of aligning marketing with the game's quality and audience expectations. Word-of-mouth marketing, in particular, is a powerful driver, as positive community sentiment can amplify a game's reach with minimal investment (Okada, 2024).

2.3. Consumer Behaviour in the Video Game Industry

Consumer behaviour in the video game industry is influenced by diverse demographics and psychological motivations. The audience spans a wide age range, with older players (55+) now accounting for a significant share (Elliott, 2024). Cultural differences also shape preferences, with Western markets favouring high-end PC and console games and Asian markets leaning toward mobile gaming with gacha mechanics (Harris, 2021).

Psychological drivers include escapism, social connection, and achievement. Players seek immersive experiences to escape real-world stress, engage in social activities through multiplayer modes, and pursue in-game rewards (Haloskokova, 2024). Marketing campaigns that highlight compelling narratives, community features, and achievement systems resonate strongly with these motivations.

Purchase decisions are heavily influenced by game reviews, price sensitivity, and franchise loyalty. Positive reviews, both professional and user-generated, boost visibility on platforms like Steam, while price sensitivity drives demand for deals or subscription models (Wallace, 2023). Established franchises benefit from loyal fan bases, as trust in a studio's track record encourages purchases (Kotler & Keller, 2016).

2.4. Industry Trends Shaping Marketing

The video game industry faces challenges such as market saturation, rising development costs, and regulatory pressures (Ball, 2025). However, emerging trends offer opportunities for innovative marketing:

- User-Generated Content: platforms like Roblox enable players to create and monetize content, fostering engagement and extending game lifecycles.
- Generative AI: AI-driven tools enhance game development and personalisation, offering new marketing angles around immersive experiences.
- Cloud Gaming and Subscriptions: services like Xbox Game Pass lower entry barriers, appealing to casual players and broadening market reach.
- Esports and Streaming: competitive gaming and platforms like Twitch amplify visibility through community engagement and live events.
- Ad-Supported Gaming: non-intrusive ads provide alternative revenue streams, with untapped potential in digital ad spending (Ball, 2025).

These trends highlight the need for adaptable, community-focused marketing strategies that leverage digital platforms and player-driven promotion.

3. Research Design

The research employs a case study methodology to explore marketing strategy drivers in the video game industry. This approach allows for in-depth analysis of specific cases, uncovering causal relationships and contextual factors not visible through statistical methods alone (Eisenhardt, 1989). The study examines nine games, categorised into four marketing approaches: universe creation (The Last of Us, LEGO franchise, Star Wars games), community-driven strategies (Balatro, Counter-Strike: Global Offensive/Counter-Strike 2), overpromising (Overwatch 2, Concord, Cyberpunk 2077), and controlled leaks (Grand Theft Auto VI).

The nine cases were mostly selected based on these three key criteria:

1. Pattern Representativeness: cases exemplify four distinct (although more may exist) marketing strategy patterns observed across the industry, providing comprehensive coverage of common approaches (Okada, 2024).
2. Success/Failure Balance: includes both high-performing (e.g. Balatro, GTA VI trailer) and failed cases (e.g. Concord, Overwatch 2) to enable contrast and avoid selection bias.
3. Data Richness: chosen for abundant, verifiable secondary data (sales, Steam/PSN reviews, industry reports) from credible sources, ensuring comparability across indie-to-AAA scale.

Alternative cases were considered but excluded to prioritise pattern clarity, recent data availability and their interestingness to the reader.

Data were collected from secondary sources, including industry reports, official websites, sales figures, player reviews on platforms like Steam and PlayStation Store, and social media campaigns. Each case study follows a consistent structure: identification of publisher and developer, game description, marketing strategy, outcomes, and evaluation. This ensures comparability and clarity in analysing the effectiveness of different marketing tactics.

Limitations of the case study method include limited generalisability and potential bias (Yin, 2017). To mitigate bias, multiple data sources were integrated, including quantitative metrics (sales, reviews) and qualitative insights (community feedback). The methodology is particularly suitable for the video game industry, where player sentiment and word-of-mouth significantly influence outcomes.

4. Research Findings

4.1. Universe Creation

Case Study 1: The Last of Us

Developed by Naughty Dog and published in 2013 by Sony Interactive Entertainment, The Last of Us is a narrative-driven action-adventure game set in a post-apocalyptic world, blending stealth, survival, and emotional storytelling to target mature audiences with a $220 million budget (Jones, 2023). Naughty Dog's reputation for cinematic storytelling, built on the Uncharted series, positioned the game as a premium PlayStation exclusive, though controversies around The Last of Us Part II's narrative choices sparked debate (Byrd, 2020). The marketing strategy centred on emotional storytelling, with trailers emphasising the bond between protagonists Joel and Ellie, complemented by developer interviews, pre-launch previews, and PlayStation exclusivity to build anticipation. Post-launch, downloadable content (DLC) like Left Behind and an HBO adaptation in 2023 expanded the intellectual property (IP) into a transmedia franchise, leveraging cross-media storytelling to maintain cultural relevance. The franchise sold over 37 million copies by 2022, earning near-perfect review scores (4.89/5 on PlayStation Store for Part I) and critical acclaim as a landmark in narrative gaming (Druckmann, 2023). The HBO series amplified visibility, drawing in non-gamers and boosting merchandise sales. The strategy's success lay in its authentic focus on storytelling, consistent branding, and transmedia synergy, creating a lasting emotional connection with players and establishing The Last of Us as a cultural phenomenon, though narrative risks in Part II highlighted the need to balance creative ambition with audience expectations.

Case Study 2: LEGO Franchise

Developed by TT Games and published by Warner Bros. Interactive Entertainment, the LEGO franchise, exemplified by LEGO Star Wars: The Skywalker Saga, combines humour, accessibility, and iconic IPs like Star Wars and Harry Potter to target multi-generational audiences with a substantial but undisclosed budget (Kerr, 2022). TT Games' reputation for family-friendly games ensured broad appeal, building on LEGO's global toy brand. The marketing strategy leveraged cross-media synergy, using vibrant trailers and social media campaigns to highlight familiar IPs, family-friendly gameplay, and nostalgic appeal, with promotions timed to coincide with movie releases like Star Wars: The Rise of Skywalker to maximise visibility. In-store events at LEGO stores and collaborations with toy retailers further reinforced brand consistency, while fan-focused content like behind-the-scenes developer videos deepened engagement. The Skywalker Saga sold 3.2 million copies in two weeks, earning strong reviews (90% positive on Steam) and contributing to the franchise's $2 billion in revenue (Batchelor, 2019). The strategy's success stemmed from its ability to align the game's branding with LEGO's universal appeal, effectively targeting both children and adults through nostalgia and accessibility, while cross-media tie-ins amplified commercial impact, demonstrating the power of leveraging an established IP to create a cohesive, multi-platform marketing ecosystem.

Case Study 3: Star Wars Games

Developed by EA subsidiaries like DICE and Respawn Entertainment and published by Electronic Arts, Star Wars games such as Battlefront and Jedi: Fallen Order target fans of the iconic franchise with significant but undisclosed budgets, offering multiplayer shooters and single-player action-adventures, respectively (D'Angelo, 2019). EA's Star Wars license faced challenges after Battlefront II's pay-to-win monetization sparked backlash, requiring post-launch adjustments (Hruska, 2018). The marketing strategy capitalised on Star Wars' cultural legacy, using cinematic trailers with iconic imagery like X-Wings and lightsabers, timed with film releases to amplify hype, while developer diaries and convention appearances deepened fan engagement. Jedi: Fallen Order emphasised narrative depth to appeal to solo players, distancing itself from Battlefront's multiplayer focus. The Battlefront series sold 33 million units, and Jedi: Fallen Order reached 20 million players, with strong reviews (4.5/5 on PlayStation Store) reflecting recovery from early controversies (Cryer, 2021). The strategy's success relied on leveraging a globally recognised IP and responding to community feedback, though initial monetization missteps underscored the importance of transparency and alignment with fan expectations, proving that adaptability can salvage a brand's reputation in a franchise-driven market.

4.2. Community-Driven Approach

Case Study 4: Balatro

Developed by solo developer LocalThunk and published by Playstack, Balatro is an indie deck-building roguelike with a modest budget, targeting strategy and indie game enthusiasts with its poker-inspired mechanics and high replayability (Playstack, 2024). Without a pre-existing IP, Balatro relied on grassroots momentum, with its marketing strategy centred on a demo during Steam Next Fest that garnered 200,000 downloads, amplified by Twitch streamers and YouTube content creators who showcased its addictive gameplay. Playstack's lean social media campaign engaged players through developer Q&As and community challenges, fostering a sense of ownership among early adopters. Post-launch, regular updates and community feedback integration sustained momentum, with fan-made guides and discussions on Reddit driving organic growth. Balatro sold over 1 million copies in its first month, earning 97% positive Steam reviews and three Game Awards in 2024, a remarkable feat for an indie title (The Game Awards, 2024). The strategy's success highlights the power of authentic community engagement, proving that a well-executed demo and influencer-driven word-of-mouth can rival big-budget campaigns, though its niche appeal suggests scalability may be limited without broader marketing investment.

Case Study 5: Counter-Strike: Global Offensive / Counter-Strike 2

Developed and published by Valve Corporation, known for community-driven titles like Dota 2, Counter-Strike: Global Offensive (CS:GO) and its successor Counter-Strike 2 (CS2) are competitive first-person shooters with a free-to-play model monetised through cosmetic skins, targeting skilled players with no public budget figures (Panda, 2025). Valve's marketing strategy eschewed traditional advertising, relying on esports tournaments, community-created skins via the Steam Workshop, and a robust skin economy to drive engagement. High-profile events like the CS:GO Major Championships, streamed on Twitch, attracted millions of viewers, while player-driven content and trading systems created a self-sustaining ecosystem. Community feedback shaped updates, ensuring longevity, with CS2's launch in 2023 leveraging CS:GO's established fanbase. CS2 holds 86% positive Steam reviews with 8.7 million reviews, and its skin market is valued at $4.5 billion, reflecting unparalleled player investment (Westerlund, 2024). The strategy's success lies in its minimal marketing spend and reliance on community passion, demonstrating that player-driven ecosystems can create enduring value, though its niche competitive focus may limit appeal to casual players.

4.3. Overpromising

Case Study 6: Overwatch 2

Developed and published by Blizzard Entertainment, known for World of Warcraft and the original Overwatch, Overwatch 2 is a free-to-play team-based shooter targeting both casual and competitive players, but its failure to deliver a promised PvE story mode damaged its reputation (Shepard, 2024). The marketing strategy hyped a robust PvE campaign and seasonal content updates, using cinematic trailers and developer livestreams to promise a transformative sequel, while the shift to free-to-play with battle passes aimed to attract a broader audience. However, vague communication about delays and the eventual cancellation of the PvE mode fuelled scepticism, compounded by aggressive monetisation that alienated fans of the original's player-friendly model. Launched in 2022, the game received 23% positive Steam reviews, reflecting widespread disappointment, with player counts dropping significantly post-launch (Shepard, 2024). The strategy's failure underscores the risks of overpromising core features and misaligning with community expectations, highlighting the need for transparency and realistic commitments to maintain trust in a franchise with a loyal but demanding fanbase.

Case Study 7: Concord

Developed by Firewalk Studios and published by Sony, Concord was reportedly a $400 million hero-shooter targeting competitive players in a crowded market, launched in 2024 with a 5v5 sci-fi premise but struggling to stand out against established titles like Overwatch (Tassi, 2024). The marketing strategy relied on polished trailers, social media campaigns, and an Open Beta to generate buzz, emphasising diverse characters and dynamic gameplay, yet it failed to articulate a unique selling proposition. Pre-launch streams on Twitch and YouTube saw low viewership, and the beta's lukewarm reception signalled weak player interest. Concord sold only 25,000 copies, with a peak of 697 Steam players, leading to its shutdown two weeks after launch and Firewalk's closure, marking one of Sony's biggest commercial failures (Strickland, 2024). The strategy's collapse illustrates the dangers of heavy investment without differentiation, emphasizing that even robust marketing cannot overcome a lack of innovation or community connection in a saturated genre.

Case Study 8: Cyberpunk 2077

Developed by CD Projekt Red, known for The Witcher 3, Cyberpunk 2077 is an open-world RPG with a $315 million budget, targeting fans of immersive narratives but marred by technical issues at its 2020 launch (Woldański, 2021). The marketing strategy spanned eight years, building immense hype through cinematic trailers, celebrity endorsements (Keanu Reeves), and global events like E3, generating 8 million pre-orders (Batchelor, 2020). Limited gameplay footage concealed performance issues, particularly on consoles, leading to unmet expectations. The game sold 13 million copies on launch day but faced refunds and delisting from the PlayStation Store due to bugs and crashes, with initial Steam reviews dipping below 50% positive (Clement, 2024). Post-launch updates, a Netflix anime (Edgerunners), and a DLC in 2023 improved sentiment to 84% positive Steam reviews, salvaging the brand. The strategy's initial failure highlights the risks of overhyping without transparency, but CD Projekt Red's recovery efforts demonstrate that sustained commitment and community engagement can rebuild trust, albeit at significant cost.

4.4. Controlled Leaks

Case Study 9: Grand Theft Auto VI

Developed and published by Rockstar Games, known for GTA V and Red Dead Redemption 2, Grand Theft Auto VI (GTA VI) is an open-world game set in a fictional Miami, targeting a broad audience with a rumoured to exceed $1-2 billion budget, positioning it as one of the most expensive games ever (Tang, 2025). Rockstar's marketing strategy employed controlled leaks and minimal official communication, with a single trailer released in December 2023 generating 251 million YouTube views, breaking records for non-music video content (Gomez, 2023). Strategic leaks, including alleged gameplay snippets on social media, fuelled speculation, while Rockstar's silence leveraged GTA's iconic brand to maintain hype without overexposure. The trailer's cultural impact disrupted industry release schedules, as competitors avoided clashing with GTA VI's anticipated 2025 launch (Zwiezen, 2025). The strategy's success lies in its disciplined scarcity, harnessing fan anticipation and brand loyalty to create unprecedented buzz, though the high expectations set by this approach pose risks if the final product falls short of its monumental hype.

5. Research Insights and Conclusions

The case studies reveal that successful marketing in the video game industry hinges on authenticity, community engagement, and delivering on promises. Universe creation (The Last of Us, LEGO, Star Wars) succeeds by leveraging strong IPs and transmedia synergy, fostering emotional connections. Community-driven strategies (Balatro, Counter-Strike) thrive on player-led promotion, with demos and esports amplifying reach. Overpromising (Overwatch 2, Concord, Cyberpunk 2077) risks backlash if expectations are unmet, though recovery is possible through transparency. Controlled leaks (GTA VI) work for established franchises, using scarcity to fuel anticipation.

Key drivers include the following.

- Community Engagement: games with active communities, like Counter-Strike and Balatro, benefit from organic promotion.
- Authentic Branding: clear positioning and consistent messaging, as seen in LEGO and The Last of Us, build loyalty.
- Delivering Promises: fulfilling marketing claims is critical, as failures like Concord and Overwatch 2 show.

The industry's diversity demands tailored strategies. Indie games rely on community and influencers, while AAA titles leverage IPs and budgets. Transparency and ethical monetisation enhance trust, particularly in a market sensitive to exploitative practices.

6. Research Limitations and Future Directions

The case study method's focus on specific games limits generalisability, as findings may not apply universally across genres or markets. Potential biases in secondary data, such as selective reporting in reviews, may skew insights. The dynamic nature of the industry, with rapid technological and cultural shifts, further complicates long-term applicability.

Future research could incorporate primary data, such as interviews with marketing directors or developers, to gain deeper insights into strategy formulation. Exploring emerging trends like AI-driven marketing or regional market differences could also provide valuable perspectives. Quantitative studies analysing larger datasets could complement qualitative findings, offering a more comprehensive view of marketing effectiveness.

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Opracowywanie skutecznej strategii marketingowej w branży gier wideo

Streszczenie: Autor analizuje czynniki wpływające na skuteczne strategie marketingowe w branży gier wideo, sektorze, który stał się dominującą siłą w globalnej rozrywce. Celem badania jest identyfikacja kluczowych czynników wpływających na efektywność kampanii marketingowych poprzez analizę trendów rynkowych, zachowań konsumentów oraz studiów przypadków wybranych gier. Wykorzystując metodę studium przypadku, zbadano dziewięć tytułów zaklasyfikowanych do czterech podejść marketingowych: kreowania uniwersum, strategii napędzanych przez społeczność, nadmiernego obiecywania oraz kontrolowanych przecieków. Wyniki badania podkreślają znaczenie zaangażowania społeczności, autentyczności oraz zgodności pomiędzy obietnicami marketingowymi a dostarczonym produktem. Sukces zapewniają silne budowanie marki, marketing szeptany oraz promocja inicjowana przez graczy, natomiast porażki wynikają często z niespełnionych oczekiwań lub braku wyróżnienia się na rynku. W podsumowaniu autor zwraca uwagę na potrzebę adaptacyjności, przejrzystości oraz etycznej monetyzacji w celu budowania długoterminowej lojalności graczy i wartości marki. Ograniczeniem pracy jest ograniczona możliwość uogólniania wyników charakterystyczna dla studium przypadku; sugerowane są dalsze badania obejmujące wywiady z profesjonalistami branży.

Słowa kluczowe: budowanie marki, zaangażowanie społeczności, zachowania konsumenckie, marketing gier wideo, marketing szeptany

Debiuty studenckie
Student debuts

DOI: 10.15611/2026.35.7.08
JEL Classification: M14, J24

Managing Cultural Differences in International Organisations

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Quote as: Skalska, W. (2026). Managing Cultural Differences in International Organisations. In J. Radomska, & A. Witek-Crabb (Eds.), *New Trends in Business Management. Culture, Strategy, Engagement* (pp. 87-102). Publishing House of Wroclaw University of Economics and Business.

Abstract: The chapter examines the strategies, difficulties and benefits of working in a multicultural environment to discuss the problems associated with managing cultural diversity in international teams. The main objective of the study was to determine the most effective techniques for reducing cultural conflicts and supporting cooperation in global organisations. The study is based on a quantitative approach and a survey conducted among 102 people with experience in multicultural teams. The results show that although cultural diversity is perceived as an asset, misunderstandings and clashes of different work styles are real challenges. It was indicated that clear communication, diverse training and inclusive leadership are essential for success.

Keywords: cultural diversity, cross-cultural management, multinational teams, organisational culture, intercultural communication

1. Introduction

One of the most unique features of contemporary multinational corporations is cultural diversity. Managing differences in leadership, work ethics, and communication has become a crucial managerial skill as globalisation speeds up international collaboration (Adler, 1997).

The management of cultural distinctions in international teams is a topic covered in this chapter. Furthermore, the necessity to comprehend and manage cultural differences in virtual settings has increased as more businesses embrace remote and hybrid work arrangements (Meyer, 2014). In addition to their team members' professional abilities, managers are expected to be aware of their cultural preferences and interpersonal styles, as these factors have a big influence on teamwork and output (Earley & Mosakowski, 2004).

The main research questions are:

- What challenges arise in culturally diverse teams?
- What are the perceived benefits?
- What strategies are seen as most effective in fostering cooperation and inclusivity?

The goal of this study is to analyse how cultural diversity influences cooperation, communication, and leadership in international teams, with particular emphasis on managerial strategies used to address cultural differences. By drawing on established theoretical models and conducting empirical research, the study aims to identify key challenges in managing multicultural teams and to explore strategies that can enhance their effectiveness. The study contributes to the ongoing discussion on intercultural management by offering insights relevant to both practitioners and researchers.

From a managerial point of view, cultural differences are practical issues that call for thoughtful and organized approaches in addition to being descriptive features of international teams. As a result, this chapter takes a management-focused approach, treating cultural models as tools that guide managerial tactics like communication standardisation, leadership adaptation, cross-cultural training, and the creation of inclusive organisational practices, rather than just as analytical frameworks.

2. Literature Review

2.1. Concept of Culture and Its Impact on Organisations

Culture is defined as a complex idea that includes common beliefs, customs, and attitudes that influence group relationships and behaviour. One popular definition describes culture as "the collective programming of the mind that distinguishes the members of one group or category of people from another" (Hofstede, 2001, p. 9). This definition highlights that culture encompasses shared beliefs, values, norms, and practices that shape the behaviours of individuals within a group. While acknowledging the uniqueness of national and regional contexts, which can influence organisational norms differently depending on external societal issues, Hofstede's perspective also emphasises the universality of cultural aspects across organisations (Hofstede, 2011).

Culture serves as a framework for guidance that forms actions, affects how decisions are made, and helps workers develop a sense of shared identity (Kotter & Heskett, 1992). Employee satisfaction, organisational achievement, and flexibility in dealing with situations of change can all be strongly impacted by this shared cultural core (Schein, 2004).

Geographical regions are typically linked to particular cultures. It indicates that people from different nations usually behave differently. However, because of differences in gender, education, ethnicity, religion, language, experiences, and other factors, different groups within a nation may also have cultures that differ from the majority. Therefore, society is made up of multiple subcultures that overlap, and individuals may display traits from more than one subculture (Trompenaars & Hampden-Turner, 1998). Additionally, history, geography, customs, language, and religion are the foundations of culture. Furthermore, it is influenced by economic, political, and even technical developments (Rozkwitalska et al., 2012).

2.2. Theories of Cultural Differences

Understanding cultural differences is essential for organisations operating across multiple regions, as cultural variability can significantly influence management practices, communication, and organisational dynamics. These differences are addressed by a number of well-known theories which provide frameworks for examining cultural differences and their effects in organisational settings. This section examines three influential theories: Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions (Hofstede, 2011), Hall's Context Theory (Hall, 1976), and Meyer's Culture Map (Meyer, 2014). These models highlight how cultural norms shape values, behaviours, and workplace dynamics, which are crucial for managers overseeing cross-cultural teams and for organisations aiming to thrive in global markets. These three models were selected due to their widespread application in international management research and their direct relevance to managerial decision-making in multicultural teams.

2.2.1. Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions Theory

Geert Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions Theory, developed in the late 20th century, is one of the most often used frameworks for understanding cultural differences. Based on empirical studies conducted across global organisations, such as IBM across over 50 countries, Hofstede first established four aspects of culture: Power Distance, Individualism vs. Collectivism, Masculinity vs. Femininity, and Uncertainty Avoidance. Later, two additional dimensions—Long-term vs. Short-term Orientation and Indulgence vs. Restraint—were added, resulting in a six-dimensional model (Hofstede, 2011).

1. **Power Distance** illustrates the degree to which less powerful members of organisations and institutions accept and expect that power is distributed unequally. Hierarchical organisational systems are typically accepted in high power distance cultures, such as those seen in many Asian and Latin American nations. Low power distance cultures, like those found in Scandinavia, on the other hand, place high importance on equality and collaborative decision-making.
2. **Individualism vs. Collectivism** separates countries where people are incorporated into powerful, cohesive in-groups (e.g. Japan) from those where individual

rights and liberty are valued (e.g. the United States). In order to comprehend team dynamics and organisational loyalty, this factor is essential.

3. **Masculinity vs. Femininity** assesses the degree to which societies value traditionally "masculine" traits (e.g. competitiveness, assertiveness) versus "feminine" traits (e.g. cooperation, care). This dimension affects organisational goals and management practices, particularly in relation to conflict resolution and communication styles.
4. **Uncertainty Avoidance** shows how much ambiguity and uncertainty are tolerated in different cultures. Low uncertainty avoidance cultures like Singapore are more adaptable and tolerant of change, whereas high uncertainty avoidance cultures like Greece prefer organised surroundings.
5. **Long-term vs. Short-term Orientation** analyses the extent to which a culture prioritizes future oriented behaviours like perseverance and thrift over short-term gratification.
6. **Indulgence vs. Restraint** makes a distinction between nations that permit the unrestricted satisfaction of fundamental and natural human needs and those that control such actions through social standards.

2.2.2. Hall's Context Theory

Hall's Context Theory, which was created in the 1970s, introduces high-context and low-context cultures. On the one hand, high-context societies mostly rely on implicit communication in which meaning is communicated through common understanding, context, and nonverbal clues, according to Hall (1976). Low-context cultures, on the other hand, place a higher value on explicit communication which involves verbally and directly communicating information.

Hall's idea has important implications for cross-cultural communication and international business. Effective communication in high-context cultures requires an awareness of implicit messages and nonverbal cues. In international teams, this requirement for contextual awareness can be problematic since workers from low-context cultures might find it difficult to understand implicit cues, which could cause miscommunication and conflict.

- **High-context cultures**: communication in high-context cultures, e.g. China, Japan, and many Middle Eastern nations, heavily depends on contextual cues like body language, tone of voice, and mutual understanding. In order to completely understand the intended meaning, listeners must frequently read between the lines because messages are frequently implicit. High-context cultures strongly emphasise communication nuance, connections, and trust. When working with personnel from various cultures, global corporations must understand high-context communication because taking statements too literally can lead to misunderstandings.

- **Low-context cultures**: low-context cultures, e.g. the US, the Netherlands, and Germany, have more straightforward, explicit, and information-focused communication. There is less dependence on outside context and the message's core conveys most of its meaning. Low-context cultures emphasise direct language and unrestricted idea expression, and they place high importance on communication efficiency, clarity, and transparency. Understanding these distinctions can help managers and staff in multinational teams prevent misunderstandings and guarantee more seamless cooperation.

Additionally, Hall's theory discusses time orientation, classifying societies into monochronic and polychronic time orientations.

- **Monochronic cultures** like the United States and Germany view time as linear and sequential. People in these cultures prioritise punctuality, scheduling, and a task-oriented approach to work.
- **Polychronic cultures**, like Latin America and the Middle East, possess a more adaptable perspective on time, prioritising relationships and multitasking over rigorous timetable compliance. Project managers must comprehend various time orientations because disparities in how people perceive time can cause friction or disagreement in cross-cultural teams.

2.2.3. Meyer's Culture Map

Meyer's Culture Map builds on previous theories by offering an extensive model that focuses on cultural variations in eight behaviour aspects that are significant to business environments: Communicating, Evaluating, Leading, Deciding, Trusting, Disagreeing, Scheduling, and Persuading (Meyer, 2014).

- **Communicating**: this dimension distinguishes between low-context and high-context communication, aligning closely with Hall's theory. For instance, countries like Japan and France are high-context, where messages are nuanced, while countries like the United States and Australia are low-context, favouring clear and direct communication.
- **Evaluating**: cultures differ in how direct or indirect feedback is delivered, impacting performance evaluations and conflict resolution. Cultures such as the Netherlands and Germany tend to give direct negative feedback, while others, like Japan and India, are more indirect to avoid confrontation and maintain harmony.
- **Leading**: this dimension examines hierarchical versus egalitarian approaches to leadership, echoing elements of Hofstede's Power Distance. It reflects leadership styles, with cultures like Japan and Sweden having a more egalitarian approach, and others, such as China and Russia, favouring hierarchical structures. Recognising these differences helps managers adjust their leadership style to be more effective in diverse settings.

- **Deciding**: cultures vary in decision-making styles, from consensual to top-down approaches. In consensual cultures like Japan, decisions are made collectively, ensuring group consensus. In contrast, in top-down cultures like India, decisions are typically made by those in authority, with less input from subordinates.
- **Trusting**: trust-building varies between cultures, with some, like the United States and Australia, building trust based on tasks and performance, known as task-based trust. Personal connections and relationships are essential for establishing trust in relationship-based trust cultures, such as those in Latin America and the Middle East.
- **Disagreeing**: cultures differ in their tolerance for open disagreement, influencing conflict resolution strategies. Countries like France and Israel have a high tolerance for disagreement and debate, while cultures like Japan and Thailand prefer harmony and avoid open conflicts, as disagreement can be seen as disruptive.
- **Scheduling:** Meyer distinguishes between linear and flexible time orientations, relevant for project management and punctuality expectations. Linear time cultures, like those in Germany and Switzerland, value punctuality and adhere to schedules strictly. Flexible time cultures, such as in India and Nigeria, view time as more fluid and adaptable to the moment's needs.
- **Persuading:** cultures also vary in whether they prefer principles-first (e.g. France and Germany), where the theory and context are presented before conclusions. In applications-first cultures (e.g., the United States), the focus is on practical examples and direct application.

Meyer's Culture Map is particularly valuable for managers overseeing multicultural teams, as it offers practical insights into how to navigate cultural differences in business practices.

The concept of culture is foundational to understanding organizational dynamics, with profound implications for performance, adaptability, and employee relations. Theories by Hofstede, Hall, and Meyer provide essential frameworks for analysing cultural differences and offer valuable insights for organisations operating in diverse environments. These frameworks underscore the importance of cultural awareness in managing effective and cohesive global teams, ultimately contributing to organizational resilience and success.

The Seven Dimensions of Culture (7D) model (Trompenaars & Hampden-Turner, 1998) provides further depth by examining cultural preferences regarding, among other things, sequential versus synchronic time, achievement against ascription, and universalism versus particularism. This model is especially helpful for looking at the real-world effects of cultural variations in typical organisational contexts, like leadership expectations and decision-making methods.

Earley and Mosakowski (2004) created the idea of cultural intelligence (CQ), which offers a behavioural and psychological lens through which to view how people negotiate interactions across cultures. To perform well in multicultural settings, one must possess cultural intelligence, composed of behavioural, motivational, and cognitive components. It emphasises personal flexibility over national prejudices.

2.3. Strategies for Managing Cultural Differences in International Teams

Managing cultural differences demands the application of conscious managerial methods that integrate cultural knowledge into routine organisational procedures, rather than simply recognising national or organisational cultural patterns. According to earlier studies, when cultural diversity is actively promoted by suitable management structures, it can become a source of competitive advantage (Thomas & Ely, 1996).

Cross-cultural training, which aims to enhance employees' cultural awareness, communication skills, and behavioural flexibility, is one of the most frequently suggested solutions. These programmes decrease the likelihood of stereotyping and misunderstanding while assisting people in accurately interpreting unusual behaviours (Adler, 1997; Earley & Mosakowski, 2004). Managing cultural differences requires deliberate leadership behaviours that promote inclusion, psychological safety, and culturally sensitive communication. Recent research emphasises that inclusive leadership is one of the most effective tools for enhancing cooperation and trust in multicultural teams (Nishii & Mayer, 2009).

Another important practice is adaptive leadership. In multicultural settings, managers must modify their leadership approach to align with cultural norms about decision-making, hierarchy, and feedback. For instance, teams with high power-distance norms could need more defined authority structures, whereas teams with low power-distance norms gain from participative leadership approaches (Hofstede, 2011; Meyer, 2014).

Organisations are depending more and more on formal diversity management systems which include training courses, leadership development programmes, and explicit policies, in addition to individual competencies. Effectiveness is greatly increased when diversity management is integrated into regular business procedures rather than being handled as a stand-alone project (Silalahi & Rumambi, 2024).

In multicultural teams, standardising communication is also crucial. Misunderstandings between high-context and low-context cultures can be decreased by establishing common guidelines for feedback, meeting formats, and documentation (Hall, 1976).

Lastly, by incorporating cultural awareness into leadership development initiatives, promotion standards, and performance reviews, organisations may establish diversity management. These structural adjustments support cultural alignment and long-term organisational effectiveness (Deal & Kennedy, 2000; Kotter & Heskett, 1992).

3. Methodology

A systematic research approach that enables measurable insights is necessary to comprehend the effects of cultural diversity on multinational teams. In order to address the study issues of managing cultural differences in multinational teams, the methodology is made to be accurate, reliable, and relevant.

3.1. Survey Design

This study employs a quantitative research approach to examine the management of cultural differences in international teams. A structured survey served as the primary data collection instrument, targeting individuals with experience in multicultural academic or professional settings. The survey included Likert-scale questions focused on key themes such as perceptions of cultural diversity, intercultural training, leadership, and communication.

The selection of a quantitative method was driven by the aim to identify patterns, trends, and correlations related to cultural diversity in multinational teams. Compared to qualitative methods, which explore individual experiences in depth, the quantitative approach allows for broader generalisation by collecting responses from a larger and more diverse sample. The structured and standardised nature of survey data supports objective, repeatable findings and facilitates statistical analysis through the use of numerical data. This also enables comparisons across demographic variables such as age, nationality, and organisational context.

The survey was designed not only to capture perceptions of cultural diversity but also to assess the presence and effectiveness of organisational practices used to manage cultural differences.

3.2. Data Collection and Analysis

Respondents (N = 102) represented a range of nationalities, with the largest groups from Poland (61), Germany (11), and India (7). Demographic information was used to support comparative analysis, and Meyer’s Country Mapping Tool provided cultural context for interpreting cross-national differences.

The survey was conducted using Google Forms and distributed via multiple digital platforms, including WhatsApp, Messenger, LinkedIn, Instagram, and Outlook. Participants were informed about the study’s purpose, assured of anonymity, and selected based on their experience in multicultural environments. By including individuals from both academic and professional backgrounds, the study ensured the relevance and applicability of its findings across a broad organisational spectrum.

The accurate selection of participants was a crucial component of the distribution method. Particularly, the survey was distributed to those who had previous experience working or studying in multicultural settings, whether in academic or professional contexts. This criterion made sure that participants could offer useful data about cross-cultural relationships, difficulties, and advantages in multinational teams. In order to include a range of viewpoints from both younger workers and those with substantial experience in global corporations, the minimum age requirement was set at 18, with no upper age limit.

Participants from a variety of countries, including Brazil, Bulgaria, France, Germany, Greece, Hungary, India, Italy, Mexico, the Netherlands, Poland, Russia, Ukraine, and the United Kingdom, were given the survey. A significant dataset for statistical analysis was obtained from the 102 responses that were gathered over a period of five weeks. The sample's nationality and work experience diversity improves the study's findings' accuracy and makes cross-cultural comparisons more insightful (Fig. 1).

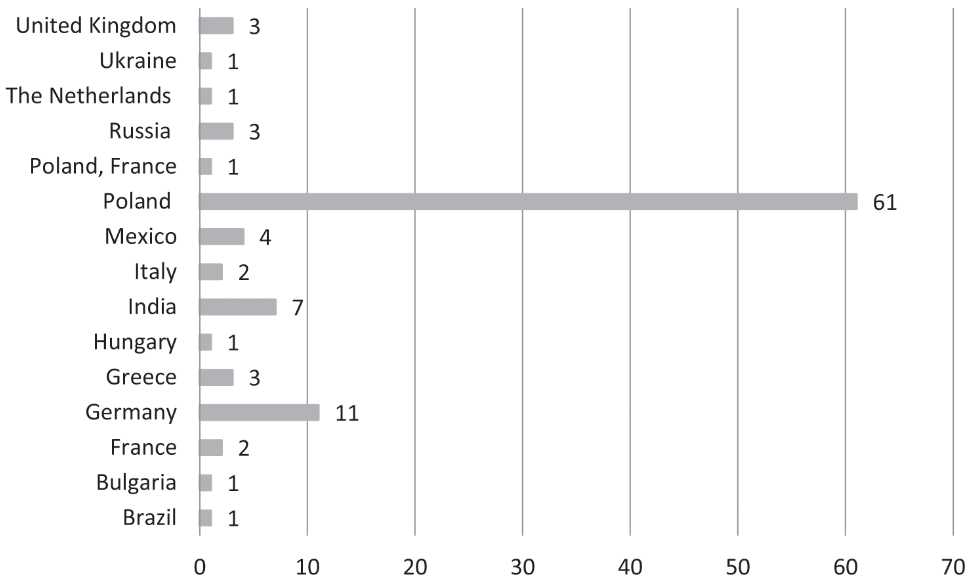

Fig. 1. Respondents' nationalities

Source: own elaboration.

Meyer's Country Mapping Tool

To gain deeper insights how cultural differences impact multinational teamwork, this study incorporates Meyer's Country Mapping Tool, a framework that systematically compares national cultures across dimensions such as communication style, decision-making, leadership, and trust building. Meyer's method is a useful resource for analysing survey results since it assists in identifying important cultural patterns that influence interactions among diverse teams and assess their impact on collaboration and performance (Fig. 2).

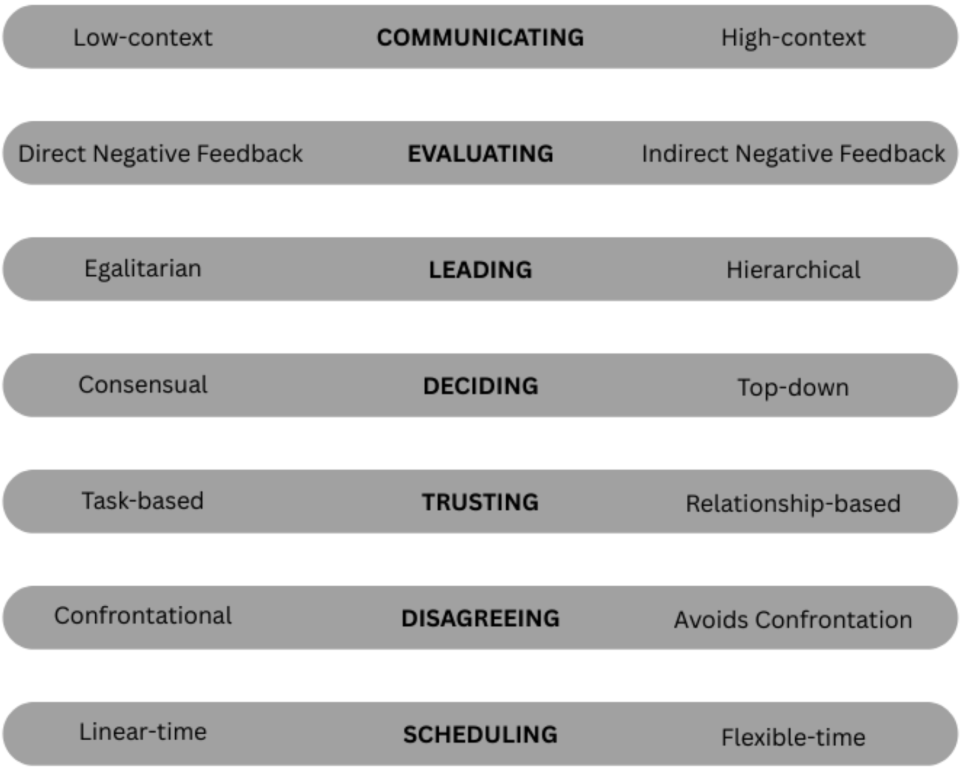

Fig. 2. The Country Mapping Tool

Source: own elaboration.

This tool is especially helpful in evaluating the ways in which respondents from Poland (61 responses), Germany (11), and India (7) approach collaboration, leadership, and conflict resolution, as these three nationalities are the most represented in the study. The purpose of this study is to find trends in their communication styles, expectations, workplace behaviours, as well as potential areas of misunderstanding that may arise in international teams, by comparing their answers to Meyer's cultural dimensions (Fig. 3).

Meyer's methodology identifies important cultural differences between Germany, India, and Poland that can greatly impact how well teams perform in global environments. Although both Polish and German professionals value direct communication, Polish professionals frequently exhibit higher flexibility and agility in task execution, whereas Germans typically favour structured decision-making, long-term planning, and a clear division of responsibilities. This disparity could result in different standards for project management and workplace organization. In comparison with Indian individuals who are more used to a formal authority structure where seniority is a key factor in decision-making, German workplace cultures generally maintain a moderate hierarchy based on ability. Furthermore, Indian individuals may utilise more indirect communication patterns to maintain harmony and prevent conflict, which could have an impact on leadership relationships and problem-solving techniques. In contrast, Germans value specific feedback more and unambiguous, task-focused communication. In an analogous way, Polish and Indian individuals have different approaches to hierarchy. While Indians tend to make decisions from the top down, Poles tend to balance rigid and flexible leadership styles. These differences can have an effect on teamwork, especially when it comes to areas that call for reaching consensus and resolving conflicts.

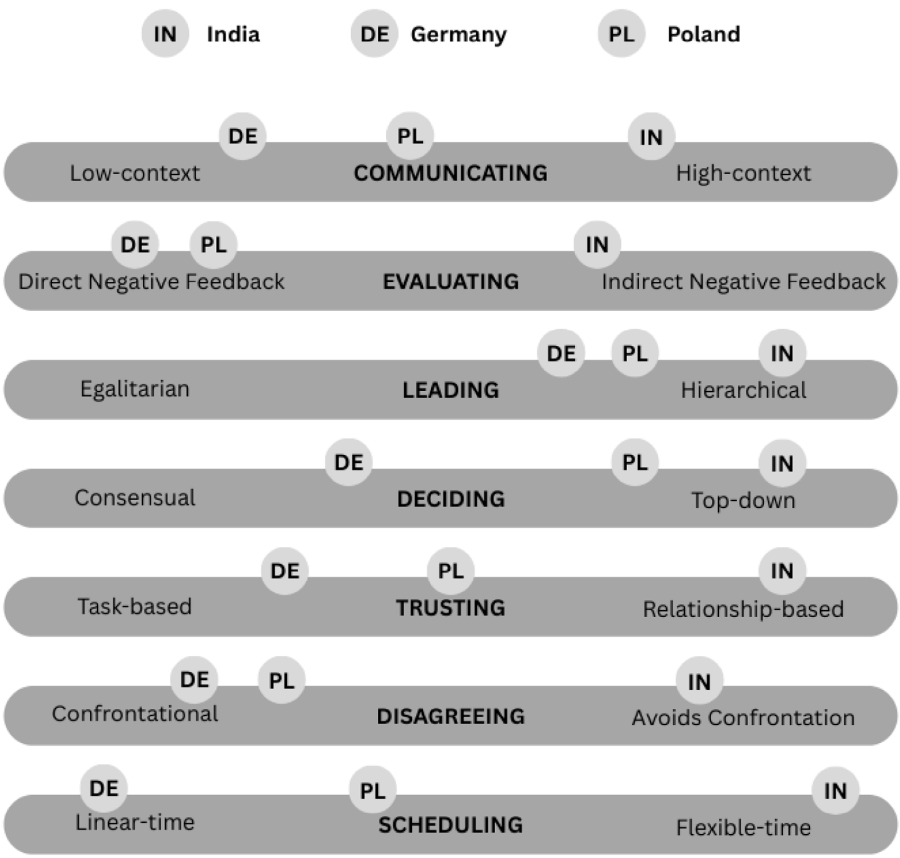

Fig. 3. The Country Mapping Tool (Poland, Germany, India)

Source: own elaboration.

This study intends to determine how these cultural differences impact workplace dynamics and collaboration in multinational teams using Meyer's Country Mapping Tool, providing insights into potential obstacles and tactics for successful cross cultural management.

4. Results

The analysis of the survey data reveals a complex but consistent picture of how cultural diversity is experienced and managed within international work environments. The respondents' overwhelmingly positive opinion of cultural variety is the most remarkable conclusion. Working in multicultural teams fosters creativity, expands perspectives, and improves problem-solving skills, according to the vast majority of participants. These advantages are consistent with a substantial body of research highlighting diversity as a tactical advantage when combined with the right support systems.

According to the research, the majority of people had positive opinions on the advantages of cultural variety. For instance, among the respondents, 56 agreed and 25 strongly agreed that creativity and innovation are fostered by cultural diversity (neutral = 13, disagree = 3, strongly disagree = 2).

Similar trends were found in other benefit-related statements. For example, international teams promote better decision-making by integrating diverse perspectives, with 22 respondents strongly agreeing and 44 agreeing (neutral = 21, disagree = 10, strongly disagree = 2).

Additionally, working in multicultural teams helps people develop problem-solving and adaptability skills. This statement was supported by 41 respondents who agreed and 27 who strongly agreed (neutral = 22, disagree = 7, strongly disagree = 2).

Nevertheless, the data also revealed lasting and structural obstacles that limit the complete achievement of these advantages. These included conflicts in leadership expectations, cultural misunderstandings, and communication issues. All respondent groups widely recognised these problems and were not specific to any one nationality or demographic group, indicating that they are inherent to intercultural collaboration rather than unique situations (Fig. 4).

These problems were further explored by quantitative analysis. According to cross-tabulations between nationality and the frequency of international collaboration, employees from national backgrounds who were less exposed to international work contexts were more likely to report misunderstandings, frustration with indirect communication, or discomfort with ambiguous leadership roles. Younger respondents were also more likely to misinterpret cross-cultural cues, probably as a result of less professional exposure or less developed cultural intelligence, according to a correlation analysis between age groups and reported communication difficulties.

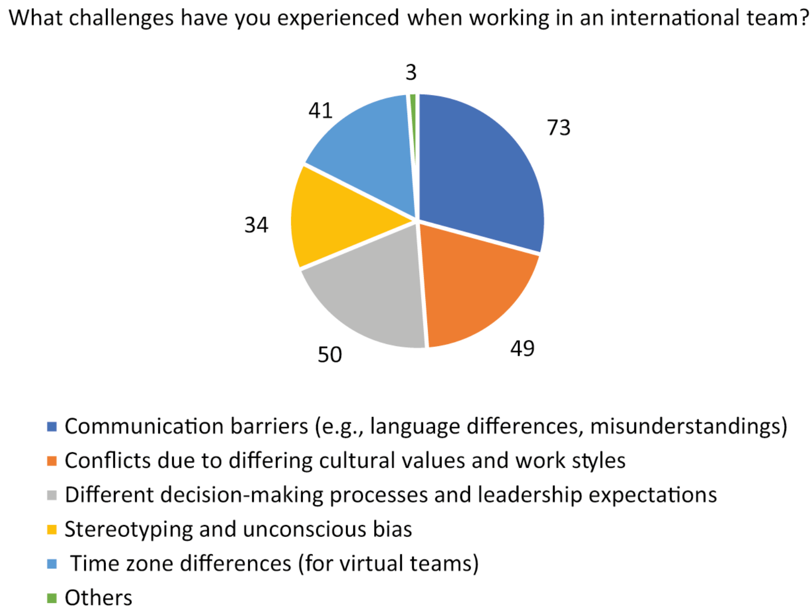

Fig. 4. Respondents' challenges experiences when working in an international team

Source: own elaboration.

The information showed an obvious difference between corporate practice and individual attitudes. Less than half of respondents said their organisations had organised programmes or policies to encourage intercultural effectiveness, despite people generally having a positive opinion of cultural diversity (Fig. 5). A major obstacle is the absence of institutional structure, leaving even well-meaning teams on their own while navigating complexity through trial and error. This increases the likelihood of conflict, inefficiency, and disengagement.

Furthermore, based on the respondents' years of experience in multicultural teams, the study revealed a notable variety of ways in which people experienced the benefits and problems of diversity. The fact that respondents who had more international collaboration experience were much less likely to mention difficulties suggests that exposure, routine, and time all contribute to the development of informal cultural intelligence. This realisation emphasises the necessity of proactive support systems for younger professionals and team members who might not have as much experience.

Combined, these results provide credence to the theoretical claim that cultural variety is neither beneficial nor inherently harmful. Instead, it operates as a hidden potential that needs to be triggered by intentional, inclusive, and strategic management.

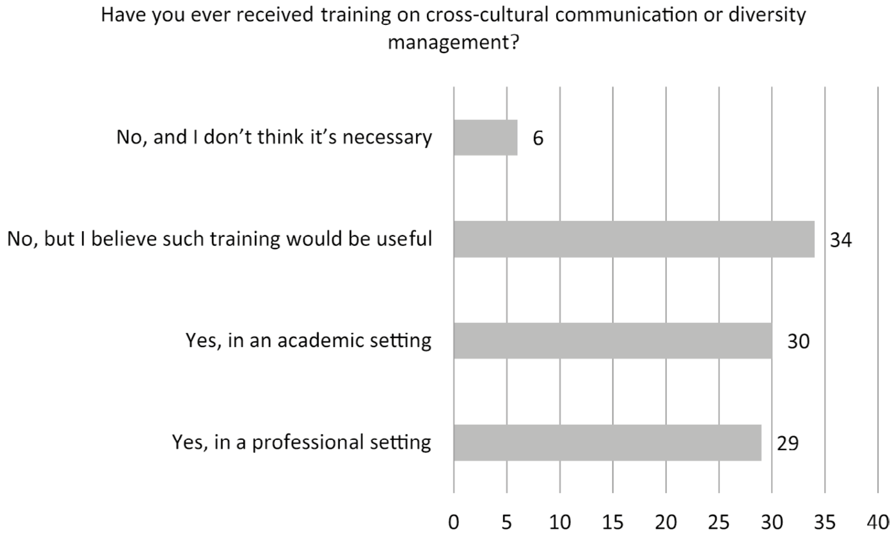

Fig. 5. Respondents' participation in cross-cultural communication or diversity management training

Source: own elaboration.

The results indicate a clear gap between positive attitudes toward cultural diversity and the availability of formal management strategies. While respondents largely recognise the benefits of multicultural teamwork, the limited presence of structured training programmes and diversity management policies suggests that many organisations rely on informal learning rather than deliberate strategic interventions.

5. Discussion

The findings confirm existing literature: cultural diversity can be a competitive advantage when managed effectively (Thomas & Ely, 1996). Diverging communication styles and decision-making processes are common sources of friction.

Nevertheless, companies may mitigate these problems by implementing focused initiatives such as clear communication techniques, open discussion about cultural norms, inclusive leadership, and cross-cultural training (Meyer, 2014).

In addition to interpersonal connections, the study discovered that diversity affects how teams handle criticism, delegation, and time management (Trompenaars & Hampden-Turner, 1998). For instance, teams comprising individuals from polychronic cultures (like those in Latin America) frequently had flexible attitudes towards deadlines, which contrasted with the monochronic tendencies of other teams (like those in Germany or the USA) (Meyer, 2014). These findings suggest that managing expectations around scheduling and accountability should be an explicit part of project planning in multicultural teams.

These results demonstrate that cultural diversity by itself does not guarantee successful outcomes. Instead, how much a company uses conscious management techniques determines how much of an impact it has. The findings support previous research indicating that cross-cultural training, organised communication techniques, and inclusive leadership are essential means of converting diversity into enhanced performance and creativity (Thomas & Ely, 1996; Meyer, 2014). Emerging evidence also highlights the value of conflict resolution strategies rooted in cultural intelligence, which statistically improve intercultural interactions (Guo, 2025).

Due to the exploratory nature of the study and the limited sample size, the findings should be interpreted as indicative rather than fully generalisable.

6. Conclusions

The study demonstrates that although there are many obstacles associated with cultural diversity, such as misunderstandings, stereotyping, and different expectations on decision-making and leadership, there are also many advantages. Training initiatives, inclusive leadership, and strategic communication design are examples of effective tactics. In the post-pandemic era, where cross-border and digital teams are becoming the norm rather than the exception, these ideas are especially relevant. Future studies could further contribute to the field of intercultural management by investigating how cultural dynamics evolve over time in virtual contexts.

In order to promote inclusive practices, employers can also consider including cultural sensitivity into promotion standards and performance reviews. This not only encourages fair professional advancement but also shows an ongoing commitment to embracing diversity (Deal & Kennedy, 2000).

Despite these findings, the study had limitations. The sample structure, dominated by Polish respondents, may have skewed the research findings—particularly regarding national attitudes toward diversity. Furthermore, the information was gathered through self-reported surveys which are useful but do not have the depth and complexity of qualitative techniques like focus groups or interviews. A longitudinal component that could have evaluated the long-term effects of diversity policies was also impeded by time and resource constraints. As an outcome, rather than drawing conclusions that are statistically universal, the results should be viewed as exploratory, providing insights into current behaviours.

Additionally, the study establishes the groundwork for further research. Investigating how diversity management varies by industry, geography, and team type (e.g. remote vs. in-person) might be beneficial. Furthermore, qualitative methods could be used in future studies to gain a deeper understanding of team members' and leaders' actual experiences determining cultural complexity. In the end, the necessity of advanced intercultural management will only increase as globalisation continues to transform the workplace, and with it, the significance of understanding and addressing the human aspect of cultural difference.

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Zarządzanie różnicami kulturowymi w organizacjach międzynarodowych

Streszczenie: Autorka analizuje strategie, trudności i korzyści płynące z pracy w środowisku wielokulturowym, omawiając problemy związane z zarządzaniem różnorodnością kulturową w zespołach międzynarodowych. Głównym celem badania było określenie najskuteczniejszych technik ograniczania konfliktów kulturowych i wspierania współpracy w organizacjach globalnych. Badanie opiera się na podejściu ilościowym oraz ankiecie przeprowadzonej wśród 102 osób z doświadczeniem w zespołach wielokulturowych. Wyniki pokazują, że chociaż różnorodność kulturowa jest postrzegana jako atut, nieporozumienia i konflikty między różnymi stylami pracy stanowią realne wyzwania. Wskazano, że jasna komunikacja, zróżnicowane szkolenia i inkluzywne przywództwo są kluczowe dla sukcesu.

Słowa kluczowe: różnorodność kulturowa, zarządzanie międzykulturowe, zespoły wielonarodowe, kultura organizacyjna, komunikacja międzykulturowa

Debiuty studenckie
Student debuts

DOI: 10.15611/2026.35.7.09
JEL Classification: M10, M15, O32

The Role of Agile Project Management in a Pandemic Business Environment

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Quote as: Wilk, W. (2026). The Role of Agile Project Management in a Pandemic Business Environment. In J. Radomska, & A. Witek-Crabb (Eds.), *New Trends in Business Management. Culture, Strategy, Engagement* (pp. 103-115). Publishing House of Wroclaw University of Economics and Business.

Abstract: This chapter explores how Agile Project Management (APM) helped organisations respond to the challenges brought by the COVID-19 pandemic. The analysis focuses on four cases within sectors such as pharmaceuticals, lab testing, automotive, and healthcare, showing how each organisation applied agile practices in different ways. The aim of the research is to understand how agile practices were adapted under crisis conditions and what lessons can be drawn for the future of project management. The study employs a multiple case study methodology, based on secondary data and thematic cross-case analysis. The findings indicate that while Agile was rarely implemented in a formal way, its core principles proved essential in managing uncertainty. The results suggest that agility is not only effective during crises but also supports long-term resilience and adaptability in complex environments.

Keywords: Agile Project Management (APM), COVID-19 pandemic, organisational agility, crisis management

1. Introduction

The COVID-19 pandemic marked a pivotal turning point for organisations worldwide. Practically overnight it reshaped how teams collaborated, how decisions were made, and how projects were executed under unprecedented pressure. Entire sectors found themselves at the forefront of the global response, most notably healthcare, pharmaceuticals, manufacturing, and diagnostic testing. These industries were challenged with urgent and complex responsibilities such as the rapid development of vaccines, the creation of large-scale testing infrastructures, the management of disrupted and fragile supply chains, and the continued delivery of essential medical services. All of this occurred under conditions of extreme uncertainty, resource scarcity, and constant change.

The crisis revealed deep structural weaknesses in many organisations and exposed the limitations of traditional project management approaches. Predictive methodologies such as Waterfall or PRINCE2 are built on assumptions of stability: clearly defined goals, sequential phases, and detailed upfront planning. While these methods offer control and predictability, they proved poorly suited to the volatile and rapidly shifting environment of the pandemic, where requirements changed daily, new risks constantly emerged, and teams had to act without complete information.

In this context, the need for adaptive and responsive methods became urgent. Many organisations, often without consciously labelling their approach, turned to practices aligned with Agile Project Management (APM). Agile, initially developed within the software development industry, is grounded in flexibility, iterative planning, continuous feedback, and stakeholder collaboration. It enables teams to pivot quickly, deliver value incrementally, and involve multiple stakeholders in decision-making processes. During the pandemic, these qualities aligned closely with the challenges faced by organisations under pressure to innovate and act decisively.

Although Agile methodologies were well established in IT before 2020, their wider adoption across other industries remained limited and under-researched. The pandemic created an extraordinary opportunity to observe how Agile could be applied in non-technical contexts and in circumstances far more turbulent than those it was originally designed for. For many organisations, Agile was not implemented in a formalised manner, but its principles nonetheless permeated crisis response strategies and enabled resilience in the face of chaos.

The main aim of this article is to identify and explain why Agile Project Management proved effective for organisations operating under extreme uncertainty during the COVID-19 pandemic. Rather than focusing solely on whether Agile approaches were applied, the article seeks to analyse which characteristics of Agile Project Management enabled organisations to adapt, maintain continuity, and deliver results in a highly turbulent environment.

The study examines four case studies drawn from different sectors—pharmaceuticals, laboratory testing, the automotive industry, and healthcare—in order to explore how Agile practices were applied in practice and how they differed from traditional project management approaches under crisis conditions. By analysing cases from diverse organisational and industry contexts, the article aims to identify the mechanisms through which Agile principles supported organisational resilience, rapid decision making, and adaptability during the pandemic, and to contribute to the discussion of Agile's role beyond the IT sector. The findings also offer insights into the relevance of Agile as a crisis management approach and its implications for the future of project management in the post-pandemic world.

2. Literature Review

Agility, derived from the Latin term *agere*, meaning ‘to drive or act’, refers to the ability to move swiftly, adapt smoothly, and respond resourcefully to changing circumstances. In project management, agility is associated with ownership, authority, adaptability, and resourcefulness (White, 2008). Agile organisations are designed for unpredictable conditions. They operate as networks of teams, emphasising collaboration, cross-functional workflows, and rapid decision-making (Project Management Institute [PMI], 2017; Ritter et al., 2023). In such settings, continuous feedback and short learning cycles become the norm, enabling organisations to adapt quickly to external shocks.

In contrast, traditional project management methodologies such as Waterfall or PRINCE2 rely on linear stages, comprehensive upfront planning, and limited flexibility. The Waterfall model, for example, assumes that requirements can be fully defined at the outset and executed sequentially, from design through implementation and maintenance (PMI, 2021). While these methods ensure control and predictability, they struggle to accommodate sudden changes and unanticipated risks, which made them less effective during a crisis such as the COVID-19 pandemic.

Agile methodologies such as Scrum and Kanban emerged as adaptive alternatives. The Agile Manifesto (published in 2001) introduced four values: prioritising individuals over processes, working prototypes over documentation, customer collaboration over closed-door meetings, and swift responses to change over rigid planning (McKinsey & Company, 2023). Scrum focuses on iterative cycles (‘sprints’), defined team roles, and continuous feedback loops (Schwaber & Sutherland, 2020). Kanban, with roots in Japanese manufacturing, visualises workflows to optimise flexibility and responsiveness (McKinsey & Company, 2023). These frameworks are not identical, but they share a common emphasis on adaptability and value delivery in uncertain contexts.

Before COVID-19, Agile was widely used in IT but was gradually spreading into other industries, such as finance, healthcare, and manufacturing (Handscomb et al., 2020). In finance, Agile supported faster product development and customer-centred services. In healthcare, it enabled more flexible clinical trial designs and collaborative responses to regulatory changes. In manufacturing, Agile approaches were increasingly visible in supply chain management and lean production processes. The pandemic accelerated this trend dramatically. Organisational agility became a key determinant of survival and competitiveness during lockdowns, supply chain crises, and mass transitions to remote work (Biçer, 2021). Research confirmed that Agile organisations were more resilient and adapted faster than those relying on traditional models (Alicke et al., 2020; Anderssen et al., 2020).

Remote and hybrid work became central to Agile practice during the pandemic. Agile ceremonies such as stand-ups, sprint reviews, and retrospectives, originally designed for co-located teams, were successfully transferred online through tools like Teams, Zoom, and Slack (Comella-Dorda et al., 2020). This shift highlighted both the resilience and the vulnerability of Agile. While digital tools allowed teams to maintain continuity, they also required cultural and organisational adjustments to preserve trust, cohesion, and engagement in virtual environments.

Organisational culture plays a crucial role in Agile adoption. According to Hofstede's dimensions, Agile thrives in low power distance, collectivist, and flexible cultures, but faces resistance in hierarchical or risk-averse environments (Bogale & Debela, 2024). The Competing Values Framework (Rizi et al., 2024) further demonstrates that group-oriented and developmental cultures create fertile ground for Agile, while rigid, rule-bound cultures hinder its effectiveness. Research by PMI (2024) confirmed that enabling mechanisms such as training, coaching, and employee resource groups directly improve project performance and Agile outcomes.

Finally, literature increasingly highlights that the future of project management lies not in a strict dichotomy between Agile and traditional approaches, but in their integration. Hybrid models that combine the adaptability of Agile with the structure of predictive methods are gaining traction. At the same time, the integration of Artificial Intelligence and data-driven tools is expected to further transform project management, enhancing predictive capabilities while still requiring Agile mindsets to ensure responsiveness and stakeholder focus. The pandemic, therefore, not only validated Agile's effectiveness under crisis conditions but also positioned it as a foundation for the evolution of project management in the years to come.

3. Research Design

Given the complexity of Agile adoption during a global crisis, a qualitative research design was chosen as the most suitable approach. Qualitative research allows for a nuanced understanding of phenomena that are difficult to quantify and provides insights into processes, behaviours, and organisational dynamics that emerge in context. Since the aim of the study was not to measure outcomes statistically but to understand how Agile principles were applied in practice across industries, a qualitative design was considered the most appropriate.

Within this framework, a multiple case study methodology was adopted. Case studies are particularly valuable in project management research because they enable the investigation of contemporary phenomena in real-life settings where the boundaries between the phenomenon and its context are blurred (Yin, 2012). The multiple-case approach provided opportunities for both within-case analysis—examining the specifics of Agile adoption in individual organisations—and cross-case analysis, allowing for the identification of similarities, differences, and recurring patterns across industries. This comparative element was critical for drawing broader conclusions about Agile in crisis contexts.

Case selection followed a purposeful sampling strategy which is commonly used in qualitative research to examine information-rich cases that offer deep insight into the studied phenomenon. The cases were selected not to prove statistical representativeness, but to enable analytical comparison and to identify recurring mechanisms of Agile Project Management operating under conditions of extreme uncertainty.

Three key criteria guided the selection process. First, each case had to demonstrate clear relevance to Agile Project Management during the COVID-19 pandemic, either through explicit use of Agile practices or through informal application of Agile principles in crisis response. Second, the cases were chosen to ensure sectoral diversity, allowing the analysis to go beyond the IT context and to explore how Agile characteristics functioned across different organisational and institutional environments. Third, each case had to be supported by sufficiently detailed and credible secondary sources, enabling systematic analysis and cross-case comparison.

Based on these criteria, four cases were selected: AstraZeneca's vaccine development project in partnership with Oxford University, Lighthouse Labs testing facilities in the United Kingdom, the response of the Moroccan automotive industry to supply chain disruptions, and crisis management practices in Polish healthcare organisations. Together, these cases represent contrasting organisational contexts, while sharing a common condition of high uncertainty, which makes them particularly suitable for examining why and how Agile Project Management contributed to effective organisational responses during the pandemic.

Data collection relied exclusively on secondary sources. These included academic publications, industry and consultancy reports, documents published by the Project Management Institute, company statements, and other institutional resources. Using secondary data was appropriate in this context because the pandemic limited opportunities for primary research, while at the same time generating a vast body of accessible documentation and analysis. To ensure the credibility and robustness of findings, data from multiple sources were triangulated, which helped reduce bias and strengthen reliability (Yin, 2012).

Data analysis proceeded in several stages. The first stage involved thematic synthesis, where key concepts such as adaptability, collaboration, digital transformation, and leadership were identified across the cases. The second stage employed pattern matching, comparing the empirical evidence from case studies with theoretical expectations derived from the literature on Agile Project Management. Finally, a cross-case comparison was conducted to highlight recurring themes as well as context-specific differences. This structured approach to analysis allowed for the generation of insights that are both empirically grounded and theoretically informed. This analytical process made it possible to move beyond descriptive accounts of Agile adoption and to focus on explaining why specific Agile characteristics proved effective in enabling organisational responses under conditions of high uncertainty.

The chosen methodology, therefore, enabled a comprehensive examination of Agile Project Management in the pandemic context. It provided not only detailed insights into individual organisational practices but also broader conclusions about the role of agility in managing crises, thereby addressing the research gap identified in the introduction.

4. Research Findings

Rather than presenting the case studies as isolated examples, the findings are analysed through a cross-case perspective that focuses on the key characteristics of Agile Project Management as underlying mechanisms of organisational response. The analysis highlights how specific Agile features enabled organisations to cope with uncertainty, adapt to rapidly changing conditions, and maintain operational effectiveness during the COVID-19 pandemic.

The first case study focused on AstraZeneca's vaccine development project, carried out in partnership with Oxford University. The partnership was formally announced on April 30th, 2020, and within just two weeks AstraZeneca committed to delivering 30 million doses to the UK by September of the same year and a total of 100 million doses overall (UK Research and Innovation [UKRI], 2021). From the very beginning, the company was under enormous pressure to deliver results within an unprecedented timeframe. Traditional project management methods, based on lengthy sequential stages, would have been unsuitable for this challenge. Instead, AstraZeneca relied on Agile principles to structure its processes. The work was organised iteratively, with multiple phases of testing and development carried out in parallel rather than consecutively. This approach not only shortened the overall timeline but also enabled teams to adjust quickly when unexpected results occurred during trials.

Cross-functional collaboration played a critical role, as scientists, regulators, supply chain managers, and production specialists worked in integrated teams rather than as isolated units. Agile practices supported frequent communication and knowledge sharing, reducing bottlenecks and ensuring alignment across global stakeholders. By early 2021, AstraZeneca had secured vaccine orders on a global scale and rapidly expanded production and distribution under unprecedented time pressure. According to AstraZeneca's reports, by July 2021 more than one billion doses had been delivered to over 170 countries, distributed on a not-for-profit basis during the pandemic period. Importantly, a substantial proportion of doses were supplied to lower and middle-income countries, demonstrating a commitment to equitable access. This case illustrated how iterative planning and cross-functional collaboration operated as core Agile mechanisms, enabling rapid adaptation to regulatory, scientific, and logistical uncertainties.

The second case examined the Lighthouse Labs network in the United Kingdom, which was established in 2020 to meet the rapidly growing demand for COVID-19 testing. In this high-pressure environment, the ability to scale capacity was essential. Agile methods provided the framework for rapid team formation, flexible workflows, and constant adaptation to changing circumstances. Within weeks, interdisciplinary teams composed of scientists, healthcare professionals, and logistics experts were assembled and trained. The labs introduced adaptive workflows, continuously updated to respond to shifts in demand, availability of testing kits, and staffing constraints. Problem-solving processes were deliberately kept flexible: bottlenecks were identified quickly, discussed in short iterative cycles, and resolved without lengthy approval chains. This approach enabled teams to respond immediately to emerging challenges rather than waiting for centralised approval, significantly reducing response times. As a result, the Lighthouse Labs were able to expand their daily testing capacity far beyond initial projections, scaling from 41 to 85 000 tests per day within a matter of months. This case demonstrates that decentralised decision-making and flexible workflows, central to Agile thinking, were critical mechanisms enabling rapid scaling in a high-pressure public health context.

The third case focused on the Moroccan automotive industry which faced severe disruptions to its supply chains during the pandemic. With global logistics paralysed and demand patterns shifting, companies had to act decisively to avoid long-term collapse. Agile supply chain practices played a crucial role in mitigating these risks. Firms adopted flexible resource allocation systems, enabling rapid adjustments in production schedules and supplier relationships. Planning processes were restructured to allow for continuous monitoring and revision, rather than fixed annual or quarterly cycles. Digital tools were introduced to provide real-time visibility into supply chain operations, allowing managers to anticipate delays and redistribute resources accordingly. Agile-inspired workflows prioritised responsiveness over rigid adherence to predefined plans, enabling faster reactions to external shocks. This case demonstrates how adaptive planning, flexible resource allocation, and real-time data use functioned as core Agile mechanisms, allowing organisations to absorb supply chain disruptions, relocate resources dynamically, and maintain operational continuity under conditions of extreme uncertainty.

The fourth case analysed Polish healthcare organisations which were under extraordinary strain during the COVID-19 pandemic. Hospitals and clinics had to manage high infection rates, shortages of equipment, and rapidly changing government regulations. In this context, Agile methods became an essential component of crisis management. Remote coordination was introduced to maintain collaboration between dispersed teams of healthcare managers, administrators, and medical professionals. Risk management strategies were applied iteratively, with priorities redefined on a daily basis in response to emerging data on infection rates, staff availability, and patient needs. Digital transformation played a significant role, as healthcare organisations implemented new tools for communication, data sharing, and patient monitoring. At the same time, Agile leadership styles began to emerge. Managers were required to move away from rigid hierarchical structures and empower frontline teams to make rapid operational decisions. This case highlights how distributed leadership and iterative risk management functioned as core Agile mechanisms, enabling healthcare organisations to respond more effectively to rapidly evolving crisis conditions and maintain their essential services.

4.1. Cross-Functional Collaboration and Communication

Cross-functional collaboration and communication emerged as a recurring characteristic across all analysed cases and functioned as a key Agile mechanism enabling rapid organisational response under conditions of high uncertainty. Agile practices reduced functional silos and facilitated continuous information exchange, which proved critical when operating environments were changing rapidly. In AstraZeneca's vaccine development project, collaboration between scientific, regulatory, and supply chain teams enabled parallel rather than sequential work, significantly accelerating development and distribution process. Similarly, the Lighthouse Labs relied on interdisciplinary teams that could be rapidly assembled and reconfigured to address operational bottlenecks during scaling. In Polish healthcare organisations, remote collaboration tools supported coordination between dispersed medical and administrative teams, allowing priorities to be adjusted daily in response to evolving conditions. These findings indicate that Agile-supported collaboration shortened feedback loops and reduced coordination delays, increasing organisational responsiveness during crisis situations.

4.2. Decentralised Decision-Making and Adaptive Leadership

Another prominent mechanism observed across the cases was the shift towards decentralised decision-making and adaptive leadership. Agile principles encouraged the delegation of authority to teams operating closest to emerging problems, enabling faster and more context-sensitive responses. At Lighthouse Labs, frontline teams were empowered to resolve operational issues without waiting for central approval, which supported rapid capacity expansion. In the Moroccan automotive industry, managers adjusted production schedules and supplier relationships in real time in response to supply chain disruptions. In Polish healthcare organisations, decision-making authority was increasingly distributed to frontline staff, reflecting a temporary departure from rigid hierarchical structures. This decentralisation reduced response times and allowed organisations to adapt more effectively to unpredictable and rapidly changing crisis conditions. This mechanism proved particularly effective in crisis contexts, where delayed decisions could significantly increase operational costs.

4.3. Iterative Planning and Adaptive Risk Management

Iterative planning and continuous reassessment of priorities were another Agile mechanism identified across all the cases. Rather than relying on fixed plans, organisations applied short planning cycles and frequent reviews, which enabled ongoing adaptation as new information became available. In the AstraZeneca case, iterative testing and development cycles allowed teams to respond quickly to unexpected trial outcomes and regulatory requirements. Polish healthcare organisations redefined operational priorities on a daily basis based on real-time data concerning infection rates, staff availability, and patient needs. Similarly, companies in the Moroccan automotive sector replaced rigid planning cycles with continuous monitoring and revision of supply chain strategies. These practices allowed organisations to manage disruptions proactively and reduce the risks associated with long-term planning in volatile environments.

4.4. Digital Enablement as a Facilitator of Agility

Digital technologies played a supporting but critical role in enabling Agile mechanisms across all cases. Rather than acting merely as substitutes for face-to-face interaction, digital tools facilitated transparency, coordination, and real-time decision-making. In healthcare and pharmaceutical contexts, platforms such as Teams and Zoom enabled continuous coordination despite physical separation. In the Moroccan automotive industry, digital monitoring systems provided real-time visibility into supply chain operations, allowing managers to anticipate disruptions and relocate resources accordingly. These tools reinforced Agile practices by supporting rapid feedback and data-driven decision making. Overall, digital enablement strengthened organisational agility by increasing information availability and supporting timely responses under crisis conditions.

Table 1 provides a concise summary and comparison of the results obtained from all four case studies.

Table 1. Comparison of findings across four case studies

Theme	AstraZeneca	Lighthouse Labs	Moroccan Automotive	Polish Healthcare
Collaboration and Communication	Cross-functional global teams, real-time info sharing	Interdisciplinary rapid teams, adaptive workflows	Coordination with suppliers via digital tools	Remote collaboration platforms for managers & staff
Leadership and Decision-making	Distributed leadership across science/ regulation/supply	Empowered teams, fast problem-solving without hierarchy	Managers adapt plans in real time	Shift from hierarchy to frontline empowerment
Digital Transformation	Digital tools to accelerate trials & global distribution	Adaptive data systems for scaling capacity	Real-time supply chain monitoring & digital dashboards	E-health, digital communication & patient monitoring

Theme	AstraZeneca	Lighthouse Labs	Moroccan Automotive	Polish Healthcare
Organisational Culture	Innovative, collaborative, open to experimentation	Startup-like adaptability, trust-based	Needed shift toward responsiveness, flexibility	Hierarchical resistance slowed adoption, but adaptation occurred
Agile Practices	Iterative parallel development, informal Agile use	Agile-inspired workflows, continuous cycles	Informal Agile in supply chain planning	Iterative risk management, emergent Agile leadership

Source: own elaboration based on the case studies.

The comparison presented in Tab. 1 highlights that similar Agile mechanisms were observed across all analysed sectors despite significant differences in organisational contexts. In particular, cross-functional collaboration, decentralised decision-making, and iterative planning consistently supported rapid organisational adaptation during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Taken together, the cross-case analysis demonstrates that even when Agile Project Management was not formally implemented, its core principles operated as effective mechanisms of organisational response during the COVID-19 pandemic. Whether in vaccine development, large-scale testing, supply chain reorganisation, or healthcare management, agility was central to project performance. Iterative planning, decentralised decision-making, cross-functional collaboration, flexibility, and digital enablement consistently supported organisational adaptability and resilience across diverse sectors. Rather than functioning as a rigid methodology, Agile acted as a flexible framework that helped organisations to cope with extreme uncertainty, maintain operational continuity, and achieve effective outcomes in crisis-driven environments.

5. Conclusions

The study demonstrates that Agile Project Management constituted an effective organisational response to the unprecedented challenges posed by the COVID-19 pandemic. Its emphasis on flexibility, iterative progress, decentralised decision making, and continuous stakeholder engagement made it significantly more suitable than traditional, predictive approaches in volatile and uncertain environments. Although Agile was rarely implemented as a formalised methodology, its core principles were widely and often intuitively adopted across sectors, including pharmaceuticals, healthcare, manufacturing, and laboratory testing, confirming its relevance beyond the IT.

The research findings indicate that Agile proved effective not simply as a set of tools, but as a collection of mechanisms that enabled organisations to function under extreme uncertainty. Cross-functional collaboration reduced coordination delays, iterative planning allowed for rapid adaptation to changing conditions, decentralised leadership supported faster decision-making, and digital technologies facilitated transparency and real-time information exchange. Together, these mechanisms strengthened organisational responsiveness and resilience during crisis situations.

An important insight emerging from the analysis is the role of organisational culture in shaping Agile effectiveness. Organisations characterised by openness, trust, and collaborative norms were better positioned to apply Agile principles successfully, while rigid hierarchical structures often limited their potential benefits. This suggests that Agile adoption is not only a methodical challenge but also a cultural one, requiring changes in leadership styles and organisational mindsets.

The pandemic also accelerated a broader shift in project management practice, highlighting the limitations of strictly predictive models and reinforcing the value of adaptive and hybrid approaches. Rather than replacing traditional project management entirely, Agile is increasingly combined with established methodologies, allowing organisations to balance control with flexibility depending on project context and environmental conditions.

Looking ahead, the findings suggest that the future of project management will be shaped by the interaction between Agile principles and emerging digital technologies. Tools based on Artificial Intelligence, such as predictive analytics and data-driven decision-support systems, have the potential to reinforce key Agile mechanisms identified in this research, particularly helping project teams anticipate risks and allocate resources. Moreover, machine learning algorithms may automate repetitive tasks, leaving human teams to focus on creative and strategic work. When embedded within an Agile-oriented organisational culture, such technologies may enhance adaptability rather than create additional rigidity.

In this context, hybrid project management approaches are likely to become increasingly prevalent. Organisations will combine the discipline of traditional methods with the flexibility of Agile, choosing the best elements of each depending on project context. This evolution will require project managers to develop ambidexterity—the ability to balance control and adaptability, planning and improvisation. Training and education in project management will need to reflect this shift, equipping future leaders with skills to operate across methodological boundaries.

Another important implication concerns organisational resilience and sustainability. The pandemic underscored the need for organisations not only to react quickly to crises but also to build long-term capacity to withstand disruption. Agile principles, particularly continuous learning and stakeholder engagement, align closely with these objectives and can support organisations in adapting to regulatory, environmental, and social challenges.

The study is subject to certain limitations. The analysis is based exclusively on secondary data and focuses on a limited number of case studies, which restricts the generalisability of the findings. Future research could address these limitations by incorporating primary data, such as interviews with project managers, and by examining a wider range of organisational and cultural contexts.

In conclusion, Agile Project Management has proven to be more than a temporary crisis response. The evidence from the analysed cases suggests that Agile functions as a flexible and resilient approach that supports effective decision-making, adaptability, and collaboration in environments characterised by uncertainty. As organisations continue to face complex and unpredictable challenges, the principles of Agile Project Management are likely to remain central to effective project delivery in the post-pandemic world.

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Rola zwinnego zarządzania projektami w pandemicznym środowisku biznesowym

Streszczenie: W rozdziale opisano badanie, w jaki sposób zwinne zarządzanie projektami pomogło organizacjom sprostać wyzwaniom związanym z pandemią COVID-19. Analiza koncentruje się na czterech studiach przypadków z sektorów takich jak farmacja, testowanie laboratoryjne, przemysł motoryzacyjny oraz opieka zdrowotna, ukazując, jak każda z organizacji wdrażała praktyki zwinne w odmienny sposób. Celem badania jest zrozumienie, jak praktyki *agile* były dostosowywane do warunków kryzysowych oraz jakie wnioski można wyciągnąć dla przyszłości zarządzania projektami. W pracy zastosowano metodę wielokrotnego studium przypadku, opartą na danych wtórnych i analizie tematycznej. Wyniki wskazują, że choć *agile* rzadko był wdrażany w sposób formalny, to jego kluczowe zasady okazały się niezbędne w zarządzaniu niepewnością. Autorka sugeruje, że podejście zwinne nie tylko sprawdza się w czasie kryzysów, ale także wspiera długofalową odporność i zdolność adaptacji w złożonych środowiskach.

Słowa kluczowe: zwinne zarządzanie projektami, pandemia COVID-19, zwinność organizacyjna, zarządzanie kryzysowe

DOI: 10.15611/2026.35.7.10
JEL Classification: M42, M10

Modern ISO Audit in a Medium-Sized Automotive Enterprise

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Quote as: Zapotoczny, M. (2026). Modern ISO Audit in a Medium-Sized Automotive Enterprise. In J. Radomska, & A. Witek-Crabb (Eds.), *New Trends in Business Management. Culture, Strategy, Engagement* (pp. 116-128). Publishing House of Wroclaw University of Economics and Business.

Abstract: The aim of the chapter is to assess the effectiveness of a modern approach to internal auditing in a medium-sized enterprise in the automotive industry, operating based on an integrated ISO management system. The research object was a business entity employing approximately 150-200 people, in which both process audits (traditional) and system audits (modern) were conducted. The research process employed a diagnostic survey carried out among employees, as well as an analysis of organisational documentation and audit indicators. Considering the research results, the observed employees rated process audits highly, considering them practical and less burdensome, while system audits raised concerns related to excessive workload, delays, and limited impartiality. The analysis of quantitative data confirmed the higher effectiveness of process audits. The conclusion is that, in the conditions of a medium-sized, centralised enterprise, the traditional auditing model remains a more adequate solution, ensuring effectiveness and proportionality to the available resources.

Keywords: internal audit, process audit, system audit, automotive industry, comparative analysis

1. Introduction

Audit, in its various forms, is currently gaining increasing significance in organisations operating across numerous industries. This results primarily from the growing number of compliance requirements, encompassing customer expectations, international standards (e.g. ISO), industry-specific standards, as well as national and international legal regulations (e.g. those of the European Union). Increasingly often, even small enterprises are expected to meet requirements related to diverse aspects of business activity which may seem, at first glance, unrelated to their fundamental operations, such as requirements in the areas of ethics or environmental protection.

Alongside the growing awareness of customers, the confirmation of compliance gains value and contributes to the dynamic development of the audit sector. This development can be analysed in different directions. On the one hand, in the technical aspect, associated with the use of modern technologies for data processing; on the other, in the context of the evolving role of the auditor. The technical aspect ensures that data analysis takes less time and allows for faster verification of numerous quantitative issues, which proves particularly effective in financial audits. Meanwhile, the role of the auditor is evolving towards that of an advisor, a transformation driven by enterprises' pursuit of sustainable development and greater emphasis on relationships.

In this study, particular attention is given to the growing importance of the auditor's role which is less frequently confined to verifying a checklist and more often assumes the position of an advisor who significantly influences the development of the enterprise.

The aim of this study is to assess the usefulness of a modern approach to internal audits in a medium-sized enterprise from the automotive industry, analysed through the prism of compliance with the requirements of an integrated management system based on ISO standards. The research results enabled, among other things, the confrontation of audit outcomes with subjective assessments and opinions expressed by employees of the enterprise under observation. The anticipated results of the study indicate the achievement of a significant level of acceptance for both analysed forms of audit. At the same time, it is expected that the respondents' answers will confirm the complementary character of the examined solutions, suggesting that both forms of audit not only function in parallel but also mutually reinforce one another, creating a coherent and effective mechanism for evaluating organizational processes.

With the intention of presenting a comprehensive picture and an adequate evaluation of the implementation of internal audit practices, the adopted research methodology referred both to the analysis of the literature, organisational documentation, and key performance indicators in the enterprise under study, as well as to the opinions of employees expressed in the conducted survey.

2. Theoretical Background

Humans undertook various auditing activities thousands of years before our era. In ancient Mesopotamia, such audits took the form of verifying accounting records on papyrus (Mazurek & Piołunowicz, 2008, p. 7). Similar operations occurred in ancient Rome, where an official 'audited' the accounts (from the Latin *auditor*—'listener'), verifying their content against the records of another official. Thus, it can be concluded that the earliest audits were limited to financial issues and to controlling the quality of accountants' work (Herdan et al., 2009, p. 55).

A history of auditing closer to modernity can be linked to the development of trade in Italian cities. With growing commercial expansion, double-entry bookkeeping was introduced, which increased the demand for control. The distinct separation of the auditor's profession took place during the Industrial Revolution in Great Britain in the 18th century (Herdan et al., 2009, pp. 55, 56). At that time, auditors gradually moved away from purely financial matters and began to focus more on operational issues. This period of transformation lasted until the turn of the 19th and 20th centuries, related to vast investments in railway construction (Piszczyk, 2004, p. 42). Nevertheless, financial auditing was not abandoned, as demand arose due to British investment expansion in the United States. For instance, in the 19th century, bankers required independent financial audits of American contractors' enterprises before investing their funds. This constituted external auditing mandated by the provisions of the British Commercial Code (Herdan et al., 2009, p. 56).

Accounting issues remained the only aspect of auditing until the 20th century, when a significant increase in the complexity of operations was observed. During this period, auditors began focusing on the core activities of economic entities, although their role remained confined to verifying compliance with applicable regulations. The need to expand auditor competencies and the aspiration of large corporations to become independent from statutory auditors led to a clear division between internal and external auditors.

In the 1970s, auditors increasingly evaluated the efficiency and effectiveness of departmental activities. The role of the auditor began to shift towards that of an advisor rather than a controller traditionally seeking only nonconformities. This approach expanded further in the 1990s, when attention was drawn to the fact that an auditor should not verify only a selected element of an enterprise's structure, but should consider it within the context of the company as a coherent whole (Mazurek & Piołunowicz, 2008, p. 7). At that time, the auditor ceased to be merely a controller and instead became, in essence, an advisor helping to improve processes, thanks to possessing extensive knowledge of the enterprise (Gabrusewicz et al., 2015, p. 75).

Due to this developmental trajectory, the concept of auditing can easily be confused with internal control. Although both notions may evoke similar associations, they differ in scope of authority and in perspective toward the enterprise as an organization. Control reacts to a situation that has already occurred—that is, it acts after a problem is detected. Auditing, on the other hand, functions more preventively and advisory in relation to risk, owing to the auditor's independence. Control is often based solely on the internal arrangements of an enterprise, aimed at identifying a particular person responsible for an error, whereas auditing focuses on the functioning of the enterprise in relation to legal provisions or standards (Knedler & Stasiak, 2010, p. 15).

Audit is a broad concept that can adopt various definitions depending on the source. One of the most popular definitions of audit is provided in the ISO 9000 standard, which defines it as "a systematic, independent and documented process for obtaining objective evidence and evaluating it objectively to determine the extent to which audit criteria are fulfilled" (Polski Komitet Normalizacyjny [PKN], 2015, p. 34). This definition highlights features that characterise a reliable and robust audit, namely:

- **Systematic nature** – referring to the cyclical conduct of audits. ISO 9001 explicitly states that audits should be carried out at "planned intervals," thus cyclically according to the enterprise's established needs (PKN, 2016, p. 26).
- **Independence** – a feature excluding conflict of interest during auditing, meaning that an auditor cannot conduct an audit in an area where they act as the owner. If such a situation were possible, the action would be deemed ineffective and an obstacle to continuous organisational development (PKN, 2016, p. 26).
- **Documented** – audit information, i.e., reports, collected evidence, entries in nonconformity registers, etc., constitutes confirmation that the audit took place, and its results can be presented to the commissioning authority, usually top management (PKN, 2016, p. 26).

Numerous types of audits are identified, depending on their context—for example, financial, tax, ethical, ecological, environmental, marketing, informational, knowledge-based, human capital, or personnel audits. Defining the term 'audit' is problematic precisely due to the wide range of activities that may be included. These may involve various specialisations, such as finance, industry, or even purely humanistic issues; therefore, in relation to a specific audited area, the relevant definition should be applied. All types of audits constitute adaptations of a structured form of documenting the reliability of production and services (Kuc, 2002, p. 72).

The most adequate definition of auditing in relation to production or manufacturing issues is its interpretation as a method of verifying the conformity of a process/system/product with its requirements and a means of continuous improvement through the identification of improvement areas. Each of the three types of operational audits is characterised by distinct features that determine its scope, implementation, and potential applications, as follows:

- **Process audit** – the audit of a single, specific process. During a process audit, the auditor uses work instructions, flow diagrams, and turtle diagrams to assess whether the execution of an operation complies with the documentation of that process.
- **System audit** – the verification of conformity, e.g., of a management system with a global standard, such as ISO 9001 for quality management. Systems, in this case, are simple sets of requirements defining the planning, implementation, monitoring, and control of processes to achieve defined objectives.
- **Product audit** – a type of audit often confused with final inspection, since it is performed on a finished product. Beyond confirming conformity, the product

audit provides information on whether requirements have been properly defined and whether the product can be improved in line with the concept of continuous improvement.

Another criterion for dividing audits is the party subjected to audit. Three possibilities are distinguished, each associated with different risks and serving different functions, described below:

- **First-party audit** – internal audits conducted by auditors within the same enterprise. This type of audit entails significant risk due to the auditor's potential bias toward the audited area (The Institute of Internal Auditors [IIA], 2016, p. 3). The presence of internal audits is frequently an external requirement subject to certification, such as ISO 9001.
- **Second-party audit** – audits of suppliers (or customers), i.e., verification of whether the supplier meets the requirements specified in the contract and to which they have committed.
- **Third-party audit** – audits commissioned externally, carried out by independent entities.

Auditing is inherently associated with the concept of the auditor, the individual conducting the audit. The auditor compares actual conditions with specific criteria, thereby identifying nonconformities exclusively against clearly defined rules established by the commissioning party. Nonconformities must derive from standards, customer requirements, applicable law, or technical drawings. All additional observations provided by the auditor are merely indications of potential areas for improvement. It should also be recognised that the auditor may act only within the designated scope, meaning their verification is limited strictly to the defined audit area (Midor, 2013, p. 73).

Modern enterprises are characterised by a high degree of flexibility in shaping the scope of internal audits. Organisations, considering the specificity of their activities, current market conditions, and strategic priorities, independently determine the scope of audits and decide on their directions. This practice enables the adjustment of audit activities to the most up-to-date needs, thereby increasing the effectiveness of system evaluation and improvement processes. Enterprises decide not only which areas are covered by audits but also how the auditing process is conducted—whether it is focused on selected processes, system aspects, or the overall assessment of organizational functioning.

Currently, we are on the threshold of an industrial revolution associated with artificial intelligence, which is also reflected in the technical dimension of auditing. The most likely area for development is the streamlining of processes related to financial data analysis, document processing, and deviation identification. AI algorithms can also enhance analytical accuracy, particularly in detecting anomalies and risks. A significant advantage of artificial intelligence in the context of auditing is its time efficiency, as it processes information far more rapidly. The overall development of auditing necessitates the advancement of auditors' competencies, compelling them to expand their knowledge of new technologies. Alongside the considerable benefits brought by new technologies, challenges related to ethical and legal aspects also emerge, which in the future may themselves become subjects of auditing.

3. Characteristics of Internal Audits in the Analysed Enterprise

The observed automotive enterprise limits its activities to the design and assembly of vehicles from delivered components, which requires employing between 150 and 200 people at any given time (including external workers). Within the organisational structure of this enterprise, the President plays a central and leading role, being the direct superior of department managers, who in turn are responsible for their assigned specialists/operators. As part of its integrated management system, the analysed enterprise adopted a dual structure of internal audits, thus including both system audits and process audits. Both types of audits are defined in separate procedures (Fig. 1). Process audits were defined in a way that allows them to be described as classical, whereas system audits were classified as modern.

System auditors have greater independence, thus being fully responsible for the course of the audits, while process audits are highly schematic and focused on the execution of the audit checklist. A system audit is understood here as the audit of one of the areas of the entire system, i.e., an audit of how a given unit or other organizational cell operates within the enterprise. By design, through the mutual auditing of organizational units (departments), the enterprise develops thanks to internal consultancy and benchmarking. By contrast, a process audit is defined as the audit of a single, specific operational workstation within the production or warehouse area.

The rationale behind conducting internal audits is that a given department is audited from the perspective of other departments, which, through collaboration, is intended to result in continuous improvement and mutual advisory effects. Internal auditors (approximately 15 individuals) were selected from among the employees of the analysed enterprise and were trained internally to carry out their new responsibilities. It should be noted that they did not receive additional remuneration for their auditing work.

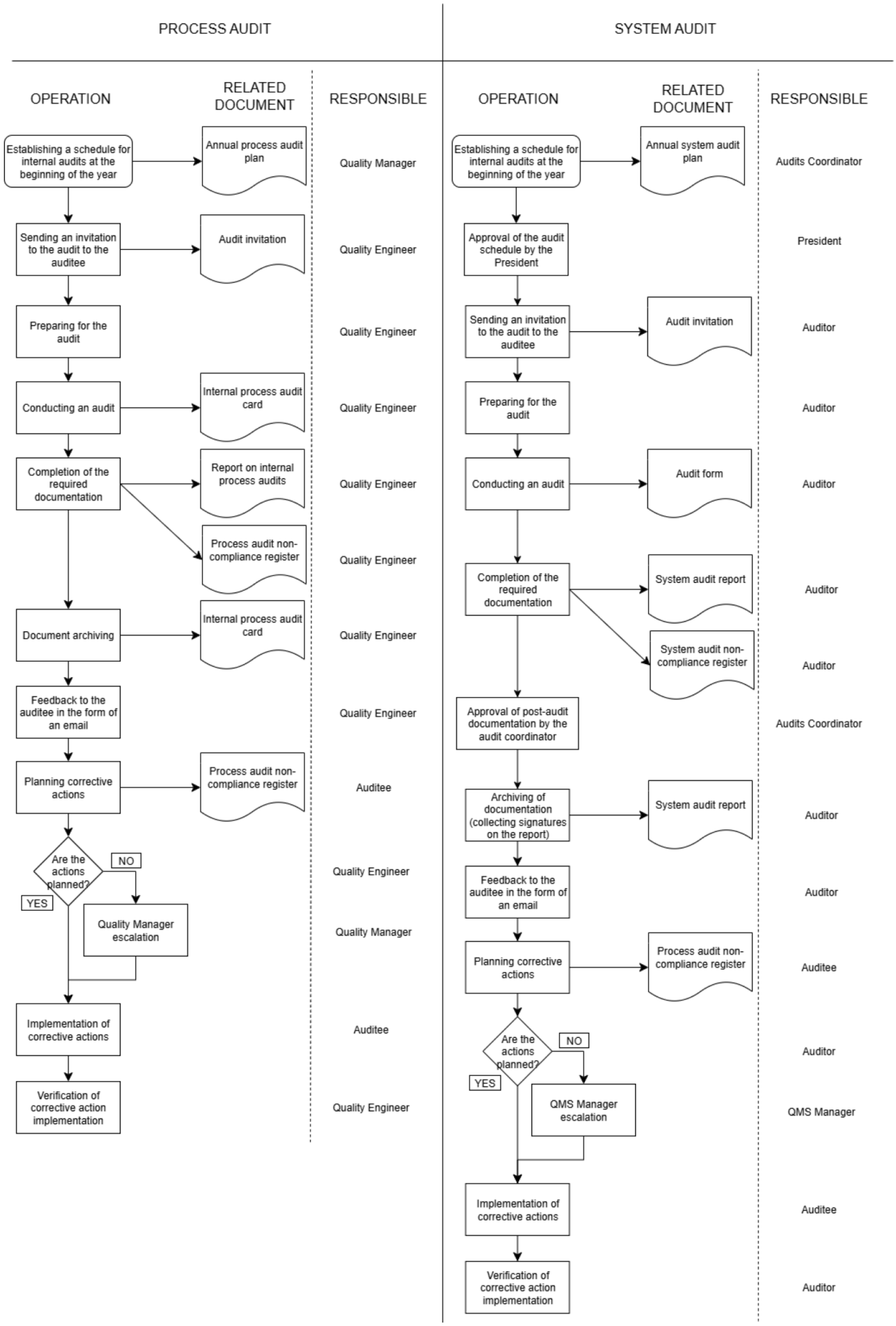

Fig. 1. Comparison of process and system audit processes implemented in the analysed enterprise

Source: own elaboration based on company documentation.

4. Research Methodology

A mixed-method approach combining quantitative and qualitative methods was applied in the study. This decision was dictated by the complexity of the research subject. To capture the full picture, it was necessary to obtain both numerical data and the subjective opinions and experiences of participants in the auditing process. Qualitative methods made it possible to identify phenomena imperceptible in statistical data and allowed for a deeper understanding of the dynamics of conducting audits from within.

To obtain the opinions of employees of the analysed enterprise regarding internal audits, an anonymous survey was carried out, in which individuals working in different positions and at various levels of the organisational hierarchy were asked about their positive and negative impressions of the audits' implementation. The author's questionnaire included questions aimed at identifying respondents':

- age,
- gender,
- position,
- awareness of the existence of audits in the enterprise,
- opinion on the purposefulness of audits in the enterprise (YES/NO),
- arguments in favour of system audits,
- arguments against system audits,
- arguments in favour of process audits,
- arguments against process audits.

The target group consisted of employees of the observed enterprise, including external workers. Data were collected using a paper-based questionnaire over the course of several days, with the aim of gathering as many completed forms as possible. In the research process, factual material was also collected—quantitative and qualitative data describing the audits conducted in the enterprise. The following data were obtained:

- delays in audit execution,
- delays in report preparation,
- delays in implementing corrective actions,
- number of opportunities for improvement (OFI),
- number of nonconformities (NC).

The process of obtaining these data involved the systematic analysis of deadlines related to the planning and execution of audit activities, as well as a detailed examination of audit documentation.

5. Results

Thanks to the favourable attitude of the company's employees, 147 correctly completed questionnaires were obtained out of approximately 200 distributed. This indicates that a significant proportion of employees in the analysed enterprise (about 75%) expressed interest in participating in the study. However, it is difficult to precisely determine the total number of employees during the research period, as external workers were also included, and their numbers fluctuated daily due to changes and rotations. The high response rate was mainly the result of using a printed survey form and the limited size of the target group, which significantly facilitated the management of the study.

Considering the survey results, respondents demonstrated a high awareness of the existence of the audit area in the analysed enterprise, as 97% of those surveyed declared that they had encountered at least one form of audit. However, the assessment of the usefulness of audits proved to be varied (Fig. 2). In the case of system audits, negative opinions prevailed, while process audits were clearly received positively. Production and warehouse employees, who most frequently participated in process audits, evaluated them particularly favourably.

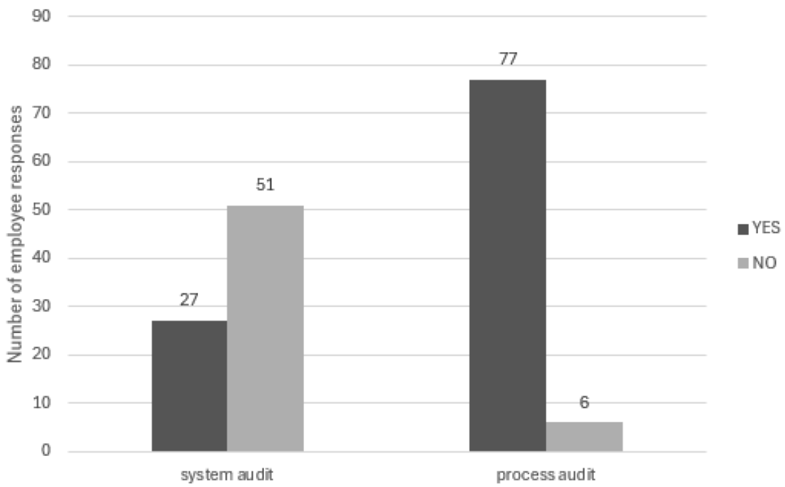

Fig. 2. Respondents' opinions on the purposefulness of audits in the enterprise

Source: own elaboration.

The positive evaluation of process audits results mainly from their practical nature, their focus on aspects directly related to the work performed, and the lighter burden on employees, as most of the actions are carried out by the auditor. An additional factor supporting positive assessments is the constant presence of the same auditor, which reduces stress and increases predictability of the process. Opinions varied depending on job position: lower-level operational employees were more favourable, while managerial staff and specialists more often expressed negative evaluations (Fig. 3), pointing to the necessity of preparing documentation, coordinating post-audit actions, and implementing corrections. In the case of system audits, critical remarks dominated, concerning excessive workload, increased pressure and stress, as well as limited impartiality resulting from the fact that all auditors came from the same enterprise. By contrast, process audits, although sometimes disrupting operational tasks, were perceived as more useful and less burdensome.

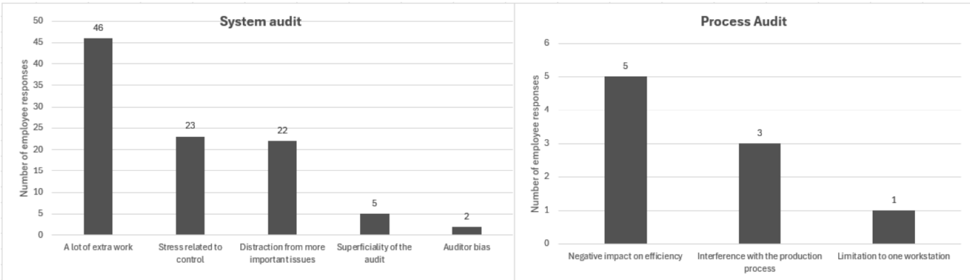

Fig. 3. Comparison of arguments against system and process audits

Source: own elaboration.

The positive aspects of system audits in the enterprise (Fig. 4) included mainly the organisation of work, better assignment of responsibilities, identification of areas requiring improvement, and facilitation of ISO compliance. Regarding process audits, employees highly valued the improvement of tool quality, monitoring of their technical condition, and updating of workstation instructions. Visual elements (e.g. shadow boards, shelf descriptions) were not considered significant, indicating that surveyed employees attached greater importance to functional rather than aesthetic aspects.

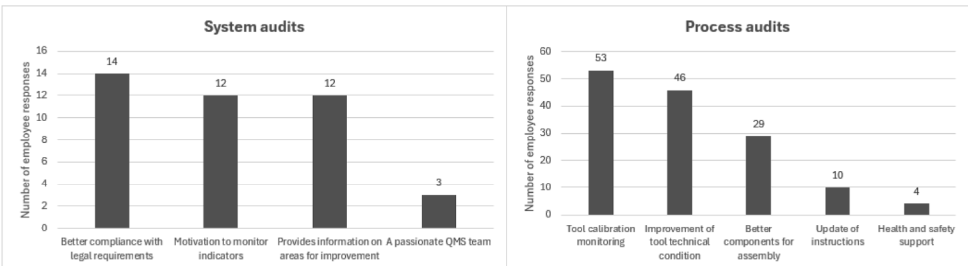

Fig. 4. Comparison of arguments supporting system and process audits

Source: own elaboration.

Referring to the factual material collected in the enterprise, the data presented in Table 1 reveal clear differences in the course and outcomes of system and process audits.

Table 1. Quantitative indicators of audits in the enterprise

Area	System	Process
Overall report quality assessment	Low	High
Average audit delay	14 working days	2 working days
Average report delay (QMS team)	4 working days	–
Average report delay (audited unit)	7 working days	0 working days
Average delay in implementing corrective actions	22 working days	4 working days
Average number of OFI (Opportunities for Improvement)	5.12	12.66
Average number of NC (Nonconformities)	1.46	4.00

Source: own elaboration.

Process audits are characterised by higher report quality assessments, shorter delays at each stage, and no postponement in report preparation. The time required to implement corrective actions is also significantly shorter (four days in process audits compared to 22 days in system audits). At the same time, process audits generate a higher number of observations and nonconformities (an average of 12.66 OFI and 4 NC) compared to system audits (5.12 OFI and 1.46 NC). This indicates greater detail and focus on real operational issues. Such results may explain why surveyed employees perceive process audits as more valuable and practical. They provide conclusions faster, and corrective actions are implemented more efficiently. On the other hand, long delays and low report quality in system audits point to insufficient organizational and personnel resources for their effective execution. These shortcomings include both documentation preparation and coordination of post-audit activities, which is reflected in the respondents' negative evaluations of system audits.

6. Conclusion

In the analysed case study, the modern audit model did not deliver the expected results; in fact, it was received much less favourably than the classical audit, contradicting the assumption that it should perform an advisory function. The main reason was its form, which proved unsuitable both for the size of the enterprise and for the available human and organizational resources. This type of audit requires a high level of organizational maturity, extensive support structures, and adequate preparation of both managerial staff and lower-level employees. In the conditions of a small, highly centralized enterprise with limited resources, these requirements turned out to be a barrier difficult to overcome.

The traditional audit model, by contrast, proved to be far more effective. It is characterised by a simpler operational concept and lower resource requirements. As a result, it was more appropriate for the specific characteristics of the observed business entity, providing a sufficient level of control and process improvement while maintaining proportionality to its operational capacities. In this context, the traditional auditing model may be considered the optimal solution for enterprises with a relatively small number of employees and a structure based on centralised management.

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Nowoczesny audyt w średnim przedsiębiorstwie branży motoryzacyjnej

Streszczenie: Celem badania jest ocena skuteczności nowoczesnego podejścia do audytu wewnętrznego w średnim przedsiębiorstwie branży motoryzacyjnej, funkcjonującym w oparciu o zintegrowany system zarządzania ISO. Obiektem badań był podmiot gospodarczy zatrudniający 150-200 osób, w którym prowadzono audyty zarówno procesowe (tradycyjne), jak i systemowe (nowoczesne). W procesie badawczym zastosowano sondaż diagnostyczno-ankietowy przeprowadzony wśród pracowników oraz analizę dokumentacji organizacyjnej i wskaźników audytowych. Poddani obserwacji pracownicy wysoko oceniali audyty procesowe, uznając je za praktyczne i mniej obciążające, podczas gdy audyty systemowe budziły zastrzeżenia związane z nadmiernym obciążeniem pracą, opóźnieniami i ograniczoną bezstronnością. Analiza danych ilościowych potwierdziła większą efektywność audytów procesowych. Wnioskiem końcowym jest stwierdzenie, że w warunkach średniego, scentralizowanego przedsiębiorstwa bardziej adekwatnym rozwiązaniem pozostaje tradycyjny model audytowania, zapewniający skuteczność i proporcjonalność do dostępnych zasobów.

Słowa kluczowe: audyt wewnętrzny, audyt procesowy, audyt systemowy, branża motoryzacyjna, analiza porównawcza

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